

LG Sandhu, CM Rekha confer degrees at GGSIPU's 18th convocation

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi Lieutenant Governor Sardar Taranjit Singh Sandhu and Chief Minister Rekha Gupta on Thursday attended the 18th convocation of Guru Gobind Singh Indraprastha University (GGSIPU), where they conferred degrees on graduating students.

A total of 26,649 degrees were awarded at the convocation, including 22,932 undergraduate, 3,582 postgraduate, 11 MPhil, 124 PhD degrees, 11 MPhils, 2,873 postgraduate, 22,455 undergraduate, and 477 MBBS degrees.

Notably, women accounted for 70 per cent of PhD recipients this year. In addition, 76 gold medals and six memorial awards were pre-

sented to meritorious students. Addressing the gathering, the Lieutenant Governor said a convocation marks not just the end of an academic journey but the beginning of thousands of new ones that contribute to nation-building.

He noted that young graduates are stepping into a world being rapidly reshaped by artificial intelligence and sustainable innovation and urged them to look beyond textbook knowledge.

Addressing the convocation, the chief minister said the university has "shown direction to the country, the world, and society". She said graduating students would not only advance their careers but also contribute ideas and vision to take India

forward. The chief minister said the ceremony reflects years of hard work, discipline and dedication by students. "Today's graduates are the real drivers of 'Viksit Bharat'. Your talent and capability will take the country to new heights on the global stage," she said, encouraging students to use their education not only for personal growth but also for the larger good of society.

Among those present were Vice-Chancellor Prof. (Dr) Mahesh Verma and Prof. Yogesh Singh, Vice-Chancellor of the University of Delhi, along with students, parents, faculty members and other dignitaries.

The Lieutenant Governor emphasised that education must equip students with



adaptability, critical thinking and the courage to innovate. Referring to the Prime Minister's vision of Viksit Bharat @2047, he said the

country needs problem-solvers who can tackle complex challenges in areas such as urban development, public health and digital

governance. Invoking the teachings of Guru Gobind Singh, he described knowledge as a powerful instrument of

justice and service and urged students to treat their education as a responsibility towards society and the nation. He expressed confidence that the future of Delhi and India is in safe hands, with young people capable of driving meaningful change.

The Chief Minister also praised the university's work in emerging fields such as AI, robotics, data science and design innovation.

Highlighting the Atal Incubation Centre, she said the university has supported over 170 startups, helping young people move from being job seekers to job creators.

Outlining the government's priorities, she said Delhi's education budget has risen to ₹19,326 crore this year. "Our

aim is not just to make schools smarter but to ensure world-class facilities in higher education as well," she said, adding that more than 2,200 students are being provided free coaching for competitive exams such as JEE, NEET and CLAT. Mahesh Verma, GGSIPU vice-chancellor, presented the university report and said a total of 26,649 degrees were conferred, including 124 PhDs, 11 MPhils, 2,873 postgraduate, 22,455 undergraduate, and 477 MBBS degrees.

Delhi Education Minister Ashish Sood, who was scheduled to attend, could not make it due to personal commitments, officials said. He congratulated the graduating students through a video message.

DDA carries out anti-encroachment drive, demolishes 23 farmhouses in Sainik Farm

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

In a major crackdown, the Delhi Development Authority (DDA) on Thursday carried out an anti-encroachment drive, demolishing 23 farmhouses in the affluent Sainik Farm area of south Delhi.



It stated that approximately 3 acres of land, involving 7 farmhouses, located in portions of Khasra Nos. 580 (1150 sq. yd.), 588, 589, and 595, could not be cleared due to active judicial stay orders issued by the High Court.

According to the Resident Welfare Association, the drive targeted two residential plots located on Western Avenue.

"This is a completely illegal action. They came around 5 am and carried out the drive despite us having a stay order from the court. This is a private land, and DDA does not have a clear demarcation of the Khasra number of this plot," Hardeep Singh Bhalla, president of the Western Avenue Residents' Welfare Association (WARWA), alleged.

While the government is talking about regularising unauthorised colonies, the DDA is taking action against the residents in the area,

Bhalla said. A police officer said that a government agency had sought the deployment of personnel for the demolition drive.

"An adequate police force was provided to maintain law and order. No protest has been so far," the officer said.

Barring 69 affluent colonies, including Sainik Farm, the Centre on Tuesday announced a new policy to regularise 1,521 unauthorised colonies based on "as is where is" eligibility criteria, subject to approvals from Delhi Government agencies.

The entire process of in-situ regularisation will be online, and it will involve the revenue department and the Municipal Corporation of Delhi.

Earlier, the DDA used to issue conveyance deeds (for government land) or authorisation slips (for private land) to properties in these colonies.

Assembly sets July 31 deadline on health audit action

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi Assembly has directed all concerned departments to act on key findings of the Comptroller and Auditor General's (CAG) health audit and submit a detailed compliance report by July 31, 2026, in a push to enforce accountability in the public healthcare system.

The directive follows the adoption of the Public Accounts Committee's First Report, which examined public health infrastructure and management of health services for the year ending March 31, 2022.

Officials said departments have been asked to submit an Action Taken Report indi-

cating the status of implementation as of June 30, 2026. The move is aimed at ensuring that audit observations translate into measurable administrative action within a fixed timeline.

The Assembly Secretariat has also written to the Health Minister of the Delhi Government and the Secretary of the Health and Family Welfare Department, seeking a time-bound response to the committee's recommendations.

Speaker Vijender Gupta said strengthening public hospitals and expanding healthcare coverage are essential for building a resilient system.

He stressed that the focus must remain on improving



infrastructure, extending services, and ensuring equitable access to quality care.

The report reviewed multiple aspects of the healthcare system, including infrastructure gaps, service delivery mechanisms, and overall management of health services. Departments have been directed to clearly

outline progress made on each recommendation and specify timelines for pending work.

Officials said the requirement to submit a structured action taken report marks the beginning of a formal follow-up mechanism within the Assembly. The aim is to ensure that policy observa-

tions are backed by implementation on the ground.

Gupta said efficient delivery of health services is central to good governance and remains a key responsibility of the state.

He noted that improvements in healthcare must go beyond infrastructure and focus on outcomes that affect citizens directly. He highlighted the need to strengthen institutional systems by investing in infrastructure, ensuring the availability of trained medical professionals, and improving access to services across all sections of society.

The Speaker also underlined the importance of accountability in public health administration.

Govt will host programmes to pay tribute to BR Ambedkar: Minister

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi Government will host a series of programmes from April 10-14 to pay tribute to Bharat Ratna Bhimrao Ambedkar to mark his 136th birth anniversary, Minister for Social Welfare and SC/ST/OBC Welfare Ravinder Indraj Singh said on Thursday.

He invited all citizens to participate, stating that this year Baba Saheb's birth anniversary will be celebrated in Delhi in a grand and enthusiastic manner. A

major highlight will be the "Bhim Jyoti Utsav" to be organised near India Gate, in the Kasturba Gandhi Marg area, where rich literature related to Baba Saheb and important aspects of his life will be displayed through a special gallery.

He informed that visitors will get an opportunity to explore and understand various aspects of Baba Saheb's life, thoughts and struggles. In addition, several folk-cultural programmes, performances and diverse activities will be organised to take his ideas to the masses.



He also informed that under "Bhim Jyoti Utsav - 2026", large-scale programmes will be organised

across various locations in the capital, ensuring participation from all sections of society. This event is not

just a celebration but a powerful campaign to spread Baba Saheb's thoughts, the core values of the Constitution and the message of social harmony.

The programme series will include floral tributes, public participation activities, the "Constitution Fest", exhibitions, awareness campaigns, cultural performances, walkathons, interactive sessions, workshops, quiz competitions and art exhibitions. These activities aim to educate youth and students about the Constitution, their rights and duties.

HIMALAYA FOOD INTERNATIONAL LIMITED
CIN: L70102DL1992PLC047399
Registered Address: 118, 1st Floor, 12 Gagandeep Building Rajendra Place, Central Delhi, New Delhi, 110008, India | **Phone no.** +91-1145108609
E-mail: cs@himalayainternational.com | **website:** <https://himalayafoodcompany.com/>

NOTICE OF THE EXTRA-ORDINARY GENERAL MEETING AND E-VOTING INFORMATION
NOTICE is hereby given that the Extra-Ordinary General Meeting ("EGM") of the members of Himalaya Food International Limited ("the Company") will be held on Saturday, May 02nd, 2026 at 03:00 P.M. (IST), through video conferencing ("VC"), other audio-visual means ("OAVM") in compliance with the applicable circulars, issued by the Ministry of Corporate Affairs and Securities and Exchange Board of India. The deemed venue for the EGM shall be the registered office of the Company.
The Notice setting out the business to be transacted during the EGM has been sent through email to the members whose email IDs are registered with the Registrar and Share Transfer Agent ("RTA")/ Depository Participants ("DPs"). The Notice of the EGM is available on the website of the Company <https://himalayafoodcompany.com/> website of stock exchange i.e. BSE Limited at www.bseindia.com and agency providing the platform for e voting i.e. CDSL at <https://www.evotingindia.com/>.
Instructions for remote e-voting and e-voting during the EGM
In accordance with the provisions of Section 108 and other applicable provisions, if any, of the Companies Act, 2013 read with Rule 20 of the Companies (Management and Administration Rules), 2014 and Regulation 44 of the Listing Regulations, the Company is pleased to provide the facility of remote e-voting to the shareholders, to exercise their right to vote on the resolutions proposed to be passed at the EGM. The facility of casting votes by the members using an electronic voting system and for participating in the EGM through VC/OAVM facility along with e-voting during the EGM will be provided by Central Depository Services (India) Limited ("CDSL").
Manner of registering/updating e-mail addresses
(a) **For the members holding shares in physical mode:** Please send duly completed Form ISR-1 along with the requisite documents to the Registrar & Share Transfer Agent of the Company i.e. M/s. BEETAL Financial & Computer Services (P) Ltd. at 3rd Floor, BEETAL House, 99, Behind Local Shopping Centre, Madangir Village, Madangir, New Delhi, Delhi 110062. The Form ISR-1 is available on the website of the Company and can be accessed at <https://himalayafoodcompany.com/pages/forms-for-investors>.
(b) **For the members holding shares in demat mode:** Please register/update your email addresses and/or bank account details with your Depository Participant ("DP").
All members may please note the following:
a) Only those members whose name appears in the Register of Members/ List of Beneficial Owners as on Saturday, April 25th, 2026 being the cut-off date, shall be entitled to avail the facility of remote e-voting or e-voting during the EGM. The voting rights of the members shall be in proportion to their share in the paid-up equity share capital of the Company as on the cut-off date.
b) The remote e-voting period commences on Wednesday, 29th April 2026 (9:00 A.M.) and ends on Friday, 01st May 2026 (5:00 P.M.). Voting through remote e-voting shall be disabled by CDSL thereafter.
c) In addition, the facility for voting through e-voting system shall also be made available during the EGM. Members attending the EGM who have not cast their vote by remote e-voting will be eligible to cast their vote through e-voting during the EGM. Members who have cast their votes by remote e-voting prior to the EGM may participate in the EGM but shall not be eligible to cast their votes again.
d) Once the vote on a resolution is cast by the members, the members will not be allowed to modify it subsequently or cast the vote again.
e) The manner of remote e-voting for members holding shares in dematerialized (demat) mode and physical mode as well as for the members who have not registered their email IDs is provided in the notice of EGM.
f) Any person, who becomes the member of the Company after dispatch of the notice of EGM and holding shares as on the cut-off date, may obtain the user id and password by sending an email request as mentioned in the notice of EGM at cs@himalayainternational.com.
g) The Board of Directors has appointed Mr. Himanshu Bhatia (CP No: 22555) sole proprietor of M/s. Himanshu and Co., Practicing Company Secretary as the Scrutinizer for providing facility to the members of the Company to scrutinize the voting and remote e-voting process in a fair and transparent manner.
If you have any queries or issues regarding attending EGM & e-Voting from the CDSL e-Voting system, you can write an email to helpdesk.evoting@cdslindia.com or contact at toll free no. 1800 22 55 33.
All grievances connected with the facility for voting by electronic means may be addressed to (CDSL) Central Depository Services (India) Limited, A Wing, 25th Floor, Marathon Futurex, Matatal Mill Compounds, M N Joshi Marg, Lower Panel (East), Mumbai - 400013 or send an email to helpdesk.evoting@cdslindia.com or call toll free no. 1800 22 55 33.
For any other query or information with respect to the EGM of the Company, members may please write to the Company Secretary at cs@himalayainternational.com.
For and on behalf of the Board of Directors
Himalaya Food International Limited
Sd/-
Megha Saini
(Company Secretary)
Mem. No.: 51243
Address: D-56, 2nd Floor Naharpur Sector-7 Rohini Delhi 110085 India

Can Fin Homes Ltd
WANTED OFFICE PREMISES
Can Fin Homes Limited a Housing Finance Company require space of 700-1000 sq.ft in Ground Floor / First/ Second Floor in a good locality on lease for 5 to 10 years at the following location:

Sl. No.	Location	Contact Person & Designation	Contact No. Mob. & Landline
1.	Balbahgarh, Faridabad (Haryana)	S.P. Srivastava, Vice President	0129-2972269/9606084363

Interested Premises Owners may send their offers in a closed envelope to Address: **Can Fin Homes Ltd., Zonal office-North, BLG Tower, Nit-5, Faridabad-121001** as per our format in our website www.canfinhomes.com on or before 18th April, 2026. Premises should be ready for occupation with all facilities/ amenities. Offers from the brokers /intermediaries will not be entertained. Can Fin Homes Ltd. reserves the right to reject any or all the offers without assigning any reason whatsoever. Canvassing in any form will disqualify the offer. No brokerage will be paid.
Place: Faridabad
Date: 10.04.2026
Sd/-
Branch In-charge

The Pioneer Classified
CHANGE OF NAME
I, MADAN LAL SAINI s/o VIJENDER SINGH r/o House No. 584, Mundka Village, Nangloi, Delhi-110041 declare that name of mine has been wrongly written as MADAN LAL in my minor son namely SIKANDAR aged 17 years in his educational certificates. That the actual name of mine is MADAN LAL SAINI
PD(826)C
I, Parmila Devi, Mother of No.14652466L Hav Armt Tech (FD) Sunil Gavaskar, R/o- Vill-Kiranpur, PO- Pararia, Teh-Budana, Dist- Banka, Bihar, have changed my name from Parmila Devi To Pramila Devi, Vide Affidavit Dated 09/04/2026 Before Notary Public Delhi.
PD(827)C
I, Susama Devi, W/o JC-859423M Nb/Sub Manoj Kumar, R/o- Vill-Jaor Ka Purva, PO- Pahari, Teh-Lalgaonj, Dist- Raibareilly, U.P.- 229201, have changed my name from Susama Devi to Sushma Devi, vide affidavit dated 09/04/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.
PD(828)C
I, Kumari Savita Devi, W/o No.14683251N Hav Rajesh Kumar Yadav, R/o- Maughalsarai, Alinagar, Bichari, Chandauli, U.P.- 232101, have changed my name from Kumari Savita Devi to Savita Devi, vide affidavit dated 09/04/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.
PD(829)C
PD(824)C
I, Rajesh, Mother of No.16021051K L/Hav Gaurav Kumar, R/o- Vill&PO- Garhi Noabad, Teh-Budana, Dist-Muzaffarnagar, U.P. - 251309, have changed my name from Rajesh Devi to Rajesh, vide affidavit dated 23/03/2026 before Notary Public U.P.
PD(825)C

OFFICE OF MUNICIPAL CORPORATION KORBA
e-Procurement Tender Notice
Main Portal: <http://eproc.cgstate.gov.in> KORBA
NIT No:- 332/2026 Dated:-07.04.2026

SN	System Tender No.	Name of Work/Description of Work	Probable Amount of Contract
1	188571 (2nd Call)	Construction for Gaurav Path Four lane B.T. Road From CSEB Chowk to Jain Chowk to ITI Chowk to Kosabadi Chowk in Korba (C.G.)	Rs. 3356.30 Lakh

The details can be viewed directly from the Government of Chhattisgarh **<http://eproc.cgstate.gov.in>** from 07.04.2026 at 15.30 Hours. (IST) onwards.
Sd/- Commissioner
Municipal Corporation Korba (C.G.)

AXIS BANK LTD.
Corporate Office: Axis House, Block-B, Bombay Dyeing Mills Compound, Pandurang Budhkar Marg, Worli, Mumbai-400025, Registered Office: Trishul, 3rd floor, opposite Samartheashwar Temple, Law garden, Ellisbridge, Ahmedabad-380006. Also at: Axis Bank Ltd. Himalaya House, Upper Ground Floor & First Floor, KG Marg, Connaught Place, New Delhi-110001
POSSESSION NOTICE UNDER SARFAESI ACT 2002
Whereas The undersigned being the Authorized Officer of Axis Bank Ltd. under the Securitisation, Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002 and in exercise of the powers conferred under section 13 (12) read with Rule 9 of the Security Interest (Enforcement) rules 2002, issued demand notice upon the Borrower(s)/ Co-Borrower(s)/ Guarantor(s)/ Mortgagee(s) mentioned below, to repay the amount mentioned in the notice within 60 days from the date of receipt of the said notice.
The Borrower(s)/ Co-Borrower(s)/ Guarantor(s)/ Mortgagee(s) having failed to repay the amount, notice is hereby given to the Borrower(s)/ Co-Borrower(s)/ Guarantor(s)/ Mortgagee(s) and the public in general that the undersigned has taken possession of the property described herein below in exercise of powers conferred on him/ her under Section 13(4) of the said Act read with Rule 8 of the said rules on the below-mentioned dates:
The Borrower(s)/ Co-Borrower(s)/ Guarantor(s)/ Mortgagee(s) in particular and the public in general are hereby cautioned not to deal with the property and any dealings with the property will be subject to the charge of Axis Bank Ltd.
The Borrower(s)/ Co-Borrower(s)/ Guarantor(s)/ Mortgagee(s) attentions is invited to provisions of sub-section (8) of section 13 of the Act, in respect of time available, to redeem the secured assets.

Sl. No.	Name Of Borrower / Co-Borrower	Date Of Demand Notice	Date of Possession	Amount in Demand Notice (Rs.)
1	Mr. Ankit Kapoor S/o. Mr. Ashok Kapoor R/o. Bg-2/30, R. Paschim Vihar, Sec. Dist-West Delhi Delhi-110063 Also At:- Mr. Ankit Kapoor Frozen Food Diffie Stockit 2, B-201, R-G, City Centre, Plot No-4 DDA Community Centre, Motia Khan Paharganj, North Delhi, New Delhi-110055 Also At:- Mr. Ankit Kapoor S/O, Mr. Ashok Kapoor Lig Flat No- 62/A, Ground Floor, Pocket Bg-5, Paschim Vihar, New Delhi-110055	06-Dec-2025	07-Apr-2026	Rs. 51,33,245/- Rupees Fifty One Lakh Thirty Three Thousand Two Hundred Forty Five Only
2	Mr. Vishvendra Singh R/o. 91, National Park Lajpat Nagar-IV, Country Delhi-110024 2. Mrs. Archana Singh R/o. 91, National Park Lajpat Nagar-IV, Country Delhi-110024 Also At:- Mrs. Archana Singh Century Pulp And Paper B/54-A, 4th Floor, The Corethum A-41 Sec-62, Noida, Uttar Pradesh- 201301 3. Mrs. Sushila Rani R/o. 91, National Park Lajpat Nagar-IV, New Delhi-110024	19-Dec-2025	07-Apr-2026	Rs. 6,08,58,474/- (Rupees Six Core Eight Lakh Fifty Eight Thousand Four Hundred Seventy Four Only)

DETAILS OF PROPERTIES:- DDA Built Up Free Hold Lig Bearing No. 62-A, On Ground Floor, Situated At Pocket Bg-5, Paschim Vihar, New Delhi-110063 And Bouded As Under:- East - As Per Site Plan West - As Per Site Plan North - As Per Title Deed, West - As Per Title Deed
The above-mentioned Borrower(s)/ Co-Borrower(s)/ Guarantor(s)/ Mortgagee(s) are hereby given a 30 days' Notice to repay the amount, else the mortgaged properties will be sold on the expiry of 30 days' from the date of publication of this Notice, as per the provisions under the Rules 8 and 9 of Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules 2002.
Dated: 10.04.2026, Place: NOIDA
Sd/-, Authorized Officer, Axis Bank Ltd.

PUBLIC NOTICE
I Mr. Sushil Kumar Dua, S/o Mr. Chaman Lal Dua, R/o B-6/9 Mianwali Nagar, Rohtak Road, Paschim Vihar, Sundar Vihar West Delhi 110087 have purchased a property bearing No LM/624 in Eco Citi Project address Sec:137 Noida UP 201301, I have lost the original, allotment letter of the above said property, I have request M/s SuperTech Limited, to issue the duplicate allotment letter of the said property, if anybody or financial institutions have objection, helshme may contact to M/s Supertech limited office Plot no-C-2, Sector 96, Noida 201303 UP, Within Ten Day.
Public Notice
This is to inform the general public that Mrs. Manju Devi is the Owner of the land area measuring 100 sq. yards, i.e. 83.61 sq. meters, out of Kharsa no. 218 min, 219 min, 220 min, 221 min, 222 min & 223 min situated at village Salapur Khadar, Pargana & Tehsil Dadri, Distt. Gautam Budh Nagar, U.P. through 2 Sale Deed i.e. Sale Deed dated 30.11.2023 regd. as doc. no. 10689 executed by Mr. Brahm Pal as GPA of Fateh Singh in favour of Mrs. Manju Devi is in the process of mortgaging the said property at Sale Deed dated 01.08.2025 regd. as doc. no. 10691 executed by Mr. Pankaj Kumar in favour of Mrs. Manju Devi in respect of Land area measuring 60 sq. yards, i.e. 41.80 sq. meters, out of Kharsa no. 218 min, 219 min, 220 min, 221 min, 222 min & 223 min. Mrs. Manju Devi intends to transfer the ownership of above said property by way of Sale Deed to Mr. Rahul Aggarwal. Subsequently, Mr. Rahul Aggarwal is in the process of mortgaging the said property with Aditya Birla Housing Finance Limited. Any objections or concerns regarding this transaction should be raised within a period of 7 days from the date of this public notice. Any objections submitted after the completion of this 7-days period will not be considered binding with respect to the said property or the interests of our client.
If anyone wishes to raise an objection, please do so within the stipulated 7-days period by contacting Law Veritas: North (Advocates & Legal Consultants) at Office No. 11, 1st Floor, E Block, No. 4-A/6A, Sector-16, Noida, Uttar Pradesh-201301; Landline(s): +9101240499711, e-mail: accounts@lvnorth.in

THE COURT OF CIVIL JUDGE (SENIOR DIVISION) PATNA
Execution No. 219/2023
Rizwanullah Khan Decree Holder
Blue Coast Infrastructure Development Pvt. Ltd. Judgment debtor
NOTICE
Mr. Manoj Sharma, Authorized Signatory Blue Coast Infrastructure Development Pvt. Ltd., 415-417, Antriksh Bhavan, 22 K. G. Marg, New Delhi-110001
It is hereby notified to you through this publication notice that despite receiving the summons via Nazarat and registered post, you have not appeared in the said case. As such, you are hereby informed that to appear in this case on the date. 18/04/26at 10:30 AM by self or advocate otherwise, an ex parte proceeding will be done against you.
Issued today on 4/04/26. with my signature and seal.
CIVIL JUDGE (SENIOR DIVISION) Patna

Man brutally stabbed inside public toilet in Ashok Vihar area

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

An alleged road rage incident took a fatal turn when a 27-year-old factory worker was chased down by assailants and stabbed multiple times inside a public toilet in north-west Delhi's Ashok Vihar area, police said on Thursday.

According to police, the incident took place on Wednesday night, when witnesses saw the victim, Santosh Kumar, running into a public toilet in a desperate bid to save his life, with his attackers hot on his heels.

"A PCR call was received at 6:23 pm on April 8 regarding a man being stabbed inside the compound of a Sulabh Sauchalaya located at the fish market in Wazirpur Industrial Area," a senior police officer said.

A police team rushed to the spot and found the victim lying in a pool of blood inside the toilet premises. The victim, originally from Nepal, was residing in the Macchi Market area, the official said.

Preliminary inquiry revealed that the incident stemmed from an altercation

between the victim and a motorcycle rider. The verbal spat soon escalated into a physical scuffle, during which the accused, along with an associate, allegedly attacked Santosh with a knife.

Police sources said in a desperate attempt to save himself, the injured victim ran towards the nearby public toilet and tried to latch the door from inside.

Eyewitness accounts suggest he tried to take refuge inside the public toilet and shut the door to prevent his attackers from entering. However, he was



chased down, overpowered, and stabbed multiple times.

Santosh collapsed on the spot, where he later succumbed to his injuries,

police said.

A case under sections 103(1) (murder) and 3(5) (common intentions) was registered at Ashok Vihar police station, and an investigation was taken up.

During the probe, police arrested one accused identified as Tanish (19), a resident of CSA Colony in the Macchi Market area, and apprehended a juvenile allegedly involved in the incident. Police said the motorcycle used by the accused, which they had abandoned while fleeing after the attack, was recovered near the crime scene.

Family members and acquaintances of the deceased expressed shock over the killing. Santosh's

uncle, who reached the spot after being informed, recounted the scene.

"When I came here, I saw him lying on the floor, dead. I noticed that he had been stabbed twice. I am not aware of what exactly happened. He was just 27 years old and used to work in a steel company with me. I don't know how many people were involved in the attack. We are from Nepal, and I have been working here for 15 years. I think he was stabbed outside and later came inside the toilet to save himself. There was a

bike outside, which I think belonged to the attackers," he said.

Police said the motive behind the crime appears to be road rage — a sudden and heated altercation on the road that spiralled into a violent assault resulting in the victim's death.

Efforts are underway to identify and apprehend any other persons involved in the attack. Police teams are analysing CCTV footage from the surrounding area and examining local witnesses to piece together the sequence of events.

Govt transfers 33 IAS, DANICS cadre officers

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

In a bureaucratic reshuffle, the Delhi Government has transferred 33 IAS and DANICS cadre officers, giving charge of additional chief secretary power and administrative reform to Prashant Goyal. The reshuffle also involved an administrative shake-up, with transfers and postings involving Sub-Divisional Magistrates (SDMs), Additional District Magistrates (ADMs) and District Magistrates (DMs) across districts.

IAS officer Prashant Goyal will continue as Additional Chief Secretary of the Food and Civil Supplies Department. He has also been given additional charge of several key responsibilities, including the roles of Chairman and Managing Director of Delhi Financial Corporation and Delhi State Civil Supplies Corporation, as well as Additional Chief Secretary roles in Administrative Reforms and Power.

Among the senior-most changes, IAS officer Dr G



Narendra Kumar of the AGMUT cadre has been appointed as Financial Commissioner. He was previously awaiting posting. The position is one of the top administrative roles in the Delhi government.

In another key posting, IAS officer Soumya Saurabh, currently serving as Deputy Commissioner of North West district, will continue in the same role and has been given additional charge as Special Secretary in the Industries Department. IAS officer Sonika Singh, who was serving as Special Secretary and Private Secretary to the Lieutenant Governor, has been posted as Commissioner in the Delhi Development Authority.

Several DANICS officers have also been reassigned as part of the reshuffle.

Navlendra Kumar Singh has been appointed as Additional Commissioner in the Goods and Services Tax department, while Harshit Jain has been posted as Joint Secretary in the Legislative Assembly Secretariat. Jain was earlier handling responsibilities related to preparations for Census 2027.

Mangal Sain, who was awaiting posting, has been appointed as Superintendent in Central Jail. Om Prakash Saini has been posted as Deputy Secretary in the Delhi Subordinate Services Selection Board. Vinay Kumar Tripathi has been posted as Deputy Secretary in the Urban Development Department. Amit Kumar has been appointed as Deputy Secretary in the State Election Commission. Vijay Singh has been assigned the role of Sub Divisional Magistrate in Badli.

Other appointments include Manoj Kumar as Assistant Director in the Directorate of Vigilance, Bhoop Singh as Deputy Director in the Delhi Agricultural Marketing Board, and Mukesh Kumar as Assistant Commissioner in

the Food and Supplies Department.

Ashish Shokeen and Ashwini Kumar have also been appointed as Assistant Commissioners in the Food and Supplies and Trade and Taxes departments, respectively. Daljeet Kumar has been posted as Assistant Commissioner in the Trade and Taxes Department. Suresh Kumar has been appointed as Assistant Registrar in the Cooperative Department. Shaurya Vir Singh has been posted as Deputy Secretary in the Administrative Control Department.

Further postings include Lalvarmoy in the College of Arts, Shashi Kumar as Deputy Secretary in the Women and Child Development Department, and Parveen Bhargava as Deputy Secretary in the Finance Department. Shyam Prakash will serve as Deputy Secretary in the General Administration Department, while Naveen Kumar Verma has been posted as Deputy Secretary in the office of the Minister handling law, labour, and related portfolios.

June 30 deadline set to tackle waterlogging

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

With the monsoon still weeks away, the Delhi Government has set a firm June 30 deadline to complete drain desilting across the city, as Chief Minister Rekha Gupta pushed for coordinated action to prevent the annual crisis of waterlogging.

Chairing a high-level review meeting at the Secretariat, the Chief Minister directed all departments to finish cleaning drains on time and ensure that vulnerable areas are prepared in advance. She made it clear that delays or negligence would not be accepted.

The Chief Minister said that managing waterlogging requires joint responsibility across agencies. She stressed that fragmented efforts and poor coordination in the past have worsened the situation on the ground.

Senior officials, including Chief Secretary Rajeev Verma and representatives from PWD, MCD, DMRC, DDA, and the Delhi Cantonment Board, attended the meeting. Departments



presented detailed plans on desilting, repair of drains, and other flood prevention measures.

The Chief Minister underlined that silt removed from drains must be properly transported to designated sites. She said blocked drains and uncollected silt often lead to overflow during heavy rain, causing water to spill onto roads and disrupt daily life.

She also flagged the issue of garbage clogging drain inlets in markets and residential areas. According to officials, such blockages are a major reason behind water accumulation at intersections and key stretches during rainfall.

Highlighting a successful intervention, the Chief Minister cited Minto Road as a model. The area, once known for severe flooding, did not face waterlogging last monsoon. The Chief Minister attributed this improvement to continuous monitoring and timely action by officials. She directed departments to replicate similar practices across other flood-prone areas. The focus, she said, should be on sustained efforts rather than temporary fixes.

Taking a firm stand on accountability, the Chief Minister warned against blame shifting among departments. She said any instance of agencies passing responsi-

bility would invite strict action. Officials have been asked to work in close coordination and respond collectively during emergencies.

The Chief Minister also pushed for the use of modern machinery to tackle waterlogging more effectively. While some civic bodies have already deployed equipment, she asked others to adopt similar measures.

Officials were instructed to identify vulnerable points in advance and ensure that systems are in place to quickly drain out water during heavy rain. The Chief Minister said that relying only on traditional methods would not be enough to manage the scale of the problem.

She also stressed the importance of field-level monitoring during the monsoon. Engineers and ground staff have been asked to remain alert and maintain constant communication with senior officials.

The Chief Minister said she will personally conduct field visits during the rainy season to assess the situation and review preparedness.

113 held in massive cyber fraud crackdown in city

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi Police have arrested 113 accused across 57 cases under a special operation that exposed a web of interstate and transnational financial scams.

The operation, code-named Cy Hawk 04, was carried out by the Cyber Police Station of the South West District. Investigators linked 303 complaints from the national cybercrime portal to mule bank accounts and mobile networks used by fraudsters. The total fraud amount traced in these complaints is estimated at over ₹22 crore.

Deputy Commissioner of Police, South West District, Amit Goel, said the operation dealt a major blow to organised cyber crime networks. He said the arrests and recoveries have weakened multiple fraud modules and helped establish strong investigative linkages across cases.



He added that further action is expected as the probe expands.

Police said ₹17 lakh has been secured in beneficiary accounts through timely intervention. During the raids, teams recovered ₹47.79 lakh in cash, a luxury Mercedes S Class car, six laptops, 85 mobile phones, 11 passbooks, 42 debit cards, 135 SIM cards, a WiFi router, and a PAN card.

As part of the drive, 488 individuals were rounded up for questioning and verification. Police also issued 164 legal notices to individuals linked to the financial

trail of these crimes. In addition, 23 new cases have been registered against identified cyber fraudsters. Officials said the operation involved detailed analysis of data, surveillance, and coordinated raids across multiple locations. It was conducted under the supervision of senior officers in the South West District.

One of the major breakthroughs came in a case involving a syndicate that targeted non-resident Indians through fake air ticket bookings. Four accused were arrested in this case.

DDA to organise cultural event at Mehrauli Archaeological Park

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi Development Authority (DDA) is planning to organise a mega cultural event at Mehrauli Archaeological Park, featuring performances by artists from across the country, officials said on Thursday.

The multi-state event, themed around Baisakhi, is expected to host around 400 guests, who will be served a wide variety of festive snacks amid music and other festivities. The final date of the event is yet to be finalised.

Baisakhi is a harvest festival celebrated in north India, mainly Punjab, around April 14.

The event at Mehrauli Archaeological Park is part of a broader initiative of the land-owning agency to create public spaces that not only reflect Delhi's identity but also actively bring people together through shared experiences.

Nearly 100 artists, around 15 from each participating state, will perform at the venue. Assam, West Bengal, Odisha,

Punjab, Gujarat, Tamil Nadu and Kerala are the states that are participating in the event.

According to the plan, water-proof tents, vanity vans, portable toilets, floodlights, and other arrangements are being made for the multi-state event.

Earlier this year, DDA hosted an event at 'Baansera' park near Sarai Kale Khan, the authority also plans to appoint an event management company to curate, manage and execute a comprehensive annual calendar of events at designated locations in Delhi.

Food will play a central role in the celebration, with a diverse spread of regional dishes planned. From eastern India, offerings will include jhol momos with sesame gravy, Kolkata paneer kathi roll, beetroot chop and jhalmuri.

The assortment of snacks would also include Gujarati Dabeli, Khandvi Rolls and Khaman Dhokla, from Punjab Pindi Dahi Bhalla, Bhuttayan di Tikki (Corn Fritters) and Tille Wali Kulfi among others.

Mehendi visit turns into theft, two arrested in Sultanpuri case

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

What began as a routine visit by a familiar face ended in betrayal, as a woman allegedly used a pretext of applying mehendi to gain access to a house in Sultanpuri and orchestrate a theft of cash and jewellery worth several lakhs.

Delhi Police have arrested two accused, including a woman believed to be known to the complainant, in connection with the case. A significant portion of the stolen property has been recovered.

Deputy Commissioner of Police, Outer District, Vikram Singh, said the case was cracked through swift investigation and local intelligence. He said the team acted promptly after the complaint and managed to trace the accused within days. He added that further efforts are underway to recover the remaining stolen items and identify any other



persons involved.

The case was registered on April 4 at Police Station Sultanpuri after the complainant reported a theft at her residence between 1 pm and 5 pm. According to the complaint, an unknown person entered the locked house and stole cash and jewellery. The total stolen amount included about Rs 3.2 lakh in cash, along with multiple gold items such as necklace sets, rings, a chain, and anklets.

Given the seriousness of the case, a police team was formed. The team began examining all possible leads. Investigators analysed CCTV footage from the area. One clip showed a man accompanied by a woman dressed

in a burkha carrying a bag near the location. This became a key lead in the case. At the same time, the police developed local intelligence to track suspicious activity.

On April 7, the police received specific information that a man was trying to sell jewellery in the E Block area under suspicious circumstances. Acting on the tip-off, the police conducted a raid and apprehended a suspect identified as Rajinder, a 22-year-old resident of Sultanpuri.

During questioning, Rajinder admitted his role in the theft. He told police that he had acted under the guidance of his aunt, who is the female co-accused in the case. He also revealed that the stolen cash and jewellery had been hidden at his residence.

Based on his disclosure, the police recovered cash amounting to ₹1,92,500 along with several jewellery items from his house.

Kejriwal can't seek judge's recusal for attending legal seminar by ABAP, CBI argues in HC

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Former chief minister Arvind Kejriwal and other discharged accused in the liquor policy case cannot seek the recusal of Justice Swarana Kanta Sharma merely because she attended a "legal seminar" by the Akhil Bharatiya Adhivakta Parishad (ABAP), as it does not demonstrate any ideological association, the CBI has told the Delhi High Court.

In a reply filed to applications by the AAP leader and others seeking the judge's recusal from hearing the Central Bureau of Investigation's (CBI) challenge to the trial court's discharge order, the agency highlighted that several sitting Supreme Court judges, including Chief Justice of India Surya Kant, and high court judges have attended functions by the RSS-affiliated



ed confederation of lawyers, and if their plea is accepted, all of them would have to recuse from hearing any case involving politically exposed persons as accused.

The CBI asserted that making "unscrupulous" and "sweeping" allegations of bias over attending legal seminars, which had no political topic, was an attempt to scandalise and lower the court's authority and interfere with the administration of justice, which amounted to contempt of court.

Kejriwal has filed the application for recusal of Justice

Sharma, claiming there was a grave, bona fide, and reasonable apprehension that the hearing in the matter before her would not be impartial and neutral.

His plea stated that Justice Sharma has decided multiple cases arising from the CBI FIR, including Kejriwal's petition against his arrest, and never given relief to any of the accused.

Besides Kejriwal, the applications for recusal of the judge have also been filed by AAP leaders Manish Sisodia and Durgesh Pathak. Other respondents, including Vijay Nair and Arun Ramchandra Pillai, have also filed similar applications seeking recusal.

On April 6, Justice Sharma had granted time to CBI to respond to the recusal application and listed the case for hearing on April 13.

The CBI said in its response that the prayer for recusal was based on frivolous and

baseless averments, which were wholly vexatious, and should be dismissed with "heavy cost".

"It is submitted that attending a legal seminar can never be a ground for recusal when the topic of the seminar was not a political one; therefore, it does not demonstrate any ideological association, hence the said averment is also otherwise untenable. If attending a function of the Akhil Bharatiya Adhivakta Parishad shows ideological bias of any judge, then a large number of sitting high court and Supreme Court judges would have to recuse from hearing any case where politically exposed persons are accused," the reply stated.

The agency said that a view taken by a judge in a judicial decision cannot be a basis to allege bias, and the request by Kejriwal and others amounted to "forum shopping".

Delhi's iconic Lodhi Garden turns 90

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Home to centuries-old tombs and some of the most exotic plants and bird species, Delhi's iconic Lodhi Garden — often described as the 'best urban oasis in Asia' — turned 90 on Thursday.

The horticultural delight, nestled in the heart of the national capital, bordering the posh Lodhi Estate and upscale Khan Market, was opened on April 9, 1936, as 'The Lady Willingdon Park', named after the then Vicerine of India.

Virtually acting as the lungs of Delhi, the wide green space, spread over 90 acres, is a top favourite of many for morning and evening walks, as also for joggers, or those looking just for some quieter moments away from the hustle and bustle of the city.

This garden was laid out after shifting what was then the village of Khairpur, on the outskirts of New Delhi.

At the 1911 Delhi Durbar, the



Visitors at Lodhi Garden in New Delhi

PTI

British had announced the shifting of their imperial capital in India from Calcutta (now Kolkata) to Delhi, and a new capital city — later named New Delhi — was built, which was formally inaugurated on February 13, 1931, by the then Viceroy Lord Irwin.

With its beautiful flora and fauna, the Lodhi Garden is also a top choice of many picnickers and tourists, both domestic and foreign. Besides scattered monuments, a variety of plants and trees can

be found here, such as neem, jamun, royal bottle palm, bamboo, eucalyptus and numerous birds, including parakeets, mynahs, kingfishers, babblers and hornbills.

"The garden happens to contain an unusually rich variety of architectural styles, ranging from Sayyid and Lodi to Mughal. The present landscaping was done by American architect Joseph Allen Stein (in 1968) and modified by a group of Japanese landscape design-

ers," according to INTACH.

Incidentally, the Indian National Trust for Art and Cultural Heritage (INTACH), a Delhi-based non-profit body that works for the preservation of unprotected heritage in the country, is located in the vicinity of the garden.

Purnima Datt, head of the HECS (Heritage Education and Communication Service) department at INTACH headquarters, says the garden is "our close neighbour" and also virtually a "living classroom for students" as it is an abode of so many species of plants, trees and birds, butterflies and other fauna.

"INTACH and Lodhi Garden have a very symbiotic relationship. For us, we see it every time we go to work, and we have so many fond memories associated with it. Either visiting it purely for a stroll or for doing heritage walks, every time the experience is amazing, just to be there in such an open space right in the heart of the city," she said.

IN FOCUS



Commuters travel in a boat across the Ganga River at sunset in Patna

Bollywood celebrities gather for Anant Ambani’s birthday

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Jamnagar

Jamnagar has turned into a Bollywood hub with the arrival of film celebrities for Anant Ambani’s birthday celebrations. A two-day grand celebration has been organised in the city, including cultural events such as traditional folk performances (dairas) and other programmes. On the occasion of Anant Ambani’s 31st birthday, the Ambani family has announced donations for public welfare.

A total of ₹30 crore has been allocated for the construction of a modern pilgrim guest house at Dwarka to provide better facilities for devotees and pilgrims visiting the sacred shrine. Additionally, ₹10 crore has been pledged for establishing a state-of-the-art cowshed for 500 cows in Salangpur.

Deeply devoted to Lord Dwarkadhish, Anant Ambani and his family, motivated by



faith and gratitude, announced the ₹30 crore contribution to build the pilgrim accommodation.

As the number of devotees visiting the Dwarkadhish temple continues to increase day by day, the construction of such accommodation facilities will greatly benefit pilgrims and serve as a noble act for their welfare, as expressed by the temple committee.

The week started with Anant Ambani and Radhika Merchant visiting the Krishna Kali Temple.

Protests in Manipur over killing of 2 children

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Imphal

Defying curfew, thousands of demonstrators across five valley districts of Manipur held protest rallies and burnt tyres against the bomb attack that claimed the lives of two children in Bishnupur district.

At Tiddim Line in Imphal West district, hundreds of people under the aegis of the All Manipur United Clubs Organisation staged a rally from its office near Kwakeithel, denouncing the killings and demanding the immediate arrest of the perpetrators.

Several children, holding posters of the two minors killed in the attack, also attended the rally, which was stopped by security forces from advancing further near Kwakeithel.

Later, representatives of AMUCO and others were escorted to meet Chief Minister Y Khemchand Singh to address their concerns.

On April 7, a 5-year-old boy and his 6-month-old sister were killed when suspected militants hurled a bomb at their house at Tronglaobi in



Bishnupur district. Soon after the incident, a mob of around 500 protesters stormed a CRPF camp near Gelmol, a few hundred metres from Tronglaobi, and engaged in vandalism and burning of security vehicles. In the ensuing firing by personnel,

three protesters died while 30 were injured. On Thursday, at Samurou in Imphal West district, hundreds of protestors also attempted to head towards the CM’s official bungalow but were stopped by police. Protesters also burnt tyres and

stopped vehicular movements at Moirang Lamkhai and Ningthoukhong in Bishnupur district. Similar incidents of tyre burning were reported from Khurai in Imphal East district and parts of Thoubal and Kakching districts.

In Imphal, a lawyer allegedly attempted self-immolation in front of the Lok Bhavan in protest against the bomb attack, officials said.

Sinam Apollo (32) arrived in front of the Lok Bhavan on a two-wheeler and poured kerosene over himself, but his attempt to set himself on fire was foiled by the police.

He was later taken to a police station for questioning. On Wednesday night, clashes broke out between protesters and security forces at Khurai Lamlong in Imphal East district, where agitators resorted to stone pelting, prompting security forces to fire tear gas shells to disperse the crowd. Earlier, police arrested three suspected cadres of the United Kuki National Army during operations following the Tronglaobi incident.

Amreli shaken by repeated tremors; 14 quakes felt in 30 hours



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Amreli

Gujarat, known for its seismic sensitivity due to its geological conditions, once again experienced earthquake tremors, with the Savarkundla region of Amreli district witnessing continuous ground activity over the past 30 hours. In the Mitiala area and nearby villages, residents reported as many as 14 minor to moderate tremors, creating widespread panic among locals.

According to official data from the Gandhinagar-based Seismology Department, only one earthquake has been formally recorded. The main tremor occurred at 1.14 AM with a magnitude of 3.0. Local residents, on the other hand, reported additional tremors at 1.37 AM (magnitude 1.1) and at 8.58 AM (magnitude 1.5), following which frightened people rushed out of their homes.

Sources indicated that around eight tremors were felt in the district on the previous day. The Seismology Department officially confirmed one tremor with its epicentre near Vankiya village, approximately 43 kilometres from Amreli.

Centre calls for district-level push for cooperative reforms

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Varanasi

Under the overarching vision of ‘Sahkar se Samridhhi’, the Ministry of Cooperation has called for a decisive shift from policy deliberation to grassroots execution.

Addressing the inaugural National Review Conference, Secretary Dr Ashish Kumar Bhutani emphasised that the revival of the cooperative sector now hinges on grounding reforms at the district level through time-bound action plans.

Reviewing the progress of flagship initiatives, Dr Bhutani highlighted the need to maintain momentum for the ambitious target of establishing two lakh Primary Agricultural Credit Societies (PACS).

2 held for ₹7 lakh fake stock investment fraud

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

A promise of quick profits turned into a costly trap, as Delhi Police arrested two men for allegedly cheating a person of around ₹7 lakh through a fake stock investment scheme operated on social media.

The accused, identified as Shashikant Sharma and Deepak, were arrested from the Palam area on April 5 following an investigation by the Cyber Police Station in Shahdara. Police said the duo was part of a larger syndicate that targeted victims by posing as investment



professionals. The case was registered after a complaint was filed by a man who alleged that he had been lured into an online investment scheme that promised high returns. According to police, the fraudsters contacted the

victim through a social media platform and added him to a group where they projected themselves as representatives of a legitimate firm. Officials said the accused used a calculated approach to gain the victim’s trust.

They initially shared stock recommendations and analysis reports at no cost. These appeared credible and were designed to convince the victim of their authenticity.

Over time, the complainant was persuaded to invest money in what was presented as stock market opportunities, including

initial public offerings. Police said the victim was shown a fabricated portfolio that reflected false investments and profits. The deception continued until the victim attempted to withdraw his money. When he failed to access the funds, he realised that he had been cheated and approached the police.

During the investigation, officers traced part of the defrauded amount to a bank account linked to a shell entity operating from a virtual office in central Delhi. This led to the identification and arrest of the accused.

Nitish Kumar to take oath as Rajya Sabha member today

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Bihar’s long-time chief minister Nitish Kumar will take oath as a member of the Rajya Sabha on Friday, paving the way for the formation of a new Government in Bihar.



Kumar arrived in the national Capital on Thursday including JD-U’s national working president Sanjay Kumar Jha. “I have arrived to take oath,” Kumar told reporters at the airport.

He will be administered the oath as a member of the upper house in the chamber

of Rajya Sabha Chairman CP Radhakrishnan.

With Kumar assuming his Rajya Sabha role, marking the end of his rule in Bihar, the NDA is likely to elect a new chief minister of Bihar on April 14. Bihar minister Vijay Kumar Chaudhary said Nitish Kumar will take the

oath after being elected to the Rajya Sabha and will soon relinquish the post of chief minister. “Bihar will have an NDA Government and will certainly follow the Nitish Kumar-created ‘Nitish model’, as it has been running for the past 20 years,” Chaudhary said.

FROM PAGE - 1

PM calls for TMC ouster, promises Viksit Bengal

The PM alleged the State Government failed to match fish production with its high demand in the state. “Bengal has a high demand for fish. Yet it imports fish from other states. In the last 15 years, the TMC Government has taken no worthwhile step to enhance supply and attain self-sufficiency in fish production,” he said.

The prime minister promised the people of West Bengal that the BJP would make the state self-sufficient in fisheries and the seafood sector, while highlighting that the BJP Government at the Centre has set up a dedicated ministry for the welfare of the fisherfolk and allotted a record budget for them.

Underlining “six Modi guarantees” for the people, the prime minister said the BJP, once in power in the state, will bring about changes in the governance system and make public servants accountable to citizens for their actions, stating his second guarantee.

“The BJP will reopen all files on corruption and crimes committed against women in Bengal, which the TMC has suppressed,” he added, spelling out his “third guarantee”. All leaders, irrespective of their positions in Government, who are involved in corruption will be in jail. No TMC goons can escape the clutches of law,” he added as the fourth.

While pledging that the benefits of Government facilities and schemes will be made available to all refugees who took shelter in India legally, Modi underlined that “infiltrators won’t be allowed to stay in this country”.

He alleged the “TMC cheated Bengal’s youth on two counts — destroyed the private sector and looted Government posts for money”. “Even in 100 years, the TMC cannot absolve itself of the sins it committed against Bengal’s youth,” Modi added, referring to the closed industrial units of the state and workforce migration.

Puri, Jaishankar lead India’s Gulf outreach...

Although a two-week ceasefire has since reduced immediate risks, the situation remains volatile.

Official details of Puri’s engagements have not been disclosed, but discussions are expected to centre on crude oil and gas supplies. The Government said further information will be released after the visit concludes.

Jaishankar’s upcoming trip to the UAE signals parallel diplomatic outreach, aimed at reinforcing ties with key regional partners at a time of heightened geopolitical uncertainty.

Amid these developments, India’s energy lifelines have shown resilience. The India-flagged LPG carrier Green Asha has safely reached Jawaharlal Nehru Port Authority in Navi Mumbai with 15,400 tonnes of Liquefied Petroleum Gas (LPG). The vessel crossed the Strait of Hormuz on April 5 at the height of regional tensions. Another LPG tanker, Green Sanvi, which transited the Strait on April 6, is expect-

ed to arrive in India shortly.

Meanwhile, India has quietly granted case-by-case waivers to speed up energy imports from Iran amid a severe LPG shortage. India is the world’s second largest importer of LPG and is in the middle of its worst gas crisis in decades.

Indian authorities have made two specific exceptions for Iranian cargoes. LPG tanker Aurora (30 years old) was allowed to dock at Mangalore port in Karnataka, even though India normally requires older vessels (over 20 years) to have special seaworthiness certification from recognised classification societies. Crude oil tanker Jaya has been given permission to unload despite being under US sanctions. India normally bars sanctioned vessels from its ports.

Iran has increasingly used an older shadow fleet of tankers to bypass Western sanctions, which is why such vessels are involved. According to sources in the Government, these waivers are strictly on a case-by-case basis and only for ships that meet basic safety standards.

UP ATS arrests six in rail sabotage plot linked...

The module’s broader motive, according to police officials, aligned with the avowed objective of Pakistan to Balkanise India, it added.

Their interrogation has revealed that they were planning large scale explosions by targeting railway stations at the behest of ISI and the involvement of more people, according to the police. Their accomplices were identified and well-coordinated raids were conducted in Shamli, which led to the arrest of six people on Thursday, the police claimed.

According to the police, the arrested had conducted detailed reconnaissance of the vital installations in cities including Ghaziabad, Aligarh and Lucknow and shared Google location pins, videos and sensitive details with their handlers through social media platforms and were waiting for instructions.

The modules were tasked to attack railway signal boxes and set them on fire, the police claims. Further, that they were also trained via social media platform to setting fire to gas cylinder-laden trucks and targeting public assets and vehicles to spread panic and mayhem and also trigger economic disruption.

In order to impress their handlers, the UP ATS claims, the members of the module had carried out minor arson acts and videos were sent back to handlers in exchange for payments via QR codes. The forensic experts of the UP ATS are analysing the digital devices recovered from those arrested to trace funding channels, handler identities and the full extent of the network.

Sources said that the evidence recovered from the first four accused involved in the failed terror plot to target Charbagh railway station and their subsequent interrogation, points to a larger network of youths in western Uttar Pradesh, who were being groomed through online social media channels by the ISI to

launch attacks in India on their behalf. Senior police officials involved in the pan India investigation say more arrests are likely as the ambit of the investigation has been expanded.

CWC meets to strategise parliament special...

The Union Cabinet on Wednesday cleared the draft bills, which seek to implement the Women’s Reservation Act before the 2029 parliamentary polls and increase the number of Lok Sabha seats.

The Congress has accused Prime Minister Narendra Modi of using the quota law as a poll issue.

Last week, the Congress alleged that the Government called a special session of Parliament to pass these bills to “grab political mileage” in West Bengal and Tamil Nadu polls. The party claimed, it is a “gross violation” of the Model Code of Conduct.

The Congress also cautioned against any haste in amending the Constitution regarding delimitation, saying it is a sensitive matter, and the Government must tread carefully, as the exercise might put several states like Tamil Nadu and Kerala at a significant disadvantage.

The Congress has been severely critical of the Government’s handling of the West Asia crisis and took a swipe at the Government on Wednesday, saying that the role played by Pakistan in bringing about the ceasefire is a “severe setback” to the PM’s “highly personalised diplomacy”. The Opposition party also asked why the PM was not in the picture at all during the ceasefire negotiations.

West Asia ceasefire in peril as Israel pounds...

Israeli forces reportedly killed a senior aide to Hezbollah leader Naim Qassem. Backing Israel’s position, US Vice President JD Vance described the exclusion of Lebanon as a “misunderstanding” and said the US had never formally agreed to cover Lebanon in the truce.

Iran’s President Masoud Pezeshkian condemned the attacks, warning that continued strikes would render negotiations meaningless and reaffirming support for the Lebanese people. Pakistan, which has played a central mediating role, maintained that Lebanon had been included in the ceasefire. Former US envoy Robert Malley suggested that the current escalation reflected US inconsistencies and a temporary green light for Israel to continue strikes.

As the ceasefire’s future appeared increasingly precarious, former President Trump issued a social media ultimatum threatening renewed US attacks (“Shootin’ Starts”) unless Iran fully reopened the Strait of Hormuz and abandoned nuclear weapons, without referring to Lebanon.

Global allies, including the UK, EU, Canada, and Japan, have called for a comprehensive ceasefire encompassing Lebanon. EU foreign policy chief Kaja Kallas condemned Israel’s heavy-

handed approach, while France’s Jean-Noël Barrot and UK Foreign Secretary Yvette Cooper described the strikes as “unacceptable” and “deeply damaging,” warning of regional destabilisation.

Diplomatic efforts are also focused on reopening the strategically vital Strait of Hormuz, which channels a fifth of global oil and LNG supplies. In the 24 hours following the ceasefire, only 11 ships-four Iranian, four Greek, one Chinese, one Omani, and one of unknown nationality-were allowed passage, leaving roughly 1,400 vessels stranded and sending oil prices climbing toward \$100 a barrel amid mounting uncertainty.

Ticket glitch or fraud? Entry dispute puts IPL...

Responding to the claims, DDCA secretary Ashok Sharma dismissed the allegations of ticket duplication and termed the issue a technical error. He said the problem occurred due to a failure of the scanning system to read the barcode on the tickets. “Delhi Capitals have communicated to us that it was a technical issue. Sometimes the scanner fails to read the barcode,” Sharma said, rejecting the suggestion of fraud.

The conflicting versions have brought focus on the robustness of ticket verification systems used during high-profile sporting events. While Verma has raised the issue as a case of fraud involving unauthorised access, DDCA officials have maintained that it was an isolated glitch without any larger implications.

The complaint has been formally submitted to the police, and it remains to be seen whether an investigation will be initiated to verify the claims. If proven, the allegations could have serious implications for stadium security and ticketing protocols. For now, the incident has triggered a debate within the cricket administration over accountability and transparency in managing access to one of the country’s busiest cricket venues.

High turnout fuels speculation in Assam...

The poll percentage in 16 constituencies, mostly in minority-dominated areas, have already crossed the 90-per cent mark, while 83 constituencies are in the range of 80-89 per cent and the remainder in the 70-79 per cent category. Dalgao recorded the highest voting at 94.57 per cent, while the lowest turnout was in Amri at 70.40 per cent.

Reacting on the high turn out, Assam Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma said the high turnout in Thursday’s assembly election was not “ordinary but historic”. Sarma said the result of this election is “already visible - in the hope, pride, and happiness on the faces of our people”. “What we set out to do was not merely fight an election, but to turn it into a movement - a movement to protect our civilisational values, our culture, and our land,” Sarma said in a post on

X. “Today, for the first time, our people have come out in unprecedented numbers - voting shoulder to shoulder, matching and even surpassing our opponents in turnout. In many polling booths, participation is crossing 95 per cent. This is not ordinary. This is historic,” he asserted.

Kerala’s 140 constituencies feature a battle between continuity and comeback. The crucial elections will decide whether the ruling Left Democratic Front, led by chief minister Pinarayi Vijayan, will get a straight third term, or if the Congress-led United Democratic Front, which is campaigning on anti-incumbency, governance concerns, and past electoral setbacks makes a comeback or if BJP springs a surprise in an otherwise bipolar battle. In the 2021 Kerala Assembly polls, a turnout of 74.06 per cent was recorded and the highest polling the state has seen is 80.5 per cent which was in the 1987 Assembly elections. The ruling LDF is fighting to retain power, banking on Chief Minister Pinarayi Vijayan’s model of governance and welfare.

The Congress-led UDF is vying to regain power, seeking to end a decade of Left rule in the state. Amidst this traditionally bipolar contest, the BJP-led NDA is looking to disrupt the duopoly of LDF and UDF and aims to translate its growing vote share into a decisive presence in the state assembly. The figures also showed that Kozhikode district recorded the highest polling percentage of 77.63 per cent and pushed Ernakulam, which had been in the front since morning, to second place with 77.25 per cent at 5 pm. Constituency-wise, Kunnathunad topped with 81.99 per cent. The lowest turnout came in Kaduthuruthy with 66.81 per cent (all 5 pm data).

Officials said the final turnout is expected to rise further as late voters in queues are counted. If the trend continues, the overall turnout could cross 80.54 per cent registered in 1987.

Chief Minister Pinarayi Vijayan cast his vote along with his family at a polling station in Kannur district. Describing the election as decisive, he said it would determine the direction of Kerala’s development. “We have been able to achieve development and it should continue. It should not be disrupted and people desire its continuation,” he told reporters. Leaders across Kerala’s three main political fronts offered differing explanations for the high voter turnout, with each linking the trend to factors that could shape the election outcome. CPI(M) leader C N Mohanan attributed the rise to the revision of electoral rolls. Congress leader Deepthi Mary Varghese said the trend needs closer study. BJP leader K S Shaiju linked the rise to voter behaviour on the ground.

In the 30 assembly constituencies in Pudukcherry, the election sees a direct contest between the AINRC-BJP-led NDA headed by chief minister N Rangasamy and the Congress-DMK alliance. A key contest is in Thattanchavady, where Rangasamy is up against former chief minister V Vaithilingam. Key issues include the long-pending demand for statehood, unemployment and water contamination. The entry of Tamilaga Vettri Kazhagam is also being seen as a factor that could influence outcomes.

PM urges support for women’s quota amendments

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Thursday said that the proposed amendments to the Women's Reservation Act are not just a legislative exercise but a reflection of the aspirations of crores of women across India, urging all MPs to come together to support this significant move.

In a signed article posted on his website narendramodi.in, the prime minister also said that the initiative is an affirmation of a principle that has long guided India's civilisational ethos, that society progresses when women progress.

He said it is imperative that the 2029 Lok Sabha elections and Assembly polls in various States in the coming times are conducted with women's reservation in place.

The prime minister said the nation stands at the threshold

of a historic occasion, and it is an opportunity to deepen the foundations of the country's democracy and to reaffirm the collective commitment to equality and inclusion.

He said that on April 16, Parliament will be convened to discuss and pass an important bill that advances women's reservation.

In a video message posted later, he urged women to read his article and encourage others to also go through it.

He said people should encourage and inspire political parties to pass the measure when Parliament meets on April 16, 17 and 18 for the "special" work.

"To describe this merely as a legislative exercise would be an understatement. It is a reflection of the aspirations of crores of women across India," he said.

The Budget session of Parliament has been extended, and a special three-day



sitting of the House has been convened from April 16 to 18, when the 'Nari Shakti Vandan Adhiniyam', more commonly known as the Women Reservation Act, would be amended for its implementation from the 2029 general elections.

The provision to provide 33 per cent reservation to women in the Lok Sabha and State assemblies was brought by amending the Constitution in 2023, but it will come into effect after the completion of

the delimitation exercise on the basis of the 2027 Census. It is expected to come into force only in 2034 if the present law remains as it is, and therefore, there is a need to amend it to make it enforceable from the 2029 general elections.

The redrawing of the constituencies will be done on the basis of the 2011 Census rather than the proposed 2027 Census. A similar exercise will be carried out for State assemblies, where

seats will be reserved on a pro-rata basis.

According to the broad contours available, the number of Lok Sabha seats would be increased from the present 543 to 816, with 273 seats reserved for women. The reservation will also be done on a "vertical basis" with seats allocated for SCs and STs.

In the article, Modi said women constitute nearly half of India's population, their contributions to the nation are vast and invaluable, and today, India is witnessing remarkable achievements by women across every field.

"From science and technology to entrepreneurship, from sports to the armed forces and from music to the arts, women are at the forefront of India's progress," he said.

The prime minister said that over the years, sustained efforts have been made to create an enabling environment for women's empowerment.

GOYAL SLAMS DMK FOR BLOCKING WOMEN'S RESERVATION BILL

Coimbatore (Chennai): Union Minister Piyush Goyal on Thursday slammed the DMK Government in Tamil Nadu, accusing it of creating "flimsy excuses" to block the implementation of one-third reservation for women in Parliament and State assemblies.

He said that the Centre intends to add additional seats in the Lok Sabha and legislatures to accommodate this reservation without affecting current seats.

"The Congress and DMK are creating all flimsy excuses and are trying to block the Parliament sessions on April 16, 17 and 18, which will ensure one-third reservation without affecting the current seats," Goyal said.

Rise above politics to serve people, Birla tells lawmakers

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Panaji

Lok Sabha Speaker Om Birla on Thursday urged lawmakers to rise above personal and political interests, emphasising that elected representatives must act with integrity to translate public expectations into concrete actions.

Inaugurating the first CPA India Region Zone VII Conference in Goa, Birla noted that upholding citizens' trust requires unwavering commitment to public welfare. Addressing the roles of emerging leaders, he stated that young lawmakers carry a pivotal responsibility in realising the vision of "Viksit Bharat" by 2047 through innovative policies and the strengthening of democratic institutions.

"Parliamentary democracy is globally recognised as the best system of governance," Birla said, adding that the steady increase in voter turnout since 1952 reflects India's success as a vibrant democracy. He called for healthy competition among State legislatures to promote good governance and suggested that States like Maharashtra, Gujarat, and

Goa should share best practices, particularly in coastal development.

Emphasising the digital transition, the Speaker remarked that while artificial intelligence (AI) is a powerful tool, "human sensitivity remains essential." He urged legislators to harness technology to address grievances while maintaining empathy and goodwill.

Birla also stressed the importance of mastering legislative rules, observing that those who engage in thoughtful discussions often emerge as prominent leaders. "The more legislators familiarise themselves with processes, the more effective their participation will be," he noted.

Deputy Chairman of Rajya Sabha Harivansh, Goa Chief Minister Pramod Sawant, Maharashtra Legislative Council Chairperson Ram Shinde, and Maharashtra Legislative Assembly Speaker Rahul Narvekar also addressed the occasion. Goa Legislative Assembly Speaker Ganesh Gaonkar delivered the Welcome Address on the occasion. Goa Legislative Assembly Deputy Chairman Joshua D'Souza delivered the Vote of Thanks.



Lok Sabha Speaker Om Birla delivering the Inaugural Address at the First CPA India Region Zone VII Conference in Panaji, Goa

PIONEER PHOTO

3 more children die in Rajasthan's Salumber

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Jaipur

Three more children have died in Rajasthan's Salumber, with authorities saying their deaths are not connected with the "mysterious" deaths of five children earlier this month.

The fresh deaths took place in the last two days in the Jhallara and Lasadiya areas in the district and have been attributed to vomiting and diarrhoea.

Chief Medical and Health Officer Mahendra Kumar Parmar said, Raunak aged four-and-a-half years a resident of Amloda village in Jhallara, was brought dead to the hospital on Tuesday.

A two-month-old infant, Banshi, from Kalibheet village and Divyansh Patel, aged two years from Mandli village, died on Wednesday after suffering from fever, vomiting and diarrhoea, the officer said.



Make Poshan Abhiyaan a Jan Andolan: Annpurna Devi

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Union Women and Child Development Minister Annpurna Devi on Thursday said the Poshan Abhiyaan should become a 'jan andolan' and stressed the need to reduce children's screen time and improve nutrition in the first six years of life.

Launching the eighth edition of Poshan Pakhwada under the theme 'Maximising brain development in the first six years of



life', Devi said the campaign is not merely a nutrition programme but an effort to turn it into a "jan andolan" (people's movement).

"The first six years of a child's life are the most

important. Eighty-five per cent of brain development takes place during this period, so we all have to pay attention to it," she said.

"This is not just a Poshan Abhiyaan; there are efforts

to make it a 'jan andolan' under the leadership of Prime Minister Narendra Modi," Devi added.

Minister of State for Women and Child Development Savitri Thakur, Women and Child Development Secretary Anil Malik and Joint Secretary Radhika Jha were also present at the event.

Devi said children are the future of the country, and ensuring proper nutrition in the early years is essential for achieving the goal of a developed India.

"There can be nothing more important than ensuring a better future for our children," the minister said.

Devi said the women and child development ministry has a vast network of around 14 lakh Anganwadi centres across the country, reaching nearly every village and household.

She said more than 8.9 crore beneficiaries are linked with Anganwadi centres and credited Anganwadi workers for continuing their work in all seasons.

Centre invites applications for CVC

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Centre has sought applications from eligible candidates to fill the post of Central Vigilance Commissioner in the probity watchdog CVC (Central Vigilance Commission).

"It is proposed to appoint the Central Vigilance Commissioner in the Central Vigilance Commission (CVC) against the vacancy due to arise with effect from August 3, 2026, upon completion of the tenure of the incumbent," an order issued by the min-



istry of personnel said.

Praveen Kumar Srivastava, a 1988-batch Indian Administrative Service officer (retired) of the Assam-Meghalaya cadre, is currently working as the Central Vigilance Commissioner.

Indian values more relevant amid global conflict: ICCR DG

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

India stands for peace, harmony and universal brotherhood, ICCR's DG, K Nandini Singla, has said, asserting that in times of wars, conflicts and growing anxiety, the Indian values and its ideas as a civilisation are becoming more and more relevant.

At a press interaction



held at Azad Bhawan on the eve of the 77th foundation day of the Indian Council for Cultural Relations (ICCR) on

Wednesday, she also said the world needs to be reminded of the ancient Indian ethos of Vasudhaiva Kutumbakam.

"It is not a cliché. The feeling of 'Vasudhaiva Kutumbakam' is something that every person in the world appreciates, the idea that we are all interconnected, we cannot thrive at somebody's expense," Singla said.

Nation Focus



Surrendered Maoists to train cops on IED detection

The Chhattisgarh police have roped in surrendered Naxalites with expertise in improvised explosive devices (IEDs) to train security personnel, aiming to enhance their operational capabilities, officials said on Thursday.

The counter-insurgency strategy comes shortly after Chhattisgarh, particularly the Bastar region that had grappled with Left-Wing Extremism for over four decades, was declared free of armed Maoists on March 31.

According to officials, this knowledge-sharing will play a crucial role in making the Bastar region safer by strengthening the capacity of security forces to detect and neutralise IED threats. It will protect both personnel and local communities from the dangers of explosives that Maoists had once planted extensively across the region during the peak of their influence and activity.



Posters declare Samrat Chaudhary as new Bihar CM

Posters declaring Samrat Choudhary, the deputy CM of Bihar, as the man who would head the new government in the state, were on Thursday put up outside the BJP office in Patna as Chief Minister Nitish Kumar left for Delhi to be sworn in as a Rajya Sabha MP.

The posters, a few of which were pulled down by the party office staff, bore the label of 'Valmiki Samaj', a community of Dalits associated with scavenging work.

"We do not know who has put up these posters. We can, at this moment, only say that who would be the next CM is a decision to be taken collectively, as has been the party's tradition," BJP state media in charge Danish Egbal told reporters. Speculations are rife that upon being sworn in as Rajya Sabha MP on Friday, Kumar, who turned 75 last month, will hold the last meeting of his cabinet next week before giving up the chief minister's post.

Chanting Navkar Mantra relevant amid global conflicts: Amit Shah

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Union Home Minister Amit Shah on Thursday said the collective chanting of the Navkar Mantra here for the welfare of the entire world is highly meaningful and relevant at a time when different parts of the world are witnessing conflicts over different ideologies.

Addressing the 'Vishwa Navkar Mahamantra Diwas' as the chief guest, Shah said mantras guide human life towards a higher path, awaken our consciousness, and strengthen noble intentions.

He noted that in an era when the world desperately needs peace, collective chant-



ing of the Navkar Mantra can help purify the environment and calm the disturbances of the mind. "It will also strengthen mutual understanding, harmony, and sensitivity toward one another," he said.

Shah said the tradition of the Navkar Mantra has persisted for thousands of years, significantly contributed to by the 24 Tirthankaras and their followers.

He stated that our enlightened sages, through tireless penance over generations, have composed these mantras for the welfare of all humanity. "We should accept them with devotion and also incorporate them into our practice," he said.

He described the Navkar Mantra as a formless, impartial, and universal prayer that does not discriminate based on time, caste, region, or religion. Such an inclusive and universally accepted prayer is extremely rare in the world, he noted.

According to Shah, this prayer serves as a tribute to the virtues of great souls who have conquered their karma and paved the way for self-realisation and liberation.

Too early to draw lessons from West Asia conflict: Navy Chief

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Bengaluru

Describing the West Asia conflict as a critical case study in modern warfare, Chief of Naval Staff Admiral Dinesh Kumar Tripathi on Thursday said it was too early to draw definitive lessons from the war.

Addressing the 'Ran Samvad' forum on "Maritime Forces — Visualisation of Multi Domain Operation (MDO)", he said the Indian armed forces were closely tracking developments in the West Asia conflict to derive lessons for future operations.

"It is too early to draw definitive lessons. The war is still going on. We are monitoring what is happening, what is working, what is not working, and learning the correct lessons," Admiral Tripathi said during the question-answer session.

The Navy Chief emphasised that one of the most striking takeaways from the conflict is the heightened vulnerability of military assets across domains.

"Battle space transparency today is so high that anything



CNS Admiral Dinesh K Tripathi addressing a session on 'Maritime Forces Visualisation of MDO' during the 'Ran Samvad 2026' in Bengaluru, Karnataka

PTI

visible, whether moving or stationary, is inherently vulnerable," he said.

He added that while all platforms, land, sea and space, face exposure, subsurface assets retain a relative advantage due to detection challenges.

The conflict has also underscored the importance of resilience, particularly in sustaining supply chains under prolonged hostilities.

States Focus



ROBOT WELCOMES VOTERS WITH FLOWERS AT PUDUCHERRY BOOTH

A robot carrying a plate of flower petals welcomed voters at a model polling booth set up at VOC Government higher secondary school in the Raj Bhavan constituency during the Assembly polls on Thursday. Moving along the corridor, the robot greeted visitors and encouraged them to exercise their franchise. District Election Officer of Puducherry, A Kulothungan, said that the booth was among the model polling stations opened in Puducherry, and the initiative has drawn positive responses from the voters. "This innovative arrangement delighted visitors, who appreciated the robot's voice messages urging them to vote and help achieve 100 per cent polling," the official said, adding that the robot was brought from Chennai.



FIRE BREAKS OUT AT MUMBAI AIRPORT TERMINAL 1B

A fire broke out inside Terminal 1B of Mumbai's Chhatrapati Shivaji Maharaj International Airport on Thursday evening, triggering a swift emergency response and causing concern among passengers as thick smoke filled parts of the building. According to officials, the fire started around 6 pm in the seating area of the terminal. It was later found to have originated in cable trays and switch boxes located on the ground floor. The blaze was confined to this section and did not spread to other parts of the airport. Chief Fire Officer Ravindra Ambulgekar said that fire brigade teams rushed to the spot immediately after receiving the alert. Multiple fire tenders were deployed to control the situation. Police and local ward staff also joined the operation to manage the emergency and assist with evacuation if needed.

BJP will rename places antithetical to Bengal culture: BJP chief Nabin

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Raiganj (WB)

BJP national president Nitin Nabin on Thursday asserted that the names of places antithetical to West Bengal's culture and ethos will be changed if the BJP forms the Government in the State. Asserting that Bangladeshi infiltration was endangering women's security in the State, he said that voting the BJP to power in the State will ensure that such people face the law and are sent back. Addressing an election rally at Chakulia in Uttar Dinajpur district, Nabin said that the names of places in the State, from Alipurduar to Islampur, which he claimed are "antithetical to West Bengal's culture", will not be allowed to remain under a BJP Government. "After May 4, changes in your lives will be ushered in along with changes in the names of

these places," he said.

Assembly elections in West Bengal will be held in two phases on April 23 and 29, and the counting of votes is scheduled on May 4.

The BJP chief said that this election is a battle between the State's "tyrannical Government, which signifies corruption, repression, lawlessness and 'mahajangalra'", and the BJP, in which the people of the country have faith.

He urged people of the State to give themselves a double-engine Government under the stewardship of Prime Minister Narendra Modi to ensure all-round development of the State.

Nabin said that West Bengal, which had a glorious past in every aspect from education to industries, has been shrouded in darkness since the rule of the Congress, followed by the Left Front and currently the TMC.



BJP National President Nitin Nabin addressing a public rally ahead of the West Bengal Assembly elections in North Dinajpur district

TMC demands investigation into purported video of Humayun Kabir

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Kolkata

The Trinamool Congress on Thursday shared a purported video of Humayun Kabir in which the former party leader alleged claims of proximity with the BJP's Leader of Opposition, Suwendu Adhikari, and Assam Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma, and demanded an ED probe into the matter.

At a press meet, the TMC circulated the video in which Kabir was also purportedly heard saying that he was ready to go to "any extent" to unseat West Bengal Chief Minister Mamata Banerjee.

PTI, however, could not independently verify the video. Reacting to the allegation, BJP spokesperson Debajit Sarkar said the TMC opted for cheap theatrics after realising that they won't return to power and asserted that the saffron party had never adopted unfair means as it believed in people's support.

"While the TMC knows that they are losing ground, there is a possibility that they have



a nexus with Kabir, and this is part of a got-up game to cut the BJP's share of votes," Sarkar said.

At the press meet, the TMC also claimed that the Prime Minister's Office was also part of a multi-crore plan to defeat Banerjee in the polls.

Claiming that the video was AI-generated, Kabir said it was aimed at maligning him and threatened to take legal action.

In the video, Kabir, who founded the Aam Janata Unnayan Party days after he was suspended by the TMC late last year, is also purportedly heard claiming that he

had communication with the PMO and was advised to coordinate with leaders from other BJP-ruled States.

The video further purportedly captures Kabir stating that his strategy revolves around diverting minority votes away from the ruling Trinamool Congress, suggesting that such a shift could benefit the BJP electorally.

He allegedly mentions having received ₹200 crore as an advance as part of a ₹1,000 crore deal to execute the plan.

Reacting sharply, senior TMC leader and minister Firhad Hakim said Kabir has been "working in tandem"

with the BJP to mislead minority voters.

Asking Kabir not to take the emotions and sentiment of the Muslim community for granted, Hakim said the video "exposes a deep-rooted conspiracy" aimed at influencing the electoral outcome in the state.

Hakim further alleged that Kabir was heard in the video saying that invoking the Babri Masjid issue would be more effective in mobilising Muslim votes, even if it does not ultimately materialise.

"The BJP is trying to manipulate the mandate by using proxy players. This video, if true, confirms our allegations," another senior TMC leader and minister Aroop Biswas said.

He also said the AIMM and its president, Asaduddin Owaisi, should clarify their stand on the issue.

Asked who shot the video, Hakim said, "That is not important. What he said and his demand to be made deputy chief minister in the event of the BJP coming to power is important."

Congress pulls out of Baramati bypoll, gifts NCP a walkover

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Mumbai/Pune

The Opposition Congress on Thursday opted out of the bypoll to the Baramati Assembly seat in Maharashtra at the last moment, giving a virtual walkover to ruling NCP candidate and Deputy CM Sunetra Pawar, though a contest will still take place as 22 other nominees remain in the fray.

After initially appearing firm to contest the April 23 bypoll, necessitated due to the death of former Deputy Chief Minister and sitting Baramati MLA Ajit Pawar, the husband

of Sunetra, the Congress withdrew its candidate in the wake of calls from ruling allies Nationalist Congress Party, BJP and also its Opposition partner NCP (SP).

Addressing a press conference in Mumbai, State Congress president Harshwardhan Sapkal sought to frame the decision to climb down as a move rooted in Maharashtra's political culture and decorum and referred to the death of Ajit Pawar in an air crash just over two months ago.

"The decision was taken to maintain the state's political culture, decorum and dia-

logue. We are taking two steps back since the bypoll is taking place immediately after the tragic demise of Ajit Pawar. Even though Ajit Pawar started his political career with the Congress, he had joined hands with the BJP for the sake of power," Sapkal said.

"The Congress is withdrawing from the Baramati bypoll, but not supporting any candidate," the MPCC president maintained. Soon after his announcement, Congress candidate Akash More withdrew his nomination from the high-profile assembly seat, a Pawar family bastion in Pune district, just before end of the deadline.



"As per directions from the party leadership, I have withdrawn my nomination," More told reporters in Baramati.

Sapkal made it clear his party's decision had nothing to do with Chief Minister Devendra Fadnis, a BJP leader, speaking to him with a

CPI(M) slams ECI over deletion of 90 lakh West Bengal voters

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi



The Communist Party of India (Marxist) on Thursday lodged a strong protest with the Election Commission of India (ECI) over the alleged "large-scale deletion" of voters from the electoral rolls in West Bengal following the Special Intensive Revision (SIR).

In a letter to the Chief Election Commissioner (CEC), CPI(M) General Secretary MA Baby termed the exercise a "systematic mass disenfranchisement." He claimed that over 90 lakh voters — roughly 12 per cent of the State's electorate — have been excluded from the rolls.

"Reports indicate that a significant number were placed under an impervious category of 'under adjudication,' only to find that redressal mechanisms were inaccessible and non-operational," Baby stated. He alleged that the SIR relied on algorithm-driven exclusions and arbitrary criteria like "logical consistency" rather than transparent, field-based verification.

The party further claimed that the exercise disproportionately impacted marginalised communities, including Muslims, women, and the economically vulnerable. The CPI(M) argued that the removal of these names amounts to a denial of the right to vote guaranteed under Article 326 of the Constitution.

"The voter was treated as a suspect, and the burden to prove otherwise rested on them," the letter noted, highlighting the "mental trauma and inconvenience" caused to citizens. The party demanded that the ECI guarantee the constitutional right to vote "at any cost" and criticised the opacity of the process, alleging that lists were released in formats that prevented public scrutiny.

Mamata accuses PM of misrepresenting facts over fish production

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Kolkata

West Bengal Chief Minister Mamata Banerjee on Thursday hit back at Prime Minister Narendra Modi for claiming that her Government failed to attain self-sufficiency in fish production, and accused him of misrepresenting facts.

Addressing a public rally at Agarpara in North 24 Parganas district, she also alleged that people are not allowed to eat non-vegetarian food in BJP-ruled States.

"I heard that today, he (PM) said that there is no fish production in Bengal, while

Bihar is producing more and exporting. But you do not allow people to eat fish in Bihar. Here we purchase fish from markets and eat," the TMC supremo said.

Earlier, Bengal used to import fish from Andhra Pradesh, but that has been stopped, Banerjee said, and urged Modi to keep track of these developments.

"You are uttering whatever your party people are whispering in your ears. You do not allow people to eat fish, eggs and meat in Rajasthan, Bihar, and UP. Shops (selling such items) are being shut down," Banerjee claimed.



West Bengal CM Mamata Banerjee with TMC candidate for the Banaragar constituency, Sayantika Banerjee during campaigning ahead of the state Assembly elections in Kolkata on Thursday

AIADMK chief defends pandemic remarks against Tamil Nadu CM

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Chennai

AIADMK chief Edappadi K Palaniswami on Thursday said he had only sought to know where Chief Minister MK Stalin "disappeared" during the pandemic, but did not say anything wrong about him.

Addressing a poll rally in support of his party candidate Aadhi Rajaram in the high-profile Chepauk-Thiruvallikeni assembly constituency, he said, "You and your son Udhayanidhi spoke very derogatorily about me. Can this be accepted? If you



speak one word, I can utter ten. The weapon I handle to retaliate is decided by my political foes, not me. I will certainly counter."

Rajaram, a senior AIADMK leader, is pitted against Udhayanidhi Stalin, who is seeking re-election from this seat for the second time.

Palaniswami said, "In my 51 years of public life and pol-

itics, I have never criticised anyone personally, but the Chief Minister and the Deputy Chief Minister have been making slanderous remarks against me. I won't remain a silent spectator if I am needlessly tarnished but will immediately respond."

"Yesterday, while campaigning in Kolathur (from where Stalin is contesting), I had said the Chief Minister did not give proper guidance during the pandemic and that he took photoshoots. I had asked where he had disappeared during the pandemic, and nothing wrong against him," he added.

Actors turn up to vote in Kerala, urge public participation

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Thiruvananthapuram

Popular film actors cast their votes, reflecting the enthusiasm of electors in the crucial 2026 Assembly polls on Thursday, where stakes are high for all political fronts in Kerala.

This election has also seen at least eight celebrities, including actors Ramesh Pisharody, Anjali Nair and Major Ravi, contesting in various constituencies.

Minister KB Ganesh Kumar, who has been winning elections from Pathanapuram in Kollam district, is once again contesting from the same constituency.

Actor Mohanlal waited outside Mudavanmughal Government School in Thiruvananthapuram to cast his vote at around 7 am. He was seen interacting with LDF candidate V Sivankutty and UDF candidate KS Sabarinadhan in the Nemom constituency.

"Done my part. Your turn, Keralam, go vote," he wrote on his social media platform after casting his vote.

Voters gathered in large numbers when star actor Mammooty and his family arrived in Ponnuruni, Kochi, to cast their votes.



Actor Mohanlal casting vote during the Kerala Assembly elections in Thiruvananthapuram on Thursday

"It is a once-in-five-year opportunity, and people should come forward to cast their votes," he said.

Actor Prithviraj Sukumaran and his wife, Supriya, cast their votes in Thevara, Kochi.

Ahaana Krishnakumar arrived at a polling booth in Thiruvananthapuram with her family.

She is the daughter of actor K Krishnakumar, who had earlier contested elections for the NDA.

"I think people, including the younger generation, are well aware of their voting rights. Thanks to social media, everyone has more information, and it is easier for them to make a decision and cast their votes," she said.

CBI registers FIR in ₹550 crore IDFC bank embezzlement case

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

The CBI has registered an FIR in the alleged embezzlement of ₹550 crore from the Haryana Government's accounts maintained with IDFC First Bank in Chandigarh after taking over the investigation in the matter, official sources said Thursday.

The Haryana Government had transferred the probe to the central probe agency. The referral was sent to the agency on Wednesday by the Department of Personnel and Training, they said. The CBI registered the FIR taking over the case earlier probed by the Haryana State Vigilance and Anti-Corruption Bureau (SV & ACB).

"The case pertains to fraudulent banking operations and fictitious transactions allegedly undertaken in a systematic manner to siphon off Government funds into the accounts of shell entities, including Swastik Desh Project, SRR Planning Gurus Pvt Ltd, Cap Co Fintech Services, RS Traders, and other associated firms/individuals, resulting in a substantial loss to the public exchequer," the vigilance department of Haryana said while referring the case to the agency.

According to the police and ED allegations, Haryana Government funds were supposed to be deposited by various departments of the state in the bank in FDs but were allegedly diverted by the accused for their personal purpose, the sources said.

Preliminary probe shows "huge" funds have been transferred to various shell companies and minor jewellery entities and finally siphoned off under the guise of gold purchase and investment into real estate sector, the sources said.



High voter turnout in Assam elections historic: Himanta

TONY DAS ■ Guwahati

Assam Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma on Thursday said the high turnout in Thursday's Assembly election was not "ordinary but historic".

Sarma said the result of this election is "already visible — in the hope, pride, and happiness on the faces of our people". Polling for all 126 assembly constituencies, held in a single phase, ended at 5 pm on Thursday, with an estimated voter turnout of 84.42 per cent, which was expected to rise further.



Assam CM Himanta Biswa Sarma with his family members after casting their votes in Guwahati

"What we set out to do was not merely fight an election, but to turn it into a movement — a movement to protect our

civilisational values, our culture, and our land," Sarma said in a post on X.

"Today, for the first time,

our people have come out in unprecedented numbers — voting shoulder to shoulder, matching and even surpassing our opponents in turnout. In many polling booths, participation is crossing 95 per cent. This is not ordinary. This is historic," he asserted. The CM said Assam has risen above language and caste, and "our people have voted with one clear resolve — to protect our land, our identity, and our culture from illegal infiltration and demographic aggression".

"This is not just an election.



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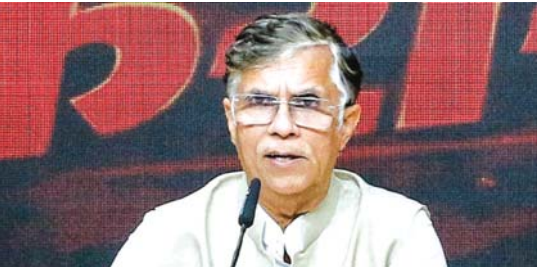
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Telangana HC adjourns hearing on Pawan Khera’s anticipatory bail plea



The Telangana High Court adjourned the hearing to Friday in the anticipatory bail petition filed by Congress leader Pawan Khera in a case filed by the Assam Government on his allegations against Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma’s wife.

Congress leader and senior advocate Abhishek Singhvi, who virtually argued for Khera, alleged political vendetta in the case filed by the Sarma-led Government in Assam.

Assam Advocate General Devajit Saikia, who argued against Khera’s petition, stressed that there is no political vendetta and that the petition is not maintainable before the Telangana High Court.

Khera’s lawyer, Ponnamp Ashok Goud, told PTI that orders are likely to be pronounced on Friday.

Tribunal awards ₹29.79 lakh compensation to Thane man injured in road accident



The Motor Accident Claims Tribunal in Maharashtra’s Thane has awarded a compensation of ₹29.79 lakh to a 35-year-old man who sustained grievous injuries after a speeding private bus rammed into him in Mumbai in 2022.

In an order dated April 6, a copy of which was made available on Wednesday, MACT Member RV Mohite held that the accident occurred due to the rash and negligent driving of the bus driver and fixed joint and several liability on the vehicle owner and insurer.

According to the tribunal, Mayuresh Ramesh Punekar was standing with his motorcycle in Mumbai’s Kanjurmarg area on July 8, 2022, when a private bus approached “in high and excessive speed with rash and negligent manner” and hit him from behind.

“The driver of offending vehicle was the person having last opportunity to avoid accident. There is nothing on record to show any contributory act on the part of claimant,” the tribunal said.

Punekar had sought compensation of ₹50 lakh. The tribunal held that the claimant had suffered 46 per cent permanent partial disability but clarified that the same could not be directly equated with loss of earning capacity.

The tribunal awarded a total compensation of ₹29.79 lakh to Punekar under various heads, including loss of income, future loss, medical expenses, pain and suffering, conveyance and special diet.

The money has to be paid with interest at the rate of 9 per cent per annum from the date of petition till depositing of the amount, it ordered.

PIL in SC seeks stringent guidelines for issuing Aadhaar cards to adolescents, adults

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

A petition filed in the Supreme Court has sought direction to the Unique Identification Authority of India (UIDAI) to issue new Aadhaar cards only to citizens up to the age of six years, and frame stringent guidelines for its issuance to adolescents and adults, to stop infiltrators from masquerading as Indian citizens.

The Public Interest Litigation (PIL) filed by lawyer Ashwini Upadhyay has also sought a direction to the authorities to install display boards at common service centres stating that the 12-digit unique identification number is only a “proof of identity” and not a proof of citizenship, address or date of birth.

Besides all states and Union Territories, the plea has made UIDAI — which is the authority that issues Aadhaar



cards — and Union ministries of home, law and justice, and electronics and information technology as parties.

The plea, filed through lawyer Ashwani Dubey, argued that Aadhaar, originally intended as a proof of identity, has increasingly become a “foundational document” enabling individuals to obtain other identification documents, such as ration cards, domicile certificates and voter identity cards.

“The UIDAI has issued 144 crore Aadhaar cards, and 99



India’s electoral watchdog in eye of a political storm



**ARUN
BHARDWAJ**

From its modest origins in colonial administrative arrangements to its present status as a constitutional watchdog of the world’s largest democracy, the Election Commission of India stands as one of the most critical pillars of India’s institutional framework. Yet, even as it continues to conduct massive electoral exercises with remarkable efficiency, the Commission today finds itself at the centre of political contestation, legal scrutiny, and public debate. The unfolding tensions raise a fundamental question: are India’s democratic institutions being tested, or are they being undermined?

The origins of electoral governance in India can be traced to the Montagu-Chelmsford Reforms, which culminated in the Government of India Act, 1919. This marked the first structured attempt to introduce representative governance in British India. Consequently, elections were held in 1920 and later in 1934, where the Indian National Congress emerged as a dominant political force. However, these elections were conducted under the supervision of provincial governments, lacking neutrality and independence. There was no institutional equivalent of today’s Election Commission. Electoral processes were essentially administrative exercises, vulnerable to executive influence and devoid of constitutional safeguards.

The turning point came with the framing of the Constitution of India by the Constituent Assembly. Between August 1947 and November 1949, extensive deliberations shaped the architecture of a democratic republic. Notably, Part XV of the Constitution (Articles 324-329) was dedicated exclusively to elections—an indication of the framers’ foresight. Article 324 vested the “superintendence, direction and control” of elections in the Election Commission of India. This provision ensured that elections would not be

left to the whims of the executive but would instead be conducted by an independent constitutional authority. The Commission was also entrusted with the preparation and revision of electoral rolls, further strengthening its role as the guardian of electoral integrity.

Initially, the Commission functioned as a single-member body led by the Chief Election Commissioner. However, the constitutional design allowed flexibility for expansion. A significant institutional evolution occurred in October 1993, when the Election Commission was transformed into a multi-member body. This shift was not merely structural but deeply functional, ensuring greater deliberation, checks and balances within the institution.

The tenure of TN Seshan remains a watershed moment in the Commission’s history. Known for his hawkish approach, Seshan redefined the authority of the Commission, in fact exceeded his brief to enforce the Model Code of Conduct with unprecedented rigor and asserting its constitutional mandate. The appointment of additional Election Commissioners such as MS Gill and GVG Krishnamurthy in the early 1990s further cemented the multi-member framework, where all Commissioners were vested with equal powers, ensuring institutional parity rather than hierarchical dominance.

The Commission’s authority is reinforced by statutory backing, particularly the Representation of the People Act, 1950, which governs electoral rolls and voter qualifications. Section 22 of the Act empowers the Commission to revise electoral rolls—an essential function to maintain the integrity of the electoral process. The Commission’s powers have also been consistently upheld and interpreted by the Supreme Court of India, which has recognised Article 324 as a reservoir of plenary powers, enabling the Commission to act in areas where legislation may be silent.

A major development in recent years has been the enactment of the Chief Election Commissioners and Other Election Commissioners (Appointment, Conditions of Service and Term of Office) Act, 2023. The law establishes a selection committee



comprising the Prime Minister, a Union Minister nominated by him, and the Leader of the Opposition in the Lok Sabha. While the framework seeks to institutionalise the appointment process, it has also triggered debates—particularly regarding the exclusion of the Chief Justice of India from the selection panel. Critics argue that this may tilt the balance in favour of the executive, while supporters contend that the presence of the Leader of the Opposition ensures adequate checks.

Recent appointments to the Commission, including Gyanesh Kumar and Sukhbir Singh Sandhu, have not been marred by allegations regarding integrity or competence. Under their supervision, along with Chief Election Commissioner Rajiv Kumar, the 2024 General Elections for the 18th Lok Sabha were conducted. The results themselves present an interesting counterpoint to allegations of bias.

The Bharatiya Janata Party saw its tally decline significantly, while the Indian National Congress registered notable gains. Similarly, in subsequent Assembly elections across multiple states, electoral outcomes reflected a competitive political environment rather than any one-sided trend.

These results raise an important question: if the electoral process were compromised, would such diverse outcomes be possible?

Despite this, the Election

Commission has increasingly become the subject of political criticism. In recent months, spokespersons of the Indian National Congress have publicly targeted the Chief Election Commissioner by name, particularly over the issue of Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of electoral rolls. This criticism is notable for two reasons. First, the Commission is a multi-member body, yet allegations

are often directed at the Chief Election Commissioner alone. Second, the matter is sub judice, and the Commission’s actions are rooted in its constitutional and statutory mandate.

Under Article 324 and the Representation of the People Act, the Commission possesses wide powers to conduct revisions of electoral rolls. Such exercises, while administratively complex, are essential to ensure accuracy and prevent electoral fraud. The controversy reached a new peak with a move by opposition members to initiate impeachment proceedings against the Chief Election Commissioner. The process for removal of the CEC is akin to that of a judge of the Supreme Court, requiring a high threshold of parliamentary support and proof of “misbehaviour” or “incapacity.”

In this context, the landmark judgment in *M Krishna Swami vs Union of India* provides critical guidance. The Court clarified that “misconduct” implies wrongful intention and cannot be equated with mere

Exclusion from temple may divide society, impact Hinduism, says Supreme Court

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Everybody must have access to all temples and ‘maths’ and excluding a denomination will negatively affect Hinduism and divide the society, the Supreme Court on Thursday said.

The remark by a nine-judge bench Constitution bench came while hearing petitions related to discrimination against women at religious places, including the Sabarimala Temple in Kerala, and on the ambit and scope of religious freedom practised by multiple faiths.

The bench comprises Chief Justice Surya Kant and Justices BV Nagarathna, MM Sundresh, Ahsanuddin Amanullah, Aravind Kumar, Augustine George Masih, Prasanna B Varale, R Mahadevan, and Joymalya Bagchi.

Senior advocate CS Vaidyanathan, appearing for



organisations including the Nair Service Society, Ayyappa Seva Samajam, and Kshetra Samrakshana Samiti, submitted that a denominational temple can give permissive rights and have worship or confine it only to the denomination.

At this juncture, Justice Nagarathna remarked, “There is one apprehension. If you say the right of entry, in the context of Venkataramana Devaru, where they said anybody

other than Gowda Saraswat Brahmin is excluded, it will affect negatively Hinduism.”

She added, “Everybody must have access to every temple and math. Keep aside the controversy in Sabarimala judgement. But if you say it is a practice and it is a matter of religion that I will exclude others and only my section, my denomination will attend temple and nobody else. That is not good for Hinduism. Let the religion not be adversely affected. It

will be counter productive for the denomination.”

Concurring, Justice Kumar said such exclusion will divide the society.

Vaidyanathan submitted that if temples serve only their denomination, they cannot seek funds either from the state or private donors or from the public because they are not dependent on them.

If a law is to be made, it has to pass the test of public order, morality or health, he asserted.

In Devaru judgment, the top court had upheld the Madras Temple Entry Authorisation Act, affirming that while the temple remains open to all Hindus, certain ceremonial practices reserved for the Gowda Saraswat Brahmins are constitutionally permissible.

The nine-judge bench has framed seven questions on the scope of religious freedom.

HC rejects Sanjay Bhandari’s plea against ‘fugitive offender’ tag

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

The Delhi High Court on Thursday upheld a trial court’s order declaring UK-based arms consultant Sanjay Bhandari a “fugitive economic offender” in connection with a money laundering case. “Appeal dismissed,” Justice Neena Bansal Krishna said.

On July 5, 2025, the trial court declared Bhandari a “fugitive economic offender” on a plea by the Enforcement Directorate, which enables the agency to confiscate all of Bhandari’s assets worth crores of rupees.

Bhandari’s chances of coming to India have been virtually nullified after a UK court ruled against his extradition.

His legal team, while



opposing the ED’s move to declare him a fugitive offender, claimed its “client’s stay could not be called illegal in the UK as he has a legal right to reside there, and the Government of India is bound by the judgment of the UK court... Bhandari is legally living there, and declaring him a ‘fugitive’ in that scenario is legally wrong”.

Delhi HC refers to mediation dispute over use of Tridev song in Dhurandhar 2

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

The Delhi High Court on Thursday referred to mediation a dispute over the alleged unauthorised use of a song from the 1989 film ‘Tridev’ in ‘Dhurandhar 2’.

Justice Tushar Rao Gedela passed the order on a lawsuit filed by ‘Tridev’ maker, Trimurti Films, against Aditya Dhar’s B62 Studios Pvt Ltd and Super Cassettes Industries Pvt Ltd.

Trimurti Films alleged that Dhurandhar 2’s track ‘Rang De Lal (Oye Oye)’ used Tridev’s track ‘Tirchi Topi Wale’ without due authorisation.

The claim was opposed by the defendants.

Justice Gedela listed the case for hearing on May 6, observing that deciding the issue of granting any interim relief was not required at this stage in view of the studio’s statement that Dhurandhar 2 was unlikely to be released on any OTT platforms soon.

The judge, however, asked the defendants to maintain a record of accounts, as the dispute was “financial” in nature.

“Having regard to the fact that the statement has been rendered on behalf of defendant number 1 (B62 Studios), no order in respect of passing an interim



injunction at this stage as of date is required. However, it is directed that the defendants shall maintain their record of accounts of all the possible and plausible exploitation taking place from the time when the movie was launched i.e. March 19 till the decision is reached by this court,” the court said.

“In the meanwhile, the parties are referred to mediation since they are willing to settle their disputes by referring their matter to mediation. The parties are directed to appear before the Delhi High Court Mediation Centre on April 22,” the court said.

The senior counsel for the plaintiff said

the end credits in Dhurandhar 2 show that the copyright in the song in question ultimately belongs to Trimurti Films.

She further said the song can be removed from the OTT release of the defendant’s film or any other digital platform.

Senior Advocate Akhil Sibal, appearing for Super Cassettes, said the label has the rights over the song and no interim relief should be granted.

He also alleged that the plaintiff suppressed important facts and that songs from Tridev were used in another film even earlier.

Editor's
TAKE

A new chapter in India-Bangladesh ties

The visit of Khalilur Rahman to New Delhi marks the first substantive engagement between India and Bangladesh after a political transition in Dhaka

With the formation of The Bangladesh Nationalist Party (BNP) government in Bangladesh, there is renewed vigour and movement in Indo-Bangladesh relations. Historically, India and Bangladesh have enjoyed synergy and have cooperated on various issues of development and mutual security. However, the Gen Z uprising and the subsequent removal of Sheikh Hasina from the top post changed the equation between New Delhi and Dhaka. Anti-India sentiment prevailed as India allowed Sheikh Hasina to take shelter on its soil. The interim government, headed by Muhammad Yunus, made no bones about showing its displeasure and sought the return of Sheikh Hasina to try her for a plethora of charges levelled against her. However, with the formation of an elected government in Dhaka, some movement towards normalising relations is visible. The visit of Foreign Minister Khalilur Rahman to New Delhi must be seen in this context, and it is more than a routine diplomatic exchange – it signals Dhaka's effort to have better relations with its close neighbour. This engagement is the first real test of how both nations intend to take forward their relations and whether they are willing to overlook irritants and move forward for the betterment of their people. For India, relations with Bangladesh, rooted in historical goodwill, are a strategic necessity.

At the heart of this “reset” lies the question of trust. The Bangladesh Foreign Minister has categorically stated that his government will follow a policy of ‘Bangladesh first’ and would be open to resetting relations on that premise. Dhaka's renewed emphasis on unresolved issues, such as the Teesta River water-sharing agreement, must be dealt with carefully. For Bangladesh, equitable water distribution is not merely a bilateral irritant but a domestic political imperative.

India must take into account the concerns of its neighbors to retain credibility. Incidents of illegal migration and civilian casualties along the border have long cast a shadow over the relationship. A humane and transparent approach to policing the border is essential. Energy cooperation offers a more promising avenue. India is well-positioned to emerge as a reliable partner through electricity exports and infrastructure collaboration. Yet, the diplomatic path to normalisation is mired in difficulties. The extradition of Sheikh Hasina is a complex matter, and New Delhi will have to handle it with caution. Neither nation can afford to let a single contentious issue derail the larger strategic framework. A calibrated, law-bound response, rather than a politically reactive one, must be explored. For New Delhi, the challenge is to strike a balance between reassurance and realism. While extending a hand of cooperation, India must also articulate its core concerns, ranging from cross-border security to regional stability.

The emphasis must be on incremental progress and should reflect a pragmatic recognition that trust is rebuilt gradually, not overnight. The onus lies on both sides to ensure that this diplomatic opportunity does not slip into yet another chapter of missed possibilities.

World Homoeopathy Day: The time-tested wellness recipe

World Homoeopathy Day highlights its role in promoting affordable, sustainable, and inclusive healthcare, advancing holistic wellbeing for individuals and communities globally



PRATAPRAO
JADHAV

As India advances toward the vision of equitable, inclusive and holistic health infrastructure for all, we must ask a fundamental question: how do we ensure that quality care reaches the last person, in the last village, at the right time?

The answer lies not only in expanding infrastructure or deploying advanced technologies, but also in strengthening systems that are inherently accessible, affordable, and trusted by communities. In this context, homoeopathy is emerging, along with Indian traditional medicinal systems, as a quiet yet powerful force-transforming holistic health infrastructure at the grassroots.

Across tribal regions, rural hinterlands, and underserved urban communities, we are witnessing how homoeopathy is bridging critical gaps in healthcare delivery. Its impact is not defined by scale alone, but by its ability to reach where it matters most-the last mile.

World Homoeopathy Day is being celebrated this year as “Homoeopathy for Sustainable Health.” It is an opportune moment to reflect on how this system is contributing not only to individual well-being, but also to building a model for holistic wellbeing that is affordable, environmentally responsible, and socially inclusive.

Developed in the 18th century by Samuel Hahnemann and introduced to India in the 19th century, homoeopathy is based on the principle of Similia Similibus Curentur – “like cures like.” Over the decades, it has evolved into an integral part of India's pluralistic health & wellness system, offering a holistic and patient-centric approach.

What distinguishes homoeopathy at the grassroots is its ability to ensure continuity of care. In many underserved regions, healthcare is not episodic – it is sustained and relationship-driven. Homoeopathy's individualised treatment approach, especially in managing chronic conditions, recurrent infections, and lifestyle disorders, fosters long-term engagement between practitioner and patient. This continuity significantly improves adherence and overall health outcomes.

Today, India has over 290 homoeopathic medical colleges and hospitals, along with a vast network of practitioners across the country. Yet, the true impact of homoeopathy is best understood not in institutions, but in the field-in the tribal districts of Jharkhand, the forested belts of Chhattisgarh, and the remote habitations of Himachal Pradesh, where even a single practitioner can transform community health outcomes. One of the key strengths of homoeopathy lies



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HEALTH &
WELLNESS
PRACTICES

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in its simplicity. Medicines are cost-effective, easy to transport, and do not require complex storage infrastructure. In regions where supply chains are fragile and care personnel are limited, these characteristics become invaluable.

For tribal communities, who constitute a significant segment of our population and often face a disproportionate burden of disease, healthcare must also be culturally aligned. Homoeopathy's gentle, non-invasive approach resonates with traditional healing practices, making it more acceptable and accessible.

Recognising this potential, the Government of India has taken several steps to integrate homoeopathy into mainstream healthcare delivery. Under the National Ayush Mission, more than 12,500 Ayushman Arogya Mandirs (Ayush) have been established, providing comprehensive primary healthcare services, including homoeopathy, at the community level.

Importantly, homoeopathy is also contributing to India's response to non-communicable diseases. The Central Council for Research in Homoeopathy (CCRH) has integrated homoeopathy into national programmes addressing conditions such as diabetes, cardiovascular diseases, and other chronic illnesses-demonstrating its relevance beyond primary care.

Equally encouraging are the innovative delivery models that are taking shape. Co-location of services under Ayushman Arogya Mandirs has improved both access and trust. Mobile medical units are reaching remote populations, while community outreach initiatives and epidemic response programmes have demonstrated the adaptability of homoeopathy in diverse public health scenarios. Perhaps the most scalable model is that of community health workers

trained in basic homoeopathy. When equipped with the right knowledge and supported by referral systems, these workers can significantly expand healthcare coverage at minimal cost. Programmes such as Swasthya Raksha and outreach initiatives led by CCRH have already shown how community-driven approaches can deliver meaningful outcomes. As we look ahead,

the importance of sustainable health & wellness cannot be overstated. Rising healthcare costs, increasing burden of chronic diseases, and emerging challenges such as antimicro-

bial resistance require solutions that are not only effective but also economically and environmentally viable. Homoeopathy aligns naturally with this vision. Its low-cost interventions reduce financial strain on families and public health systems, while its minimal ecological footprint supports environmentally responsible health & wellness practices. Our focus now must be on scaling these efforts-strengthening training in underserved areas, ensuring consistent availability of medicines, promoting rigorous research and documentation, and empowering community health workers.

The vision of Viksit Bharat will be realised only when quality healthcare reaches every citizen, regardless of geography or socio-economic status. Homoeopathy, with its deep community connection and sustainable approach, offers a pathway to achieving this goal.

The true measure of our healthcare system lies not in its most advanced facilities, but in its ability to serve those at the margins. When a simple, affordable intervention brings relief to a family in a remote village, it reinforces a powerful idea-that healthcare in India is becoming more inclusive, more humane, and truly universal.

PIC TALK



People from the Jain community perform the 'Abhishek' as part of rituals on the occasion of 'Vishwa Navkar Mahamantra Divas', in Prayagraj.

PHOTO: PTI

Curiosity, creation, and the quiet instinct to possess



SANJAY
CHANDRA

2ND OPINION

Humans possess an insatiable curiosity, a restlessness that continually pushes them to explore new boundaries. It is this quest that has given rise to newer technologies, enabling progress that often appears both inevitable and admirable. Yet, the same impulse carries within it a quieter, more troubling tendency – the desire not only to discover, but to possess; not only to reach, but to claim what was never inherently theirs, whether it be land, boundaries, or even fellow human lives. Over the past few months, I have come across two pieces of news that, in very different ways, reinforced this belief in the complex duality of human ambition. One of them was about researchers at the Indian Institute of Technology Bombay, who have developed a solar-powered thermochemical battery using strontium bromide-an innovation capable of storing summer heat

and releasing it during the freezing Himalayan winters. It offers a clean and cost-effective alternative to diesel-based heating, especially in remote, high-altitude regions, and holds the potential to significantly improve conditions for the local population, as well as for soldiers stationed in some of the harshest environments on Earth. Here, curiosity manifests as care, as problem-solving, as an extension of human ingenuity directed towards sustaining life. And yet, the same impulse that enables such life-sustaining innovation can, when left unchecked, take on a very different character.

Another development pointed to this more unsettling possibility. It concerned emerging claims over the Moon by countries that have successfully landed spacecraft on its surface – an exclusive and growing club. What appears as exploration often carries the early language of possession, something history has shown us repeatedly. Beneath the language of scientific progress lies a quieter assertion of presence and, eventually, of ownership. The idea of creating “parking facilities” in space, of positioning oneself closer to future interplanetary journeys, echoes-perhaps uncomfortably-the history of terrestrial colonisation, when empires stretched across continents under the guise of discovery, leaving behind legacies that are still being reckoned with. Placed side by side, these developments reveal the paradox at the heart of human progress. The same curiosity that warms a soldier in a Himalayan outpost can

also extend its reach outward, seeking to imprint ownership upon distant celestial bodies. It is not curiosity alone, then, that defines us, but the direction in which we choose to take it – and the restraint, or the lack of it, that accompanies our pursuit. This tendency is not confined to distant frontiers

alone; it continues to shape our conduct much closer to home. One would have thought that the experiences of earlier centuries might have evolved us into a more mature and self-aware race.

Yet, the persistence of sustained conflicts across different parts of the globe in the twenty-first century quietly belies that hope, suggesting that while our technologies have advanced, our instincts perhaps have not kept pace. And yet, it would be too easy-and perhaps too convenient – to conclude that this is all that defines us. The same curiosity that drives us to claim can also compel us to correct, to collaborate, and to care. History, after all, is not merely a record of excesses, but also of gradual learning-of institutions built, of norms negotiated, and of individuals and societies choosing restraint over impulse. If there is hope, it lies not in abandoning our instinct to explore, but in refining it – so that discovery does not inevitably lead to domination, and progress does not come at the cost of our shared humanity.

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RAISING AWARENESS AND BREAKING STIGMA AROUND INFERTILITY

National Infertility Awareness Week (NIAW) is observed from 19-25 April each year to raise awareness about infertility and to support individuals and families facing challenges in having children. It was founded in 1989 by RESOLVE: The National Infertility Association to reduce stigma and encourage open conversations about reproductive health. Seeking timely medical advice and emotional support is of utmost importance.

In women, infertility may be caused by hormonal imbalances (such as irregular ovulation), age-related decline in fertility, conditions affecting the uterus or reproductive system, thyroid disorders, or long-term medical conditions. In men, causes include low sperm count or poor sperm quality, hormonal

imbalances, certain infections or medical conditions, and lifestyle factors such as smoking, alcohol use, or poor diet. Other contributing factors include stress, environmental or workplace exposures, and long-standing illnesses or medications.

Treatment depends on the underlying cause and medical advice. It may include medication, lifestyle changes such as improved diet, exercise, and stress management, assisted reproductive techniques, and counselling. While not all infertility can be prevented, healthy habits, regular check-ups, and early consultation can significantly improve reproductive health and outcomes.

JAYANTHY SUBRAMANIAM | MUMBAI

Please send your letter to the info@dailypioneer.com. In not more than 250 words. We appreciate your feedback.

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

Limits of power exposed

Apologies “A fragile ceasefire and the limits of power,” April 9. The ceasefire announced by Donald Trump in the second month of the war against Iran has brought a much-needed, though fragile, sense of relief across the globe. It comes in the aftermath of alarming statements warning that Iran's entire civilisation could be destroyed-remarks that heightened fears of catastrophic escalation. Such rhetoric, including suggestions that “a whole civilisation could die overnight,” underscores the grave dangers posed by nuclear confrontation and strengthens the urgent call for global nuclear disarmament.

While both the United States and Iran have claimed victory, as is often the case in such conflicts, the war itself appears largely futile. For the United States, widely regarded as the most powerful military and economic force, the episode has exposed limitations and dented its global image. Iran, though battered, has demonstrated resilience and the capacity to respond against a far stronger adversary.

This ceasefire must be more than a pause in hostilities. It should open the door to meaningful dialogue and diplomacy.

N SADHASIVA REDDY | BENGALURU

Accountability through surveillance

Apologies “Centre to SC: CCTV issues in police stations will be settled in 2 weeks” (The Pioneer, April 8), a Supreme Court of India order of 2018 had explicitly directed that police stations be fitted with CCTVs at entry and exit points, near the main gate, in front of the compound, at the back, in lock-ups, lobbies, corridors, and outside washrooms, so that every part of the station is covered.

Obviously, a few states have not adhered to these directions within the mandated timeframe. Reports of non-functional CCTVs across police stations abound. The top court had made station house officers responsible for ensuring that the cameras function properly.

The primary aim of installing CCTVs is to ensure transparency and accountability in policing by preventing custodial torture and excesses.

Misbehaviour towards women, in particular, could be reduced if these systems are properly installed and maintained.

In the past, some personnel rendered CCTV cameras inoperable before engaging in misconduct. Even body cameras and cameras in police vehicles should be made mandatory.

GANAPATHI BHAT | AKOLA

Manipur violence must end

Barbarity has reached its acme in Manipur when a rocket projectile fell on the house of Oinam Babudhan in Bishnupur, killing his two grandchildren – one of whom was an infant. What makes the incident more painful is that the two innocents were asleep when the detonation took place.

Today, the plight of the Manipuri people shows little sign of easing. Precarity and suffering continue to define daily life.

Even when there is a moratorium on violence between ethnic groups, militant atrocities persist. Since the 2023 killings, thousands have been living in around 281-350 relief camps in unhygienic conditions, struggling to meet basic needs. On one hand, children are growing up learning fear as normal; on the other, socioeconomic destruction has pushed lives into jeopardy.

Unfortunately, this incident occurred just as the government was considering developing Jiribam district as a model district. Addressing the root political causes is as essential as security operations. Along with military response and dialogue, building public trust by addressing grievances is crucial to prevent further violence.

KABIR AHMED SAIKIA | ASSAM

Aligning geospatial intelligence with land acquisition reform

The growing disconnect between how land is recorded and how it is valued and acquired is fuelling disputes, delays, and mistrust. Bridging this gap-through modern geospatial technologies and a coherent legal framework-is no longer optional; it is central to sustaining India’s development ambitions

FIRST
Column



VIVEK
KUMAR
SINGH

India’s infrastructure push is no longer incremental; it is transformative. Expressways, freight corridors, renewable energy parks, and expanding urban footprints are redrawing the country’s economic geography. Yet, beneath this ambition lies a persistent bottleneck: land acquisition.

The paradox is stark. While infrastructure planning has become more sophisticated, land acquisition continues to operate through outdated records, fragmented laws, and largely static planning tools. The result is a widening disconnect between how land is understood and how it is acquired.

At the root of the problem is the mismatch between recorded land status and ground reality. In many parts of the country, land classification still depends on revenue records prepared decades ago. Land once recorded as agricultural may now host peri-urban settlements; transport corridors often spawn commercial activity; and previously marginal land may have acquired significant economic value. Yet official records frequently remain frozen in time.

When acquisition proceedings begin, compensation calculations are pegged to these outdated classifications and associated circle rates. The result is a persistent mismatch between recorded land status and actual economic value. This gap lies at the heart of many disputes, fuelling litigation, delays, and mistrust.

A similar disconnect is visible in the planning of infrastructure alignments. Linear projects, viz., highways, railways, and transmission corridors, require careful route selection to minimise both cost and displacement. Ideally, alignments should follow the most efficient path while avoiding dense settlements. In practice, however, routes often pass through habitations or take circuitous paths, increasing both acquisition costs and social disruption.

This challenge becomes sharper when viewed through the distinction between



INDIA’S
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brownfield and greenfield projects. Brownfield projects, such as highway widening, require relatively limited additional acquisition. Greenfield projects require large-scale acquisition and often traverse previously undisturbed areas. Recent policy has increasingly favoured greenfield alignments to improve logistics efficiency. However, these projects also amplify the risks of misaligned routes, avoidable displacement, and speculative land transactions.

Even where detailed guidelines exist, the underlying approach to alignment planning remains constrained. The 2018 framework issued by the National Highways Authority of India, while exhaustive on procedural aspects, continues to rely heavily on Detailed Project Reports (DPRs) prepared by consultants and subsequently certified by administrative authorities. Although the guidelines refer to technologies such as LiDAR and drone surveys, they remain largely silent on the systematic use of Satellite Image Time Series (SITS), AI-driven analytics, GIS-based optimisation, and other advanced

geospatial techniques.

The consequences of these gaps are visible on the ground. For example, even in and around Patna, three major corridors illustrate the limitations of conventional DPR-driven planning. The Patna-Bakhtiarpur stretch displays a distinctly serpentine alignment. The Patna-Koelwar road has witnessed multiple alignment revisions. The Patna-Gaya alignment cuts through a fully inhabited village in Jehanabad. These are not isolated anomalies but are symptomatic of a deeper reliance on static surveys and discretionary planning.

Modern geospatial technologies offer a way out. High-resolution satellite imagery and AI-based terrain and compensation-rate modelling can now allow planners to map land use and infrastructure corridors with far greater accuracy. More importantly, tools such as Satellite Image Time Series can capture how land use evolves over time, helping planners analyse land-use history, anticipate settlement expansion, and avoid future conflict zones.

When integrated with GIS platforms, these technologies enable decision-makers to compare multiple alignment alternatives objectively, using measurable criteria such as distance, terrain, settlement density, and environmental impact. Transparent documentation of such analysis can reduce mistrust and improve public acceptance, which is critical for smoother land acquisition.

Geospatial tools can also improve land-use documentation. Instead of relying solely on outdated revenue records, authorities can use current

imagery to establish the condition of land at the time of acquisition. This provides a more credible basis for compensation and reduces disputes over classification.

The potential of technology extends further to land valuation itself. Several states have attempted to rationalise compensation through updated circle rates and digitised transaction data. However, these efforts remain uneven and often lag behind market realities. AI- and GIS-

The Pioneer
SINCE 1865

From Bargari to Baisakhi: Why sacrilege still shapes Punjab’s political destiny



MONIKA
MALIK

Nearly a decade after the torn pages of the Guru Granth Sahib were found at Bargari in 2015, the anger that followed still lingers-quiet at times, explosive at others. Governments have changed, laws have been promised, and commissions have submitted reports, but the political aftershocks of that episode continue to travel through every election cycle. That is why the Aam Aadmi Party (AAP)-led Punjab Government’s decision to hold a special Assembly session on April 13, Baisakhi, to amend sacrilege laws is not just legislative business. It is a political message wrapped in religious symbolism.

Baisakhi, after all, is not merely a festival in Punjab. It marks the birth of the Khalsa in 1699, a foundational moment in Sikh history. Choosing that day to strengthen sacrilege laws reflects an enduring truth: in Punjab, faith and politics rarely move in separate lanes.

At the heart of the current legislative push lies the ‘Jagat Jyoti Sri Guru Granth Sahib Satkar Act, 2008’, originally enacted by the SAD-BJP government to ensure dignity and proper handling of the Guru Granth Sahib, but long criticised for weak enforcement mechanisms. The law granted exclusive rights to publish the Guru Granth Sahib to the Shiromani Gurdwara Parbandhak Committee (SGPC) and depended largely on regulating printing, storage, and transportation.

The proposed amendments go beyond harsher punishments. The AAP Government is now looking at the digitisation of registered saroops, the introduction of QR codes and bar-coding systems, and mandatory record-keeping of printing, transportation, and storage, aimed at creating traceability and accountability at every stage-an attempt to prevent not just sacrilege, but also the administrative lapses that often precede it.

The disappearance of a “saroop” of the Guru Granth Sahib from Burj Jawahar Singh Wala in June 2015 was disturbing enough. But when torn pages were found scattered outside a gurdwara in Bargari village that October, the outrage was immediate and visceral. Protests spread rapidly across the state. For many Sikhs, it was not simply a crime-it was an attack on the living Guru.

Then came the police firing at Behbal Kalan and Kotkapura. Two lives were lost. That moment transformed public anger into political resentment-against authority, and against the state itself.

For the Shiromani Akali Dal (SAD), which had governed Punjab for a decade by then, the fallout was devastating. The perception that the government mishandled the crisis-both the sacrilege incidents and the protests that followed-began to erode its credibility. The 2017 Assembly election was the first major political test after Bargari, and it showed how deeply the issue had penetrated public consciousness.

The Congress campaign under Capt Amarinder Singh repeatedly invoked sacrilege and police firing incidents, promising justice and accountability. The Akali Dal, once considered nearly invincible in rural Punjab, faced hostility in regions that had earlier been its strongholds. That election marked the beginning of the Akali Dal’s steep decline. Bargari did not destroy the party overnight, but it punctured its aura of control. The party’s Panthic credibility began to weaken visibly after 2017. Even in the years that followed, Bargari remained shorthand for betrayal in political speeches. Successive governments attempted to respond with laws and inquiries. Yet, the pace of justice remained painfully slow.

Punjab has, in fact, seen multiple legislative attempts over the years. In 2016, the SAD-BJP government introduced amendments proposing life imprisonment for desecration of the Guru Granth Sahib and lesser punishments for other religious texts.

In 2018, the Congress Government revised the proposal to include uniform punishment for sacrilege of all religious scriptures, but the Bill has remained pending for years without Presidential assent.

The inquiry process itself unfolded in layers. The SAD-BJP government first constituted the one-man Justice Zora Singh Commission in October 2015 to probe the Bargari sacrilege incidents and subsequent police firing, but its 2016 report was widely criticised as inconclusive and failed to restore public confidence. The succeeding Congress Government then set up the Justice Ranjit Singh Commission, whose findings pointed to serious administrative lapses and recommended action against several officials. Reports were tabled, allegations were made, yet visible closure remained slow.

That gap between promise and outcome gradually created a deeper crisis — one of trust. When the AAP entered Punjab’s political landscape, it capitalised on precisely that sentiment. In the run-up to the 2022 Assembly election, AAP promised swift justice and stricter laws. The promise resonated widely, especially among voters frustrated with years of unresolved cases. Its sweeping victory reflected not just anti-incumbency against Congress, but accumulated anger from the Bargari years.

What makes sacrilege different from other political issues is its emotional permanence. Sacrilege touches identity. It triggers memory rather than

debate. That is why even isolated incidents — such as reports of missing religious texts — revive the older wounds of 2015.

Every few months, the issue resurfaces. And each time it does, the political temperature rises. That lingering sense of unfinished justice is visible in the extraordinary protests the issue continues to inspire. For months, activist Gurjeet Singh Khalsa has remained perched atop a mobile tower in Samana, demanding stricter punishment for sacrilege-a stark reminder of how unresolved grievances continue to shape public sentiment.

Over time, the political conversation itself appears to have shifted. In the years immediately following Bargari, the central demand from Sikh organisations was justice-identification of the accused and accountability for the police firing. Gradually, however, as investigations dragged on and trials slowed, public discourse began to move from demanding justice in specific cases to demanding tougher laws altogether. What began as a call for accountability has, in many ways, evolved into a broader demand for stronger legal protection of the Guru Granth Sahib.

The current government’s move to amend sacrilege laws on Baisakhi must be seen in this context. It is not merely about punishment; it is about reassurance.

The proposed amendments aim to introduce stricter penalties-ranging from long-term imprisonment to life sentences-along with provisions to address newer forms of offence, including digital dissemination of sacrilegious content. The move could revive debate over exclusive protection for the Guru Granth Sahib versus uniform legal safeguards for scriptures of all religions. The real challenge is enforcement. Investigations must be credible, prosecutions consistent, and outcomes visible. Without that, even the toughest law risks becoming symbolic rather than effective. If one were to map Punjab’s electoral trajectory since 2015, sacrilege would appear repeatedly at key turning points. It weakened the Akali Dal after 2017. It remained unresolved under Congress. It helped shape the narrative that propelled AAP to power in 2022. Now, as Punjab slowly moves towards the 2027 Assembly election, the issue is returning to the centre once again. This layered tension ensures that sacrilege will not remain confined to legislative chambers. It will travel into campaign speeches, religious gatherings, and public memory. The coming Baisakhi session will be watched closely-not just for what law is passed, but for what direction it signals. Will it finally restore confidence in the system? Or will it become another chapter in a long history of announcements without closure?

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Economic justice beyond Sterling Biotech



SANGEETA
SHARMA

The Supreme Court’s closure of the Sandesara/Sterling Biotech case in December 2025, following a settlement of ₹5,100 crores, has triggered a debate on economic crime enforcement in India. This development, combined with the Jan Vishwas Reforms, indicates that India may be slowly moving from a purely punitive approach to a more pragmatic framework for economic justice. The Supreme Court treated the Sandesara settlement as a one-time exceptional measure and clearly stated that it should not be treated as a precedent. The Court’s caution was understandable. However, the case highlights a larger structural issue in India’s economic enforcement system, that is, the absence of a formal institutional mechanism for structured financial settlements in large-scale economic offence cases, especially those involving fugitive economic offenders operating outside India.

In many such cases, prosecution becomes prolonged and uncertain due to extradition challenges, jurisdictional complexities, and multi-agency investigations. Legal proceedings may continue for years while public money remains unrecovered. In contrast, structured settlements that ensure large and immediate recovery of public funds may, in certain cases, serve the public interest more effectively than long-drawn criminal trials with uncertain outcomes.

Hence, India does not need ad hoc judicial improvisation in such cases. It needs a statutory institutional mechanism. This is where the idea of an Economic Offence Resolution Authority (EORA) becomes relevant. Such an authority could provide a transparent, rule-based framework for negotiated financial settlements in large-scale economic offences such as corporate fraud, banking fraud, money laundering, and cross-border financial crimes, where recovery and restitution are critical public interest objectives.

This proposal aligns with the broader philosophy behind the Jan Vishwas legislative reforms. Importantly, the Jan Vishwas framework recognises that not every violation should automatically lead to criminal prosecution if proportionate financial penalties, compliance reforms, and administrative resolution can achieve deterrence and recovery more efficiently.

India needs to replicate global best practices. The United States uses Deferred Prosecution Agreements through the Department of Justice. The United Kingdom follows a similar framework through the Serious Fraud Office. France has introduced the CJIP settlement mechanism under the Sapin II law. Brazil operates corporate leniency agreements in corruption cases, and Singapore is developing its own structured settlement framework for financial crimes. These systems do not eliminate criminal liability but allow negotiated settlements under strict regulatory and judicial oversight, ensuring monetary recovery, corporate governance reforms, and compliance monitoring.

In India, however, major economic crime laws such as the Prevention of Money Laundering Act and the Fugitive Economic Offenders Act do not provide any structured settlement mechanism. Enforcement agencies such as the Enforcement Directorate (ED), Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI), Serious Fraud Investigation Office (SFIO), and banking regulators often operate in parallel, leading to fragmented proceedings across multiple legal forums. This not only delays resolution but also reduces the effectiveness of asset recovery.

An EORA could function as an inter-agency statutory body empowered to negotiate settlements, ensure full financial disclosure, mandate penalties and restitution, and require compliance reforms. Settlements could be subject to judicial approval to ensure transparency and accountability. The objective would not be to allow offenders to escape liability, but to ensure that economic justice includes recovery, restitution, and systemic reform.

There are, of course, some concerns. Such a system could weaken deterrence or allow powerful offenders to negotiate their way out of criminal liability. These concerns must be addressed through strict eligibility criteria, transparency norms, mandatory penalties exceeding unlawful gains, and judicial oversight. Efficient enforcement, not leniency, should be the main purpose.

The Sandesara settlement should therefore be seen not merely as an isolated judicial decision but as a policy signal. Combined with Jan Vishwas, it suggests that India’s economic enforcement framework may need to evolve from a purely prosecution-driven system to a recovery-oriented and resolution-based system in appropriate cases.

The Pioneer
SINCE 1865

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GOLD'S PLAYBOOK



Gold's dramatic journey over the past year challenged conventional wisdom, as it delivered both record-breaking highs and sharp corrections. A report by Axis mutual fund, "When Gold Broke the Playbook: Detour in a Long Journey," captures this cycle. The rally through 2025 and early 2026 was nothing short of historic. Prices surged to nearly \$5,600 per ounce. As the report notes, "Precious metals have been on a roller-coaster," with gold benefiting from "safe-haven buying, de-dollarization, easy liquidity, and geopolitical risks." A weak dollar, abundant global liquidity, and strong central bank demand created a perfect environment for gold's ascent. Central banks alone added nearly 1,000 tonnes over three years. The report emphasises that "many emerging market central banks have been ramping up gold purchases to reduce their reliance on the dollar."

However, the rally proved fragile. By Q1-26, gold experienced a steep reversal, falling 20-25 per cent from the \$4,100-4,300 range, which itself was 25 per cent lower than the earlier peak. Indeed, as the report states, "gold had given up all its year-to-date gains... a drop of about 20–25% from the peak." The correction was triggered by unwinding of leveraged positions, while geopolitical tensions drove oil prices higher, and fuelled inflation fears. This led to tighter liquidity, and a stronger dollar. The result was a sharp decline across precious metals, with gold witnessing its steepest weekly fall since 1983.

The report outlines two possible scenarios in the future. In the first scenario, persistently high oil prices may keep inflation elevated, prompting central banks to maintain tight monetary policy. This will support a stronger dollar and higher bond yields, both of which are typically negative for gold. In contrast, if oil prices stabilise, and inflationary pressures ease, expectations of rate cuts can return. This will weaken the dollar, and restore liquidity conditions historically favourable for gold. There are a few early signs of recovery, as "speculative positions have started to build again, anticipating a comeback." This suggests that investors are beginning to re-enter the market at lower levels. Geopolitics will remain another critical variable. Any escalation in global tensions, despite the temporary ceasefire, or risks to growth may revive gold's safe-haven appeal.

Despite the recent volatility, the long-term case for gold remains compelling. The report underscores that the broader narrative has not fundamentally changed: "Gold's 2025 rally was built on trust... [while] the early 2026 sell-off was driven by fear." It concludes that "for now, gold's lustre is tempered by a resurgent dollar and high interest rates. Yet the long-term story... remains intact." In essence, gold's behaviour may have "broken the playbook" in the short term, but its role as a store of value and hedge against uncertainty remains firmly in place.

While the long-term case remains intact, several headwinds could limit upside or even pressure prices in the near term. A stronger US dollar, and higher real interest rates are among the most significant negative factors. If monetary policy remains tighter than expected, gold may face resistance. Improving geopolitical conditions, like the end of the Iran war, can reduce safe-haven demand, leading to softer prices. Similarly, a sustained recovery in equity markets may draw capital away from gold, as investors shift towards higher-growth assets. There is the risk that much of the positive macro narrative may already be priced in. If expectations do not materialise fully, gold can see an ongoing phase of correction or prolonged consolidation. After a strong rally, the possibility of technical pull-backs cannot be ruled out.

Like is the case with crude oil, and other commodities, the bullion's long-term outlook may be constructive, but driven by extreme and sudden volatility. News, events, statements, and hints will drive sentiments, as is the case with the stock markets, and other assets. Hence, in the near term, the yellow metal may go through phases of consolidation or even sharp draw-downs. After a strong rally, periods of sideways movement are not only likely but healthy for the market. In many cases, the sideways turn southwards, as investors react due to fears, doubts, apprehensions, and uncertainties. Rather than expecting a continuous upward trajectory, investors need to prepare for volatility over the next six to twelve months. Obviously, the elevated valuations suggest that future returns may moderate, and price movements can become more range-bound unless they are triggered by major macro or geopolitical announcements and developments. See the ongoing phase as a period of consolidation rather than a reversal of the long-term trend. One can sell on new highs, and buy on lows. Historically, gold has moved in cycles, and such pauses often follow strong upswings.

However, always remember that gold, which was once regarded as only a hedge or safe-haven asset, or for savings, has emerged as an asset class. Its ossession works best as a supporting component, not the main one, within a diversified portfolio. A typical allocation, say experts, needs to be 10-15 per cent, which is considered adequate for most investors, and provides meaningful hedging benefits without overexposure to a non-yielding asset. Hence, do not go overboard on gold, merely because there is a thrill in expectations. In the end, a portfolio needs to incorporate all the assets.

The Pioneer

NEW DELHI | FRIDAY | APRIL 10, 2026



BUSINESS10

Shambolic, slippery, slick street

Investors need to still brood over crude, and be foxed by stocks

Day before, global crude prices plummeted by more than \$14 a barrel, or the largest fall since 2020. In the spot markets, the prices were up yesterday. The Indian Sensex, the Bombay Stock Exchange index, rejoiced the day before, as it catapulted by nearly 3,000 points. Yesterday, it was down by nearly 1,000 points. Rest assured, despite the so-called two-week ceasefire between Iran and the US, which some have dubbed as 'two-weak,' or 'messy,' things may get more difficult in the future. This is because the ceasefire is temporary, various participants are happily breaking it, and the different sides have their own variations of an agreement that has not been disclosed.

Confusion and chaos remain, and this is reflected in what the brokerage houses think of the crude oil prices by the end of this year, and in the next one. The range for 2026, obviously once the war ends, if it does end that is, hovers between a high \$92 a barrel, or just under yesterday's prices, and \$70. The spectrum for 2027, with hopes that there is no way that the war will continue till then, is between \$64 and \$80. In both cases, the range is high, \$22, and \$14, respectively.

There is considerable lag between quoted prices (contract), spot prices (immediate purchases), and futures. According to reports, even as the quoted ones were just over \$100, and came down to the mid \$90s, the spot prices reached as high as \$140, with some grades trading at \$150, or at 10 per cent premium. The latter implies that there is an acute scarcity. The futures market, as is logical, is more sober because traders know that the war will end inevitably. The only problem is when and how. With statements changing

within hours, if not minutes, oil prices are caught between facts, fiction, wishes, and desires. First, let us consider the nature of war and ceasefire. Hours after it was declared, Israel attacked Lebanon, and Iran retaliated. Israel stated that Lebanon was not included in the terms, which was accepted by an US official a few hours later.

Iran claimed that the US had agreed to its 10 points, but violated three of them immediately after the ceasefire. The US claimed to have its 15-point agenda, and future talks would revolve around them, rather than Iran's 10 points. Hence, the terms and nature of ceasefire depend on which side one talks to.

Now, let us turn to possible scenarios if the temporary ceasefire somehow continues, and further peace talks are held in earnest over the weekend, as proposed, in Pakistan. The crude's futures market suggests that "traders still expected the disruption (in supplies) to be temporary, with the possibility of a relatively rapid price correction." This is based on the understanding that while refineries in Saudi Arabia, Kuwait, and Bahrain were damaged, as was the gas infrastructure in Qatar, "much of the core oil production capacity... remains intact." In theory, therefore, oil can flow from the Middle East within days or weeks.

However, some critics maintain that oil and gas flows will be normal over months, possibly years. Qatar has categorically stated that its infrastructure may take years to repair and rebuild. In addition, many nations, which have depleted their emergency strategic reserves, will buy

excess and extra oil. In most cases, the reserve levels will be hiked to prepare for a similar situation in the future. Hence, the demand for crude will be excessively high, at least in the short post-war period. Thus, as supply struggles to gather steam, demand will zoom.

One needs to remember that the Iran war has shown the influence a nation has if it controls the oil supply routes such as the Red Sea, and Strait of Hormuz. This may lead to a deeper shift in the global security networks, logistics, and design. More nations will want to use the same strategy as Iran did. More nations will wish to escape being sucked into the waters at the choke points. The energy transport architecture that has "underpinned energy markets for decades" will undergo massive changes. Supply concerns will shift to security ones.

Until now, the US, along with NATO and the Middle East allies, was seen as the dominant guarantor of the security across the crucial shipping lines. Iran has proved that this is no longer the case. Even regional rebels will have the nerves to disrupt supplies. This may introduce a more persistent and permanent risk premium in oil prices. Despite the end of the war, consumers may continue to pay high prices, maybe in the \$75-85 range, if not the mid-to-high \$90. Thus, more supply may not necessarily translate into extremely-low prices.

Of course, the ceasefire does not imply the end of the war. Indeed, most experts feel that the subsequent negotiations will be more-tricky and complex. It is easier to accept a temporary truce. It is difficult to make it permanent, when the two sides seem rigid and inflexible. "For Iran, the conflict has been existential. For Israel, weakening Iran may be a long-term objective. And US policy goals remain less clearly defined," explains a media report. Add to this the more-blurry aims of the nations in the Middle East, Iran's allies, and powers like Russia and China.

This explains why the temporary truce may enable the stuck oil tankers to leave the Strait of Hormuz, if this happens under Iran's control, one is not sure if the ships will be willing to come back. If the nations, shippers, and insurers remain uncertain about the state of the minds of the negotiators, and, hence, the state of war, the former may not dare to do so. Only the brave and desperate, more the latter, will take the risks. Such doubts and apprehensions will play on the minds of the traders, and the volatility in crude prices will sustain for a longer time.

"A renewal of the conflict represents the worst-case scenario. Sustained high prices would bring back the spectre of inflation, high interest rates, economic slowdown, and growing unemployment. In a global economy already burdened with debt from the Covid crisis, there are few levers left for central banks to tackle this predicament," explains a media report.

In such a situation, sentiments and emotions will rule, as positive news will lead to excitement, and negative one to moroseness. The frequent fluctuations between boom and doom, glee and flee, and cries and rise will only intensify as the days go on.

A Left-Handed Economist

A few days ago, I asked a senior executive of one of the largest importers of raw materials a pertinent question. How does his firm manage to show higher profits, quarter after quarter, whether the input prices go up or down, many times dramatically in this disruptive world? His answer was intuitive, and counterintuitive. "We have an entire team, like a mini-firm, whose only job is to procure inputs at the cheapest possible prices from anywhere in the world," he replied nonchalantly. In effect, the firm houses a mini-national external affairs ministry, or manages a diplomatic think tank that is possibly larger than most nations.

Over the past few years, as trade, tariffs, wars, assets, commodities, bullion, and bonds confound businesses, even CEOs from small firms feel the need to understand the science and art of diplomacy. In a McKinsey discussion last year, a panelist remarked, "The first question I get when I speak to CEOs is, 'How do I get my own intellectual handle on what is going on?' Whereas once they engaged on these topics at a steady but low level, they now realise they need a strong grasp on all these developments, and a 'house view' on which eventualities they need to plan around, at least on a contingency basis."

For decades, large MNCs, especially the global oil giants, have played politics, gamed geopolitics, and participated in diplomacy to protect their strategic assets, and further their operations. In his book, Private Empire, on ExxonMobil, author Steve Coll revealed the true extent of its global power. The book "pulls back the curtain, tracking the corporation's recent history, and its central role on the world stage." It shows how Exxon negotiates with presidents, prime ministers, kings, dictators, policy-makers, experts, civil activists, media, and judiciaries across the globe with a single-minded intention to earn more profits.

In this sense, some of the Indian business leaders, like Aditya Birla, Dhirubhai Ambani, and Ratan Tata were prescient. Since the 1980s, they have perfected the art of collating information from across the globe to understand world affairs, and profit from their insights. The answer that this article started with is another step in the same direction in a journey that started five decades ago. Understanding geopolitics was always crucial for ambitious businesses. Now, the urge and desire have engulfed the small firms, thanks to disruptions in the Gulf. Even a self-sufficient firm needs to understand the global effects.

Of course, one of the problems with this mindset is to get stuck in the short term, and

CEOs think local but act global

Glocal turns into Lobal, as CEOs respond to geopolitical risks

forget about the long horizon. One of the McKinsey participants said that in the fast-paced and fast-changing geopolitics, the focus is on "near-term volatility, and not thinking strategically about the long-term." He added, "Tariffs (or oil prices and supplies) may be the current focus, but leaders should think about how multiple drivers... are evolving, and the interplay between them. They need to develop multiple scenarios... and understand the effect of each... and then assess choices in terms of strategy, capabilities, and talent."

Indeed, business leaders need to use both a microscope to look deeper, and a telescope to seek wider. The former enables them to deal with the issues about the here and now. The latter helps them to spot opportunities of the future that may be blurry at that stage.

"While you are dealing with the short-term issues in the microscope, are you looking enough into the telescope?" questioned a McKinsey participant. The view in the microscope may look bleak, dismal, even dangerous, or force businesses to act promptly. But the view in the telescope may be bright, profitable, and full of markets to occupy.

For example, in several initial discussions in the boardrooms over the past 12-24 months, most businesses concluded that costs will go up, prices of finished products may not rise as fast, and margins will be squeezed. If the finished products' prices are raised, there will be a cut in the market share, which will be gobbled up by the competitors. As the boards probed deeper, and for longer periods, they figured out that the impact of the current situation

may be more severe on the competitors. Hence, if they can ride this out, surf it out, they may be in a better position to hike margins, and garner more market share.

This explains why the thinking processes lead different businesses to evolve varied ways to deal with the situations that seem forever in a flux. The Ambani clan thinks of the short-term, on how to maximise profits daily. In the long term, it is not bothered about missing a bus, train, or flight. It knows that even if it is the last entrant, it has the financial muscle, political influence, and ability to shore up skills and understanding to race ahead. This is what it successfully did in telecom, retail, and tech. The long term sorts out itself in its case.

Others such as Tata think in terms of the future, even as they grapple with the short term. Their eyes are forever on what they can do, rather than what they are doing. Hence, they will swim in murky waters with the sharks, and take risks, as the Tata group did with its audacious and ambitious global takeovers, getting out of businesses, and getting rid of the feudal business satraps. Obviously, some of the ventures did not yield the desired results, and had to be shed.

They take calculated risks, unlike the Ambani family, which revels in post-risk calculations.

Kumar Mangalam Birla moves with steady pace, and assesses risks on a continuous basis. He takes decisions based on multiple inputs, searching here, scouting there, for opportunities and chances. His businesses are rooted in boardroom decisions rather than those that are taken in the corridors of power across the globe. Geopolitics, for Birla, is possibly one of the various available business tools, and not a crucial and overriding political and diplomatic weapon.

Ultimately, based on personality traits, and emerging ecosystem, "CEOs need to understand which geopolitical factors to prioritise... Second, they need analytics to help them decide whether a particular scenario related to those important factors could affect them significantly. If not, do not clutter your thinking; focus on what can meaningfully move your business.... Third, they are putting in place event boards that help them track... (things) that matter. When one of those events transpires, they have plans in place."

The Pioneer

SINCE 1865

Oil prices rise again, world shares retreat on fragile Iran ceasefire

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Hong Kong

Oil rose again and world shares were mostly down Thursday on skepticism over a fragile ceasefire between the US and Iran.

Investors were closely watching whether a two-week ceasefire between the United States and Iran was already slipping after a round of intense Israeli strikes on Lebanon that killed and injured hundreds.

Iran again closed the Strait of Hormuz, in response to the attacks in Lebanon.

In early European trading, Britain's FTSE 100 fell 0.3 per cent to 10,572.73. France's CAC 40 dropped 0.8 per cent to 8,198.77, while Germany's

DAX lost 1.3 per cent to 23,771.68.

Asian shares closed mostly lower. Tokyo's Nikkei 225 dropped 0.7 per cent to 55,895.32, while South Korea's Kospi lost 1.6 per cent to 5,778.01. Hong Kong's Hang Seng fell 0.5 per cent to 25,752.40. The Shanghai Composite index was down 0.7 per cent to 3,966.17. Australia's S&P/ASX 200 edged up 0.2 per cent to 8,973.20. Taiwan's Taiex was 0.3 per cent higher, while India's Sensex dropped 1.6 per cent.

US futures were down more than 0.4 per cent.

Oil prices were up Thursday, reversing an earlier plunge on optimism over the temporary ceasefire



agreement. Brent crude, the international standard, was up 3.5 per cent to \$98.09 per barrel. Benchmark US crude was 3.6 per cent higher on Thursday at \$97.83 a barrel.

Uncertainties over global energy supply remained. The Strait of Hormuz, a choke-point for energy transport where a fifth of the world's oil typically passes, was largely closed even though the US repeatedly demanded that it must be reopened.

"(Oil) prices rebounded as fighting in the Middle East continued, and the ceasefire outlook deteriorated, keeping uncertainty around the Strait of Hormuz firmly in focus," ING Bank analysts Ewa Manthey and Warren

Patterson wrote in a note Thursday.

Talks to pursue a permanent end to the war could start in Pakistan on Saturday, and Vice President JD Vance is expected to lead the US delegation. President Donald Trump posted on his Truth Social media platform that US military will remain around Iran "until such time as the REAL AGREEMENT reached is fully complied with."

Wall Street closed higher Wednesday following Trump's announcement of a two-week ceasefire with Iran late Tuesday.

The S&P 500 jumped 2.5 per cent to 6,782.81. The Dow Jones Industrial Average rose 2.9 per cent to 47,909.92. The

Nasdaq composite was up 2.8 per cent to 22,635.00.

Following renewed hopes over de-escalation of the war, shares of United Airlines surged 7.9 per cent on Wednesday, American Airlines was up 5.6 per cent, while cruise ship operator Carnival jumped 11.2 per cent, trimming losses since the Iran war began on concerns over rising fuel costs.

In other dealings, gold and silver prices fell. Gold's price dropped 0.6 per cent to \$4,750.20 an ounce. The price of silver fell 1.7 per cent to \$74.08 per ounce.

The US dollar rose to 158.95 Japanese yen from 158.57 yen. The euro was trading at \$1.1675, up from \$1.1663.

India turns crises into opportunity; emerges stronger amid global shocks: Shaktikanta Das

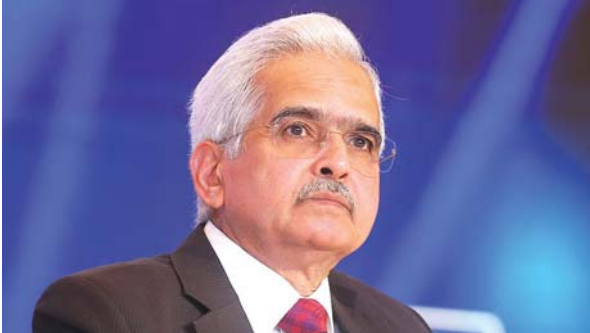
PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

India has consistently shown remarkable resilience during global crises, not only surviving them but also transforming through the turbulence to emerge stronger, said Shaktikanta Das, Principal Secretary to the Prime Minister, on Thursday.

Addressing the AIMA National Leadership Conclave here, Das said, "Through each crisis, India has not merely survived. It has in fact emerged remarkably and measurably stronger".

He noted that the global economy continues to face an "unsettled and charged environment" marked by geopolitical fragmentation, supply chain disruptions and uneven growth, with risks "decisively skewed to the downside".

Against this backdrop, the former RBI governor highlighted India's strong economic performance, stating that real GDP growth stood



at 7.6 per cent in FY26, with an average growth of 7.8 per cent over the past five years. "India's resilience does not alone explain the full story. India did not just endure the period of turbulence. It transformed through it," he said.

He also noted that several factors underpin this resilience, including macro-economic stability, policy consistency, infrastructure-led development and strong domestic demand.

The top official emphasised the importance of inflation control, describing it as critical for economic stabil-

ity. "Inflation has often been described as a tax on the poor. A low inflation would mean increasing the spending power in the hands of the consumer," Das said.

Highlighting India's policy response during crises, he said the country adopted a calibrated approach. "Fiscal and monetary expansion were followed by a timely rollback, thus froth was not allowed to accumulate or overrun the system".

Das also pointed to structural transformations in the economy, including rapid digitalisation, expansion of infrastructure and growth

in manufacturing sectors, such as electronics and semiconductors.

On the external front, he said India's strategic autonomy and diversified partnerships have reduced overdependence on any single country.

"We take decisions in our best national interest," he said.

He further described India as a safe anchor in a volatile global environment, offering stability, predictability and long-term growth prospects.

"India is now seen as a safe anchor at a time when much of the world is marked by conflict, volatility and policy uncertainty," he said.

Looking ahead, Das said India's growth drivers, ranging from demographic advantage and rising consumption to infrastructure push and digital public infrastructure, are structural and durable.

"These are not cyclical tailwinds. They are structural, compounding and durable," he said.

India able to navigate current global crisis due to matured democracy: Scindia

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

India has been able to navigate the current global situation due to a matured democracy, diplomacy, diversification and decisive action, Union Minister Jyotiraditya Scindia said on Thursday.

Speaking at an AIMA event, Scindia said Indian vessels have been moving through Strait of Hormuz to reach Indian shores.

"The current instability has sent shockwaves through the global system. Shockwaves that have disrupted supply chains, erupted geopolitical tensions. At the same time, energy markets have been fundamentally affected, it is in this environment where energy is our backbone that India has been able to navigate these very choppy waters," Scindia said.

He said the Prime Minister over the last four weeks has put in place a structured system to be able to navigate the unsurmountable problems and to convert those into opportunities.



Union Minister for Communications Jyotiraditya Scindia attends the 'National Leadership Conclave' marking All India Management Association's (AIMA) Platinum Jubilee in New Delhi on Thursday

"India today has been able to put in place engagement across multiple nations. Our Indian vessels are today moving through Strait of Hormuz, reaching the shores of India, and at the same time, ensuring that all constituencies within India are protected from this volatility. This speaks of maturity of our democracy, a maturity across diplomacy, diversification, and decisive execution," the minister said.

Talking about the telecom sector, Scindia said the Government is spending over ₹1.39 lakh crore to connect

every village with broadband service and more than half of it is to maintain the optical fibre network for the next 10 years.

"A 10 per cent increase in broadband growth capability across the country ₹1.39 lakh crore being spent by Government of India to connect every single village across the length and breadth of our country with optical fibre network. 45 per cent of the money is for capex and 55 per cent to be able to maintain that fibre for next 10 years," Scindia said.

He said in the next 5 years

or the next decade, another \$15-2 trillion will be added to the GDP in terms of opportunity.

The communications minister said India Post has 1.6 lakh branches and his ministry is on the road to transforming this vast network into a logistics powerhouse.

"A logistics powerhouse not only for India, but it is our ambition and our commitment, a logistics powerhouse for the world. On March 17, we launched three new products. 24-hour Speed Post, 48-hour Speed Post. These speak of commitment," Scindia said.

He said that in the past fiscal, FY25-26, the Department of Post is expected to have registered a double-digit growth rate. "I have a passion and a relationship from the heart with this department. 4.6 lakh Grameen Daak Sevaks have resolved that we will move from being a cost centre to Government of India to hopefully being a profit centre to the Government by 2029-2030," Scindia said.

UP will reach one trillion dollar economy before 2035: ASSOCHAM Secy-Gen

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Lucknow

ASSOCHAM Secretary-General Saurabh Sanyal said here on Thursday that Uttar Pradesh will reach the one trillion-dollar economy before 2035, looking into the way it was progressing as far as investment was concerned.

Sanyal was in the city to participate in the Uttar Pradesh Manufacturing Conclave organised by ASSOCHAM at a city hotel.

Talking about the investment climate currently prevailing in the state, he said that Uttar Pradesh has accelerated as far as the GSDP is concerned. "From 13.3 lakh crores in the financial year 2017, it has grown to 36 lakh crores, which is a phenomenal jump in 2026. I am sure that Uttar Pradesh will reach its target of a one trillion-dollar economy, which is the aspiration of CM Yogi, before 2035, the way they are progressing, that will be much before the Viksit Bharat target," he said.

He noted that the key reforms that have made the biggest impact in recent years in the State have

been the sectoral strength — the services have grown to 46 per cent, the tourism, real estate, financial services, hospitality, and agriculture have grown to 27 per cent, there has been improved productivity and irrigation facilities. Also, there has been diversification of the industries and the setting up of semiconductor manufacturing facilities, which are emerging technologies.

"By the next decade or so, UP will be the manufacturing hub of India. It is also leading in electronics manufacturing. UP is also launching ODOP 2.0, which will also be a massive success story," he added.

He stressed that the most important reform in the state has been the ease of doing excellent business. "UP is already amongst the top five States where the ease of doing business is absolutely remarkable. If an industry is set up in UP within 1000 days, hundred per cent licenses will be cleared, which is a great achievement. This reform has not happened in any other state except Gujarat," he said.

He emphasised that UP is the preferred destination for investment.



"There are fifty lakh crores of investments which are in the pipeline that are coming not only from the domestic side but also from the FDIs," he stated.

Talking about ASSOCHAM's focus as far as UP is concerned, he noted that ASSOCHAM has always been with the UP industries and that they have been promoting industries right from the word go.

"We have been connecting the industries to the Government of Uttar Pradesh, and we have sorted out their pain points. ASSOCHAM is acting as the intermediary between the Nivesh Mitra and the industry.

Out of the 96 lakh MSMEs in UP, fifty per cent are members of ASSOCHAM." He further stated that they were here for policy advocacy, policy intervention and for social and economic development.

"We are also exposing all the schemes of the Government to the industries. ASSOCHAM is planning a mega 12th Conclave on MSMEs in May this year in UP", he said.

Commenting on the key challenges faced by the MSMEs in the state, he said it is their fiscal management and the problems related to the payments made to the MSMEs, even though the Government has stipulated a time frame of forty-five days.

"Another challenge is the adaptation to technology. MSMEs are not well-versed in the emergent technologies. If they implement AI, automation, and machine learning, they will be a huge flip to their progress, and they will be at par with the MSMEs of the world. This can be addressed by skill development," he added.

Asked if any bottlenecks were affecting the growth of industries

in the State, he said that there were no stumbling blocks, and one of the major achievements of the state was the single window clearance.

On the top priorities they would recommend to the Government in the next two to three years, he said that they would stress on automation and training of the industry in artificial intelligence, because these were the tools that would give a tremendous boost to manufacturing.

"Secondly, we will request the industry to go to the farms so that the produce can be bought, processed and exported immediately right from the farms. There is enough space in the farmlands where factories can come up," he added.

He admitted that though these were the best of times, they were also the worst of times with the West Asian crisis going on. "We hope that this war gets over as it has certainly impacted the industries since the Industrial gas is not reaching, and the industries are getting shut temporarily pan India."

World Bank raises India's FY27 GDP growth projections to 6.6%; flags West Asia risks

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

The World Bank has marginally raised India's growth projections for 2026-27 fiscal to 6.6 per cent and said that although GST rate cuts would boost consumer demands in the initial months of the fiscal, headwinds arising from the Middle East crisis could dent growth.

The FY27 projection compares with estimates of 6.9 per cent by the RBI, 6.1 per cent by the OECD, and 6 per cent by Moody's Ratings.

In its South Asia Economic Update report released on Wednesday, the World Bank said India's growth is estimated to have accelerated from 7.1 per cent in FY25 to 7.6 per cent in FY26 (April 2025-March 2026), owing to strong domestic demand and export resilience.

Private consumption growth was particularly



robust, supported by low inflation and rationalisation of the Goods and Services Tax (GST).

"Growth is projected to decelerate to 6.6 per cent in FY27, reflecting headwinds from the Middle East conflict," it said.

Although the reduction in GST rates should continue to support consumer demand in the first half of FY27, elevated global energy prices are expected to put upward pressure on prices and constrain

households' disposable income, it said. Government consumption growth is expected to soften to set higher subsidy outlays for cooking fuel and fertilizers. Investment growth is likely to moderate amid elevated uncertainty and rising input costs, the World Bank said.

Improved access to the United States and the European Union for India's exports will be undermined by slower growth in major trading partners, it added.

Sensex tumbles 931 points, Nifty plunges amid fading confidence

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Mumbai

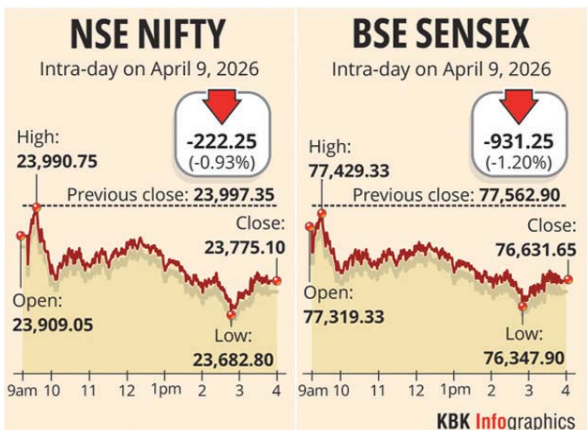
Equity benchmark indices ended lower on Thursday, with the Sensex tumbling 931 points after a spectacular rally in the previous session, as renewed tensions in West Asia faded the ceasefire-led optimism.

The ceasefire deal appeared to be at risk after Iran closed the Strait of Hormuz again in response to Israeli attacks on Lebanon.

Weak trends in Asian and European markets, a jump in crude oil prices and uninterrupted foreign fund outflows also made investors jittery in the domestic market.

The 30-share BSE Sensex dropped 931.25 points or 1.20 per cent to settle at 76,631.65. During the day, it dived 1,215 points or 1.56 per cent to 76,347.90.

The 50-share NSE Nifty



declined 222.25 points or 0.93 per cent to end at 23,775.10.

From the 30-Sensex firms, InterGlobe Aviation, Larsen & Toubro, Eternal, HDFC Bank, ICICI Bank and Kotak Mahindra Bank were among the major laggards.

Bharat Electronics, Power Grid, NTPC and Tata Consultancy Services were

among the gainers. Brent crude, the global oil benchmark, jumped 3.27 per cent to \$97.85 per barrel.

In Asian markets, South Korea's benchmark Kospi, Japan's Nikkei 225 index, Shanghai's SSE Composite index and Hong Kong's Hang Seng index ended lower after a sharp rally in the previous trade.

Rupee falls 9 paise to close at 92.63 against US dollar

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Mumbai

The rupee depreciated 9 paise to close at 92.63 (provisional) against the US dollar on Thursday, as the situation in West Asia remains fragile, keeping investors wary of the opening of the Strait of Hormuz.

Forex traders said geopolitical uncertainty was still high amid Iran's threat to step out of the talks if Israel kept bombing Lebanon, and markets are in a wait-and-watch mode rather than strong directional positioning.

At the interbank foreign exchange market, the rupee opened at 92.63 against the US dollar, then lost ground to touch an intraday low of 92.92 against the greenback. It also hit the day's high of 92.53 during the session.

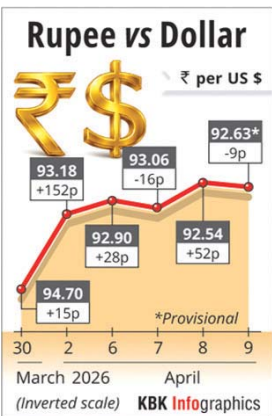
At the end of the trading session on Thursday, the rupee was quoted at 92.63 against the American currency, registering a decline of 9 paise over its previous close.

On Wednesday, the rupee appreciated 52 paise to close at 92.54 against the US dollar after US President Donald Trump announced the suspension of military strikes against Iran for two weeks, and the Reserve Bank kept the key benchmark rate unchanged with a neutral stance.

Forex traders said the fragile ceasefire and Iran's threat to step out of the talks if Israel kept bombing Lebanon weighed on investor sentiments.

Iran closed the Strait of Hormuz again in response to Israeli attacks in Lebanon. The White House demanded that the channel be reopened and sought to keep peace talks on track.

Meanwhile, the dollar index, which gauges the greenback's strength against a basket of six



currencies, was down 0.12 per cent at 99.01. Brent crude, the global oil benchmark, was trading higher by 3.08 per cent at \$97.67 per barrel in futures trade.

"The Indian rupee's five-day rally came to a grinding halt, retreating in tandem with its Asian peers. The currency faced a double whammy of rising crude prices and relentless selling by foreign investors. Domestic equities saw a 23rd consecutive session of net selling by Foreign Institutional Investors, maintaining steady pressure on the local rupee," Dilip Parmar, Senior Research Analyst, HDFC Securities, said.

Spot USD-INR is expected to trade within a range of 92.50 to 93.40, as traders balance global energy risks and domestic capital outflows, Parmar added.

On the domestic equity market front, Sensex tumbled 931.25 points to settle at 76,631.65, while the Nifty plunged 222.25 points to 23,775.10. Foreign Institutional Investors offloaded equities worth ₹2,811.97 crore on Wednesday, according to exchange data.

Meanwhile, India's Foreign Secretary Vikram Misri met senior US officials in Washington and discussed ways to further deepen the defence and trade relations and exchanged views on the developments in the Indo-Pacific and West Asia.

South Korea's Joint Chiefs of Staff said the missiles launched on Wednesday flew 240 to 700 km before falling into the sea, and that it also detected at least one projectile launched on Tuesday from an area near the North Korean capital of Pyongyang.

IMF strikes staff-level deal with Sri Lanka

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Colombo

Sri Lanka and the International Monetary Fund (IMF) have reached staff-level agreement on economic policies to conclude the combined fifth and sixth reviews of the island nation's reform programme, the global body said in a statement on Thursday.

An IMF team was in Sri Lanka from March 26 until April 9 to conduct the combined fifth and sixth reviews of Sri Lanka's reform programme supported by the global lender's Extended Fund Facility (EFF).

The two tranches together will release \$700 million from the \$2.9 billion bailout in 2023. The IMF noted that ongoing economic reforms implemented by Sri Lankan authorities have supported the country's recovery, with foreign reserves increasing and both real GDP growth and revenue mobilisation exceeding expectations.

"Sri Lanka's ambitious reform agenda continues to deliver commendable outcomes. The economy grew by 5 per cent year on year in 2025. Inflation has returned to positive territory and rebounded to 2.2 per cent year on year in March, and gross official reserves reached US \$7 billion in end-March 2026,"the IMF statement said in Colombo at the end of their visit.

Fiscal performance in 2025 was strong, primarily supported by taxes on motor vehicle imports. Debt restructuring is nearing completion, with the successful completion of Sri Lankan Airlines' debt exchange and further progress in finalising remaining bilateral agreements.



turing is nearing completion, with the successful completion of Sri Lankan Airlines' debt exchange and further progress in finalising remaining bilateral agreements.

"Sri Lanka is significantly exposed to the West Asia conflict, which has heightened energy prices, disrupted a key air hub for tourists, and affected Sri Lankans working in the region,"it said. "Authorities have ameliorated disruptions to economic activity by securing sufficient fuel supplies for households and industries. At the same time, the country needs to address the infrastructure and spending needs caused by Cyclone Ditwah."

"Heightened downside risks to the economy from disaster risks, persistent trade policy uncertainty and the conflict in the Middle East emphasise the urgency to accelerate the reform momentum to safeguard macroeconomic stability, enhance Sri Lanka's resilience to shocks, and maintain the economy on a path toward recovery and inclusive growth."

Israel-Lebanon talks likely next week

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Washington

Israel-Lebanon negotiations are expected to begin next week at the State Department in Washington, according to a person familiar with the plans.

The talks are expected to be handled on the American side by US Ambassador to Lebanon Michel Issa, and on the Israeli side by Israel's Ambassador to the US Yechiel Leiter, according to the person, who spoke on condition of anonymity due to the delicacy of the situation. It was not immediately clear whom Lebanon was sending. Axios first reported the timing and location of the talks. Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu said Thursday that he has authorised direct negotiations with Lebanon "as soon as possible."

Netanyahu said he gave the order in response to requests from Lebanon and that talks would focus on disarming Hezbollah and establishing peaceful relations between the neighbouring countries. He welcomed a call by Lebanon's prime minister to demilitarise Beirut.

There was no immediate response from Lebanon. Abdul Malik al-Houthi, leader of the Iran-backed Houthi rebels in Yemen, described the announced ceasefire between the US and Iran as a "big victory" for their biggest battles in Lebanon. Al-Houthi added that his group was able to prevent Israel and the US from using the Red Sea to attack Iran and confirmed launching strikes at Israel.



Rescuers rescue an injured man from a destroyed building that was hit in an Israeli airstrike in central Beirut, Lebanon

Iran In a video statement on Telegram on Thursday, he said Iran ultimately was able to "defeat the enemy".

He also praised the militant Hezbollah group, saying that they are leading one of

their biggest battles in Lebanon. Al-Houthi added that his group was able to prevent Israel and the US from using the Red Sea to attack Iran and confirmed launching strikes at Israel.

Looking forward to Indian trade delegation: Gor

SAGAR KULKARNI
■ Washington

US Ambassador to India Sergei Gor on Thursday met Trade Representative Jamieson Greer and said he looked forward to welcoming the Indian delegation later this month to discuss the trade deal.

Gor is currently on a visit to the US. The US Ambassador said he had a "highly productive meeting" with Greer.

"Highly Productive meeting with @USTradeRep Ambassador Greer to discuss advancing POTUS trade priorities in South and Central Asia," Gor said in a post on X. "The United States and India have previously agreed to a trade deal, and we look forward to welcoming an Indian delegation to Washington later this month," he said.



Vikram Misri launched the India-US Trade Facilitation Portal here as the two countries eye the \$500 billion bilateral trade target.

India and the US announced a framework for

an interim trade agreement in February, after months of negotiations between the two delegations.

This is a framework that promotes reciprocal and mutually beneficial trade, enhances market access and strengthens supply chain resilience immediately through expanded preferential access, rigorous rules of origin and addressing non-tariff barriers across various sectors.

On Tuesday, Gor met India's Ambassador to the US Vinay Mohan Kwatra, who said both sides are pursuing robust efforts to achieve the goals set by their leaders for the strategic relationship between the two countries. (PTI)

Philippines opens base in disputed South China Sea

JIM GOMEZ ■ Manila

The Philippines unveiled a major coast guard base Thursday on an island in the South China Sea to serve as a "steadfast sentinel of our sovereignty" in a disputed region closely guarded by China's forces.

Chinese officials did not immediately react to the Philippines' opening of its coast guard district command on Thitu Island, which has been occupied by Filipino forces and civilians for decades but is also claimed by Beijing.

Chinese coast guard and other Government-linked ships frequently patrol outlying waters off the island, which is also claimed by



Vietnam and Taiwan. Chinese and Filipino forces have had tense but mostly minor confrontations in outlying waters in the past.

China claims virtually the entire sea, a key trade route, despite a 2016 arbitration

ruling that invalidated its expansive claims under the 1982 UN Convention on the Law of the Sea. Beijing did not participate in the arbitration, rejected its outcome and continues to defy it. Philippine Transport

Secretary Giovanni Lopez, Sen Erwin Tulfo and coast guard commander Adm Ronnie Gil Gavan flew to Thitu to unveil the command in a brief ceremony, which was held to coincide with the country's Day of Valour commemoration.

"This is a permanent step for us to show that our coast guard is ready to defend our interest in the waters, our fishermen, their livelihood and, most importantly, our sovereignty," Lopez said.

A marker in the new coast guard building said it was "established as the vanguard and steadfast sentinel of our sovereignty, sovereign rights and maritime jurisdiction."

The coast guard command will be led by a commodore

and backed up by a number of personnel, patrol ships and aircraft for law enforcement, monitoring, environmental protection and search and rescue. Smaller coast guard outposts would be built on smaller Philippine-occupied outcrops, the coast guard said.

Surrounded by white beaches, the tadpole-shaped Thitu Island is called Pag-asa - Tagalog for hope - by about 400 Filipino villagers. It's one of nine islands, islets and atolls which have been held by Philippine forces since the 1970s.

More than a decade ago, China started transforming seven disputed reefs into island bases in the Spratlys. Those included Subi Reef,

now a major island base with a military-grade runway about 24 kilometres south-east of Thitu island.

"Everyday, our villagers see Chinese coast guard and militia ships all around the island," MP Albayda, who serves as the vice mayor of the island municipality, told The Associated Press. "This new coast guard district command is a big morale booster for them."

The Philippines claims the region as its most remote offshore township, under its western island province of Palawan. It encouraged fishing families to relocate there decades ago with incentives such as free rice, to underscore its control over the area. (AP)

World's oldest octopus fossil is not an octopus after all: Scientists



JILL LAWLESS
■ London

A 300-million-year-old tentacled sea creature has lost its crown as the world's oldest octopus, after scientists found evidence that it's not an octopus at all.

Newly published research concludes that fossilized remains listed by Guinness World Records as the earliest known octopus belong instead to a relative of a nautilus, a cephalopod with both tentacles and a shell.

University of Reading zoologist Thomas Clements, the lead researcher behind the new findings, said the fossil, *Pohlisepia mazonensis*, has long been the subject of scientific debate.

"It's a very difficult fossil to interpret," he said. "To look at

it, it kind of just looks like a white mush.

"If you look at it and you are a cephalopod researcher and you're interested in everything octopus, it does superficially look a lot like a deep-water octopus."

The creature, a blob about the size of a human hand, was found in the Mazon Creek area of Illinois, about 50 miles southwest of Chicago, that is rich in fossils from a period before dinosaurs walked the Earth. Its identification by paleontologists as an octopus in 2000 upended ideas about the evolution of the eight-tentacled cephalopods, suggesting they emerged much earlier than previously thought. The next oldest-known octopus fossil is only about 90 million years. (AP)

Four migrants die crossing English Channel



ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Equihen Beach

French authorities said that at least four people, two men and two women, died on Thursday as they were trying to get onboard an inflatable boat to attempt the perilous sea crossing from northern France to the UK.

The prefect of the Pas-de-Calais region in northern France, Francois-Xavier Lauch, said 38 others were rescued, including one whose condition involved medical emergency. He spoke while rescue operations were still ongoing on Equihen Beach on Thursday morning. Lauch said migrants were carried away by dangerous currents as they were trying to embark on a

"taxi-boat," the name authorities use for small motorised boats, usually inflatable, used by traffickers to pick up people along large stretches of the northern French coast.

Thursday's incident happened along a broad expanse of sand, backed by dunes and a forest where people attempting the perilous crossing hide out, sometimes for days at a time, as they wait for boats and suitable weather and sea conditions. Police patrol on buggies and keep watch from the remains of World War II-era bunkers but cannot prevent all departures on a beach so long. Attempted crossings and deaths have surged in recent days.

Sri Lankan police repatriate 125 telecom fraud suspects to China

KJM VARMA
■ Beijing

Sri Lankan police have repatriated 125 suspected criminals back to China for their involvement in telecom fraud, the Chinese Ministry of Public Security (MPS) said on Thursday. The suspected criminals had been apprehended during earlier crackdown operations.

These suspects were repatriated on March 29 with the support of the Chinese Embassy in Sri Lanka and Chinese police, according to the MPS.

The joint operation was a result of deepened international law enforcement cooperation between



Chinese and Sri Lankan police to intensify crackdown efforts on cross-border telecom fraud, the MPS said.

China's security officials claim to have "completely dismantled" telecom fraud

networks in Myanmar and Cambodia. Thousands of people in India, China and several other countries were defrauded by these gangs operating on the Thai-Myanmar border and in Cambodia. (PTI)

Benin's presidential election amidst security concerns

VIRGILE AHISSOU/ MARK BANCHEREAU
■ Cotonou (Benin)

Voters in Benin will vote Sunday to elect a new president as outgoing leader Patrice Talon steps down after a decade in power with a mixed legacy of economic growth, but also a growing jihadi insurgency in the north and a clamp down on the opposition and critics.

Romuald Wadagni, the 49-year-old finance minister and governing coalition standard-bearer, is considered Talon's anointed successor.

Wadagni is being challenged by Paul Hounkpe, the sole opposition candidate. In the parliamentary election in January, the opposition failed to cross the 20 per cent elec-

toral threshold required to win seats, leaving Talon's two allied parties in control of all 109 seats in the National Assembly and in good position before Sunday's vote.

Renaud Agbodjo, leader of The Democrats, was barred from competing after failing to secure a sufficient number of parliamentary endorsements - a threshold critics say was engineered to keep rivals out.

With the main Opposition sidelined, Wadagni is widely considered a favorite due in part to his strong economic track record and broad support from influential figures across historically rival camps, said Fiacre Vidjngninou, political analyst at the Lagos-based Behanzin Institute. "Ten years at the



Finance Ministry have given him something rare in African politics: a quantified record - verifiable and difficult to dismantle in a serious debate," Vidjngninou said.

The first round of the vote is set for April 12. In order to secure an outright victory, the winner would need to secure at least 50 per cent of the votes. If that doesn't happen, a runoff will be conducted on

May 10 between the top two candidates. Nearly 8 million people are eligible to vote in the election.

Wadagni is campaigning heavily on the country's economic performance during his decade as finance minister. Benin's economy grew 7 per cent last year, according to the International Monetary Fund, making it one of West Africa's steadiest performers.

Under Talon, the country sustained robust growth for nearly a decade, driven by agriculture, trade and a major port expansion in the economic hub Cotonou that turned Benin into a key transit point for landlocked neighbors. Infrastructure has also expanded.

However, the gains have been unequally shared, with poverty remaining widespread in rural areas and in the poorer northern region.

While Benin has historically been among the most stable democracies in Africa, Opposition leaders and human rights organisations have accused Talon of using the justice as a tool to sideline his opponents, after taking office in 2016 and changing electoral rules. (AP)

Republican fears grow as Democrats keep notching election victories ahead of midterms

SCOTT BAUER/ JEFF AMY/ JONATHAN J COOPER
■ Madison

The bluntest assessment of Republican failures during this week's elections in Wisconsin came from one of their own.

"We got our butts kicked," said US Republican Tom Tiffany, who is running for governor. He was referring to Democratic victories in campaigns for the Wisconsin Supreme Court and the mayor's office in Waukesha, a conservative suburb outside of Milwaukee.

But some Republicans were also rattled by a Georgia special election, where their

candidate to replace Marjorie Taylor Greene in Congress won by a much slimmer margin than the party enjoyed in the past.

Taken together, the swings from red to blue added more data points to an increasingly clear picture of Democratic momentum heading into the November midterms, when control of the US House, US Senate and state Governments around the country are up for grabs.

"In rural, urban, red, blue, Democrats have overperformed everywhere," said Jared Leopold, a Democratic consultant whose clients include Keisha Lance Bottoms, a candidate for

Georgia governor. "That is a significant canary in the coal mine about what November of '26 is going to look like." Some Republicans insisted there was no need to panic, and their fundraising remains stronger than Democrats. Stephen Lawson, a Georgia strategist, said "the sky is not falling."

But he also said his party is running behind where it has been in the past, and Republicans need to be "looking at these results carefully." Special elections can be notoriously unreliable as political benchmarks, but Democrats have consistently demonstrated surprising strength. They flipped a Texas



US Republican Tom Tiffany

State Senate district. They won a Florida state House seat in a district that includes President Donald Trump's Mar-a-Lago resort in Palm Beach. Then they gained ground on Tuesday in the

race to replace Greene, who resigned from Congress in January after a falling out with Trump.

Clay Fuller, the Republican candidate, prevailed by 12 points. Two years ago, Greene

won by 29 points and Trump carried the district by almost 37 points. "That's a red alarm for Republicans," said Democratic strategist Meredith Brasher.

Fuller defeated Shawn Harris, who plans to challenge him again in November. Jackie Harling, the district's Republican chairwoman, said she believed that Greene's resignation energized Democrats while her party is suffering from "election fatigue." "Marjorie Taylor Greene was like a freight train that you couldn't stop, and when she pulled out, it gave Democrats hope and it gave them a shot at winning something they believed was

unwinnable," Harling said. Georgia has key races this year, including an open contest for the governor's office. Senator Jon Ossoff, a Democrat, is trying to defend his seat as well.

There's reason to think that simmering discontent could boomerang back on Republicans just two years after Trump harnessed voters' anger with his comeback presidential campaign. In November, Democrats defeated two Republican incumbents in statewide races for seats on the Public Service Commission, which regulates utilities. Rising electricity rates have been a fault line in recent campaigns, especially as enor-

mous data centers are built to power artificial intelligence. But Georgia Democratic Party Chair Charlie Bailey is trying to maintain modest expectations. "We could cement ourselves, put ourselves, on the slightly bluer side of purple," he said. "We're not going to overnight turn into Colorado."

Wisconsin holds statewide elections for supreme court seats, and liberals expanded their majority with a 20-point blowout victory on Tuesday. Democrats saw gains in red, blue and purple counties when compared to another judicial race last year, which was also won by the liberal candidate. (AP)

India will become green fuel exporter: Gadkari

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Union Minister Nitin Gadkari on Thursday said India will become an exporter of green fuels instead of being an importer of fossil fuels. “Green hydrogen is the future,” Gadkari said and mentioned that the government is working on a project to run hydrogen buses and trucks on 10 routes across the country in partnership with auto and fuel companies.

He pointed out that Indias breakthrough in making nuclear energy with thorium, which is abundantly available in the country unlike uranium, will boost low-cost power production. Earlier, thorium was being used in making roads since the knowhow to turn it into energy was lacking, he said.

Speaking at the 11th National Leadership Conclave organised by All India Management Association (AIMA), the minister pointed out that India imports fuels worth ₹22 lakh

crore each year and it could save that money and put that into the domestic economy by turning to green fuels.

Gadkari advocated more and more production and use of biofuels to reduce imports and to boost the agriculture economy. “India cannot become atmanirbhara until agricultures share in its GDP rises to at least 24-25%,” he said. According to him, turning food into fuel and agri waste into road construction material will enrich farmers and lower Indias import dependency. He mentioned that India imports about 60 lakh tonnes of bitumen each year for building roads and its prices have shot up during the current war in west Asia. That dependence will be eliminated by using bio-bitumen made with rice straw, he said.

He espoused the cause of circular economy and said that India could have a waste economy worth ₹5 lakh crore. He referred to various



(L-R) Vineet Agarwal, Vice President, AIMA and Managing Director, Transport Corporation of India Ltd; Vishal Kampani, Senior Vice President-AIMA and Vice Chairman & Managing Director, JM Financial Ltd; Nitin Jairam Gadkari, Minister of Road Transport & Highways, Government of India; T V Narendran, President, AIMA and CEO & Managing Director, Tata Steel Ltd and Rekha Sethi, Director General, AIMA

commercial deals involved use of recycled toilet water by power plants and oil refineries, and use of steel sludge in building roads. He favoured importing used

rubber tyres for making road building material and imported scrapped cars from overseas to draw materials to make automobiles in India.

TV Narendran, President, AIMA and CEO & Managing Director, Tata Steel Ltd concurred with the minister and mentioned that his company is contributing sludge for

road making. He highlighted the impact of energy and material supply disruption on Indian economy and industry due to the war in west Asia and emphasised the need for growing the domestic economy to make it more resilient.

During the session, Gadkari presented AIMA Fellowship to Yezdi Nagporewalla, CEO, KPMG in India, and Dr JS Juneja Award for Creativity and Innovation in Micro, Small & Medium Enterprises to Algo8AI, an industrial AI firm.

The session was also addressed by Sanjiv Puri, Chairman, AIMA Excellence Award Jury and Chairman & Managing Director, ITC Limited. Vishal Kampani, Senior Vice President, AIMA and Vice Chairman & Managing Director, JM Financial Ltd delivered the vote of thanks, and Vineet Agarwal, Vice President, AIMA and Managing Director, Transport Corporation of India Ltd introduced the minister in the session.

DMRC, BEML sign deal to bid, build metros in India, abroad



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi Metro Rail Corporation (DMRC) and BEML Limited have signed a Memorandum of Understanding (MoU) to jointly collaborate on Metro rail projects in India and abroad. The partnership focuses on identifying, bidding for, and executing projects by combining BEMLS rolling stock manufacturing strength with DMRCs expertise in metro system execution and operations.

The MoU was signed by Dr PK Garg, Director (Business Development), DMRC and

Rajeev Kumar Gupta, Director (Rail & Metro), BEML Ltd. on 8th April, 2026 at Metro Bhawan in the presence of Dr Vikas Kumar, Managing Director, DMRC and Shantanu Roy, Chairman & Managing Director of BEML and other senior officers of DMRC and BEML.

On the occasion, Dr Vikas Kumar, Managing Director/DMRC described the agreement as a historic collaboration between two leading Indian entities, emphasising its potential to significantly enhance urban mobility systems in India and abroad.

SRMIST signs MoU with Ather Energy; Launches Ather Forge initiative with donation of electric vehicles

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Kattankulathur

SRM Institute of Science and Technology (SRMIST), Kattankulathur, has partnered with Ather Energy in a first-of-its-kind collaboration that brings electric mobility directly into the academic ecosystem. The partnership was formalised through a Memorandum of Understanding (MoU), alongside the handover of three electric scooters to support research, innovation, and hands-on learning on campus.

This initiative also marks the launch of the Ather Forge programme, a campus-integrated learning and industry engagement model introduced by Ather Energy, with SRMIST being the first university in India to host this initiative.

Designed as a campus ambassador and experiential

learning programme, Ather Forge goes beyond conventional academic frameworks by enabling students to engage deeply with real-world engineering challenges. Participants will have the opportunity to work directly on Athers proprietary scooter technology, ranging from battery systems to intelligent dashboards, while transforming academic concepts into tangible prototypes under industry guidance.

The programme aims to bridge the gap between theoretical knowledge and practical application by enabling students to work directly with EV systems, including both hardware and software components. It will also feature a specially designed curriculum, encouraging interdisciplinary learning and innovation. Students will not only gain exposure to real-time problem-solving but will also be mentored to convert



SRMIST and Ather Energy sign the MoU in the presence of delegates from both institutions

their ideas into proof-of-concepts aligned with industry needs.

Importantly, the initiative creates a direct pathway to internships with Ather Energy, where selected students can undertake industry training for durations ranging from six months to one year, gaining immersive experience in electric mobility and

product development.

The MoU signing ceremony was held at SRMIST in the presence of senior leadership from both institutions, faculty members, and students. The event included the formal exchange of the MoU and the handover of the electric vehicle for academic and research use.

Speaking on the occasion,



Dignitaries from SRMIST and Ather Energy during the handover of three electric vehicles

Arief Ahmed Shariff, Head – Talent Acquisition, Fulfilment and University Relations, Ather Energy, said: “As a company that originated from a campus ecosystem, we strongly believe in nurturing young talent and fostering innovation at the academic level.

This collaboration is aimed at equipping students with

practical, industry-relevant skills while enabling them to explore electric mobility through direct interaction with our technology. We are particularly proud to initiate this programme with SRMIST, marking our first such collaboration in the country.”

Dr S Ponnusamy, Registrar, SRMIST, added: “This initiative will signifi-

cantly augment our existing infrastructure in electric vehicle research and benefit both our faculty and students. We look forward to leveraging this partnership to further advance innovation and research in sustainable mobility.”

Highlighting the academic and industry relevance of the initiative, Dr Leenus Jesu Martin M, Dean, Faculty of Engineering and Technology, SRMIST, stated: “The collaboration with Ather Energy represents a significant step towards strengthening experiential learning for our students. The Ather Forge programme, along with the donation of electric vehicles, will enhance research capabilities in our electric vehicle laboratories and provide students with valuable industry exposure.

Through initiatives such as internships, curriculum co-development, and faculty

immersion, this partnership will help us align academic outcomes with evolving industry requirements.”

The collaboration will primarily benefit students from engineering disciplines such as Electrical and Electronics Engineering, Mechanical Engineering, and allied fields.

Ather Energy, a leading electric vehicle manufacturer in India, has maintained a long-standing relationship with SRMIST through campus engagements and recruitment initiatives. This MoU further strengthens the partnership, paving the way for future collaborations in research, innovation, and skill development.

The initiative aligns with SRMISTs commitment to fostering industry partnerships that enhance employability, encourage interdisciplinary learning, and drive technological advancement in emerging domains.

DAILY SUDOKU

	6			2		
9			5 4 6		8	
			3			5
7					3 6	
		3		1	5	
5 8						2
3				4		
	2		1 8 9			7
		7			1	

DIFFICULTY RATING: ★★★★★☆

HOW TO SOLVE IT

Sudoku is a logic puzzle where you fill a 9×9 grid so that numbers 1 to 9 appear once in every row, column, and 3×3 box, using elimination and logical deduction—no maths involved.



SOLUTION (09.04.26)

6	4	1	7	2	8	3	5	9
7	3	8	9	5	1	4	6	2
5	2	9	4	3	6	1	8	7
1	5	3	2	8	9	7	4	6
2	7	4	1	6	5	9	3	8
9	8	6	3	7	4	2	1	5
4	6	7	5	1	2	8	9	3
8	9	2	6	4	3	5	7	1
3	1	5	8	9	7	6	2	4

DOUBLE CROSSWORD FRIDAY | APRIL 10, 2026

1			2		3		4		5		6
		8		9							
10						11		12		13	
		14				15		16			
17	18				19		20				
					21				23	24	25
26		27					28				
29							30				
							31				
32											
							33				

ACROSS

- As a companion for one, you can take your pick (6)
- Teacher possibly due to become an actor? (8)
- Do her friends call her “Bud”? (4)
- Frustrated at fencing? (6)
- Not exactly unfair? (6)
- In Elizabethan times, it was chancy (3)
- ABC etc. (5)
- A rotten red (4)
- Meant to create as an artist (5)
- More sensible form of snare (5)
- Is this bone the humerus? (5)

DOWN

- He’s on board for the sport (6)
- A colourful girl (6)
- Play the first card after a misdeal? (4)
- It’s used for patient examination (7)
- A local provision just a street away (5)
- Kids who could play the part of Bart Simpson? (5)
- Do spare ones help keep you lean? (4)
- Hardened up like some white stuff (3)
- Write down a bit of a banjo tune (3)
- A figure that’s small, still (5)
- Did it taste heavenly? (5)
- Does he turn a hair, possibly? (5)

- Real property, money also (4)
- Didn’t lie down for a day, out of bed (3,2)
- Possible swinger with a hangup! (3)
- Former Liberal leader; bit of an author, perhaps (6)
- Finished in court, in secret (6)
- Victim of economy cuts? (4)
- Sort of affairs a politician can get involved in (8)
- Make fewer points (6)

- There’s many a one in our race (3)
- He made history in long gone years (3)
- Encourage to consume strong drink? (7)
- Can it help keep the kettle warm? (3)
- They simply adore leftovers! (6)
- Lying in one (4)
- Keep in date somehow (6)
- Piece torn off? (5)
- Sounds the horn, sweetheart (5)
- Sort of seat to contest? (3)
- Necessity to use the phone (4)

Dalcore to bring luxury branded homes in Gurugram

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Gurugram

Dalcore, a new-age real estate developer, on Thursday announced the launch of The Falcon, an ultra-luxury branded residential development on Golf Course Road, Gurugram. Positioned as North India’s first branded residences by YOO, the globally renowned design-led brand founded by John Hitchcox and Philippe Starck, the project introduces a new paradigm of design-led living to the NCR luxury housing market.

Located in Sector 53 on Golf Course Road, one of Gurugram’s most prestigious and well-connected addresses, The Falcon is envisioned as a globally benchmarked residential landmark that seamlessly integrates architecture, interiors, and lifestyle design.

The projects interiors have been designed by YOO Inspired by Starck, with architectural planning / exterior architectural planning led by internationally acclaimed firm UHA, bringing together global design intelligence and local contextual sensitivity in a single, cohesive vision.

Commenting on the launch, Sidharth Chowdhry, Managing Director, Dalcore, said, “The Falcon represents a defining moment for Dalcore as we introduce North India’s first YOO-branded residences.

This project reflects our commitment to bringing globally celebrated design philosophies to India’s most discerning homebuyers. With YOO Inspired by Starck’s design vision and UHA’s architectural expertise, we are creating a residential landmark that goes beyond conventional luxury to offer a deeply curated living experience rooted in design, innovation, and long-term value.”

Sharing his perspective as YOO Inspired by Starck Creative Director, “Philippe Starck” said, “In the beating heart of one of the most prestigious and ever-developing neighbourhoods in India, The Falcon is a visionary YOO Inspired by Starck project—a rare haven of elegance and privacy.”



JITF INFRALOGISTICS LIMITED
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Website: www.jindalinfra.logistics.com, E-mail: contactus@jindalinfra.logistics.com

NOTICE OF THE EXTRA ORDINARY GENERAL MEETING

Notice is hereby given that the Extra Ordinary General Meeting (“EGM”) of the Company will be held on **Wednesday, 06th May 2026 at 12.00 Noon** at A-1, UPSIDC Industrial Area, Nandgaon Road, Kosi Kalan, District Mathura-281403, (U. P.) to transact the business as set out in the Notice of Extra Ordinary General Meeting. The Notice of EGM has been sent to the members who hold shares as on record date, i.e., 03rd April 2026, by email, whose email is registered with the Company/Depository(s) and the physical copy to all the other members. The said documents can also be viewed on the company’s website at www.jindalinfra.logistics.com.

Further, pursuant to the provisions of section 108 of the Companies Act, 2013 read with rule 20 of Companies (Management and Administration) Rules, 2014 and regulation 44 of SEBI (Listing Obligations and Disclosure Requirements) Regulations, 2015, the Company is providing remote e-voting facility to its members to cast their vote electronically on the resolutions to be transacted at EGM of the Company.

The member please note the following:

- The remote e-voting shall commence at 9.00 a.m. on Sunday, 3rd May 2026 and shall end at 5.00 p.m. on Tuesday, 05th May 2026.
- The remote e-voting shall not be available beyond 5.00 p.m. on Tuesday, 05th May 2026.
- The cut-off date for determining the eligibility of members for remote e-voting and voting through poll at EGM is 29th April 2026.
- Any person who becomes member of the Company after dispatch of notice of the meeting and holding shares as on cut-off date i.e. 29th April 2026, may obtain the user id and password by contacting RCMC Shares Registry (Pvt.) Ltd., R & T Agent of the Company at B-25/1, Okhla Industrial Area Phase II, New Delhi – 110020, phone- 011-26387320-21, Fax- 011-26387322, Email- evoting.services@rcmcdelhi.com.
- The members who cast their vote through remote e-voting may also attend the EGM but shall not be allowed to cast their vote at EGM.
- The facility of voting through poll shall be available at the EGM to those members who have not casted their vote through remote e-voting.
- Members may go through the e-voting instructions provided in the EGM Notice or visit <https://evoting.nsdl.com> and in case of any queries, you may refer the Frequently Asked Questions (FAQs) for members and e-voting User Manual for members available at the download section of <https://evoting.nsdl.com>

For JITF InfraLogistics Limited
Sd/-
Alok Kumar
Company Secretary
ACS-19819
Place: New Delhi
Date: 09.04.2026

BRIEFLY

Leicester loses appeal against points deduction



Leicester has lost its bid to overturn a six-point deduction imposed for breaching spending rules. The ruling keeps Leicester, which defied 5,000-to-1 odds to win the Premier League title a decade ago, one point from safety in the second-tier Championship with five games left in the season. The deduction was imposed in February after the Foxes were found to have breached the English Football League's financial rules in the 2023-24 season, which saw it promoted to the top flight. The Premier League said in a statement Wednesday that the sanction "has been upheld by an independent Appeal Board." Leicester on Monday missed a chance to move out of the relegation zone by settling for a 1-1 draw with last-place Sheffield Wednesday. "With the matter now at an end and five games of the season remaining, everyone at the club is fully focused on the matches in front of us and on shaping the outcome of our season through our results on the pitch," Leicester said in a statement Wednesday. "We know this has been a challenging period," it continued, "and we thank our supporters for the backing they continue to give the team. The responsibility now is to ensure these remaining games are approached with the focus and intent our current situation demands."

Hernandez penalty earns Real Betis a 1-1 draw



Cucho Hernandez converted a penalty for Real Betis to salvage a 1-1 draw with Braga in the first leg of their Europa League quarterfinal on Wednesday. Before the kickoff, players and fans observed a moment of silence to honor Mircea Lucescu, the Romanian soccer great who died this week. Hernandez beat Lukas Hornicek from the spot in the 61st minute after the goalkeeper had saved the Colombia striker's header in the first half. Florian Grillitsch put the hosts up 1-0 early with a heel shot off a corner kick in what UEFA said is a record 98th game for Braga in Europe's second-tier competition. Braga is seeking a semifinal for the first time since 2011 when the Portuguese club reached the final. The other three quarterfinal matches will be played Thursday: Aston Villa at Bologna; Nottingham Forest at Porto; and Freiburg hosts Celta Vigo.

Atletico wins 2-0 against 10-man Barcelona

JOSEPH WILSON
■ Barcelona

Atletico Madrid scored twice after Barcelona was reduced to 10 men to earn a valuable 2-0 road win and take the advantage in their Champions League quarterfinal on Wednesday. A superb free kick by Julian Alvarez and a second goal by Alexander Sorloth gave Diego Simeone his first win at Camp Nou since Atletico's long-standing coach started his stint with the club 15 years ago. "I don't think my Atleti had ever won at Camp Nou," said Simeone, whose Atletico had won at Barcelona when it played at the Olympic Stadium in 2024 but never at

Camp Nou. "They're arguably the best team in Europe, along with Paris (PSG) and Bayern (Munich). Through good teamwork, we were able to capitalize on key moments in the match." Barcelona had hemmed Atletico into its box when the hosts received a double blow that left Hansi Flick's team down a man and behind a goal just before halftime. The game-changing sequence started when Atletico's Giuliano Simeone broke free to latch onto a rare long ball and Barcelona defender Pau Cubarsi knocked him down on the edge of the area with only goalkeeper Joan Garcia to beat. After initially showing



Cubarsi a yellow card, the referee changed it to a red following a video review. It got worse for Barcelona seconds later when Alvarez curled the resulting free kick around the defensive barrier

and past a flying Garcia for the 45th-minute lead. Lamine Yamal and Marcus Rashford tried to rally Barcelona at Camp Nou and kept the pressure on Atletico despite being undermanned.

Prosecutors to subpoena Woods' prescription drugs

MIKE SCHNEIDER
■ Orlando (Florida)

Prosecutors are seeking Tiger Woods' prescription drug records from a pharmacy, a week after his vehicle crashed in Florida and he was arrested on suspicion of driving under the influence. Prosecutors in Florida on Tuesday said they planned to issue a subpoena seeking copies of all prescription medication records for the legendary golfer on file at Lewis Pharmacy in Palm Beach, Florida from the start of the year through the end of last month. Prosecutors in Martin County, Florida, want the times the prescriptions were



filled, the number of pills, the dosage amounts and any instructions that accompanied the pills, such as warnings about driving while taking them, according to documents in an online court docket. Any objections to the subpoena must be filed with the

State Attorney's Office within 10 days. Neither Lewis Pharmacy nor Woods' attorney, Doug Duncan, immediately responded to emails seeking comment. Woods pleaded not guilty in his driving under the influence case in Florida last week, hours after a sheriff's report said deputies found two pain pills in his pocket and he showed signs of impairment after his SUV clipped a trailer and rolled over on its side. Woods was traveling at high speeds on a beachside, residential road on Jupiter Island with a 30 mph (nearly 50 kph) speed limit when the accident occurred, authorities said. The truck had \$5,000 in

damage, according to an incident report. Woods agreed to a Breathalyzer test that showed no signs of alcohol, but he refused a urine test, authorities said. Woods said last week that he is stepping away to seek treatment. It's the second time Woods has taken a leave following a car crash. In 2009, after his SUV plowed into a fire hydrant and tree outside his home near Orlando, he took a leave of absence to work on being a better person. That lasted four months and he returned at the Masters. He also was in a 2021 car crash in Los Angeles that damaged his right leg so badly he said doctors considered amputation. (AP)

Global women's sports revenue to top \$3b



ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ New York

Global women's sports revenues are projected to exceed \$3 billion in 2026, a significant increase over the \$2.4 billion in revenues generated in 2025, according to a report released Wednesday. The report produced by accounting firm Deloitte said women's sports revenues internationally have increased 340% over the last four years. That has spurred investment in the women's sports ecosystem, which in turn drives further growth but also raises the expectations of fans, athletes, investors and business partners. "Women's sports are entering a new phase — one defined by scale, structure, and sustained investment," Alicia Hatch, Deloitte's US Sports chief commercial officer and women's sports leader, said in a statement. "Rising valuations and expanding revenue streams are consistent with a maturing market where leagues, sponsors, and media partners are building for long-term success." The report, "Game Changers: Unlocking the

Potential of Women's Sports," looks at three main types of revenue: commercial, broadcast and matchday. Commercial revenue makes up the greatest share at 45%. Soccer and basketball are expected to be the top revenue-generating women's sports, with each accounting for 35% of overall revenues. New competitions, like Unrivaled Basketball, and new leagues, including the Canadian Northern Super League in soccer, are driving growth. Most of the revenue globally in 2025 was generated by North America (53%), followed by Europe (16%) and that trend was expected to continue this year. But Deloitte also cited the 2025 Women's Rugby World Cup, which drew a record 82,000 fans to the final in London, as well as last year's Women's Cricket World Cup. In North America, eight new women's leagues have been launched since 2020. "Women's sports are thriving and defined by real, transformative growth and a rapidly expanding global fan base," said Lara Abrash, chair of Deloitte US.

Kvaratskhelia scores as PSG beats Liverpool

JEROME PUGMIRE
■ Paris

Ousmane Dembele had an off night but Khvicha Kvaratskhelia added another solo goal to his collection as Paris Saint-Germain beat Liverpool 2-0 in the first leg of their Champions League quarterfinal on Wednesday. The Georgia star cut in from the left flank midway through the second half and, with typically quick feet, skipped past a defender and the goalkeeper before stroking in his team-leading eighth goal of the competition. "We had chances to score more," Kvaratskhelia said. "But I think it's OK, 2-0 is good but we have to stay concentrated." Desire Doue put the defending champions ahead in the 11th minute with a



deflected effort. The Ballon d'Or winner Dembele then spurned three chances at Parc des Princes. PSG coach Luis Enrique said his side should have scored more. "It's a pity, clearly, we played very well and deserved more goals," he said, adding that he was surprised that Liverpool played so defensively. "It's the first time under Arne Slot that they

have played with five defenders this season." Accepting his team was outplayed, Slot explained his decision to be so cautious. "They have pace from everywhere all over the pitch, no matter where you look," he said. "They have so many weapons (and) the times when we tried to play high and aggressive they ripped us apart." When the

two teams met last season in the round of 16, PSG advanced on penalties after losing 1-0 at home and winning 1-0 at Anfield. The task seems less difficult this time around for PSG with Liverpool facing a trophyless season. However, six-time champion Liverpool overcame a 3-0 first-leg loss against Barcelona in the 2019 semifinals before winning 4-0 at home. The second leg is next Tuesday at Anfield. "I've been through many special evenings at Anfield," Liverpool captain Virgil van Dijk told TNT Sports. "Our fans are the backbone of the club, and hopefully they can be there for us again." It could be another busy night for Liverpool, even at home. "We're not going there to defend, that's not in our mentality," Luis Enrique said. (AP)

8-year-old Frankie Fleetwood steals the show

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Augusta

Eight-year-old Frankie Fleetwood stole the show at Augusta National from his dad, Tommy Fleetwood, who merely had one of the many holes-in-one Wednesday during the family friendly Par 3 Contest on the eve of the Masters. The young Fleetwood went viral last year when he lamented in a post-round interview that he couldn't clear Ike's Pond, which fronts the ninth green on the par-3 course. So all eyes were on him this year, even after Tommy had aced the fourth hole an hour earlier. "I'm not so confident," Frankie admitted, "but honestly on the range this after-



noon I felt good, so I feel like I got a chance." Frankie made solid contact with his tee shot on the 120-yard hole, but he was off line and the ball splashed right of the green. As he slumped in disappointment, the crowd packed shoulder to shoulder around the eighth and ninth holes imploded

him to take a mulligan, so Frankie reteed and took another big swing. This time, the ball missed the green by a couple of feet. "Nearly got it. A few inches, maybe," Frankie said. "He was happy with his shots, and he was so close as well," Tommy said. "Another year, right, Frank?"

As for the competition itself, Aaron Rai birdied the last four holes to shoot 6 under and win the Par 3 Contest, though that may not be such a good thing. Nobody who's won the event has gone on to win the Masters in the same year. Justin Thomas aced the second hole, Wyndham Clark had a hole-in-one on the seventh and Keegan Bradley, his playing partner, aced the eighth hole, becoming the first player in Masters history to make a hole-in-one in consecutive years in the Par 3 Contest. Ex-NFL lineman Jason Kelce (Akshay Bhatia) and comedian Kevin Hart (Bryson DeChambeau) were among the celebrity caddies. "It's a special day," Thomas said. "It's really fun. Obviously

a beautiful day. And hopefully just a great start to a great week." **Thinking of the Middle East:** Fleetwood and his family moved from England to Dubai in 2022 and settled at the Jumeirah Golf Estates, where he runs the Tommy Fleetwood Academy. But when war escalated in the Middle East, and bombs began falling in the United Arab Emirates as he played in the US, Fleetwood was able to get his family on a flight back to England. They joined him at Augusta National for the Masters this week. "The main thing is hoping that everybody is always safe," Fleetwood said, "whether that be family, friends, whatever is going on — students — whatever that is.

Golf has been secondary for Scheffler

NOAH TRISTER
■ Augusta (USA)

Scottie Scheffler's son Bennett turns 2 next month, and Remy was born less than two weeks ago. Neither is old enough to understand the significance of Augusta National, the Masters and the green jacket their father sometimes wears. "His wife Meredith) got this great picture of me and Bennett walking into the clubhouse with me with my green jacket and holding his hand. But, I mean, he has no idea what it means," Scheffler said. "This place signifies so much for me in my golf journey, and that's something I'd love to be able to share with my kids. We'll see



how that goes as they age. "Right now I just — if I'm wearing it near him, I'm just hoping he doesn't ruin it or anything like that." Scheffler has two kids — one for each of his Masters titles. He's the favorite in this week's tournament, as he tends to be for all majors these days, but his family life

has been more exciting than his golf recently. The Scheffler who tore through the 2025 season, winning six times in a 4 1/2-month span, hasn't arrived yet this year. It was business as usual when Scheffler won his first tournament of the year at The American Express in January. (AP)

PSG rests, others chase Champions League spot

JEROME PUGMIRE
■ Paris

With Paris Saint-Germain given the weekend off to prepare for its trip to Liverpool in the Champions League, there will be no top-of-the-table clash against Lens this weekend. The French league controversially postponed the 1st vs. 2nd encounter following a request from PSG. Initially set for April 11, it fell between PSG's two quarterfinal legs against Liverpool and will now be played on May 13. Victory would have allowed Lens — which opposed the change — to close the gap to one point on leader PSG, which has played



one less game. Instead, the focus this weekend will be on the battle for third place, which secures automatic entry into the Champions League next season, while the team in fourth enters

qualifying. It promises to be an exciting race to the line with Lille, Marseille, Monaco, Lyon and Rennes all in contention. Third-placed Lille and seventh-placed Rennes are separated by three

points with six rounds left. Key matchups: Fourth-placed Marseille and fifth-place Monaco are level on points. Marseille needs to bounce back from last weekend's loss to Monaco with a home win over rock-bottom Metz. Monaco is on a seven-game winning streak in the league as it heads to face Paris FC. Both games are on Friday. Rennes hosts Angers on Saturday while Lille goes to midtable Toulouse on Sunday. Sixth-place Lyon bids to end a nine-match winless run in all competitions when it hosts Lorient on Sunday. The goals have dried up for Lyon with only three scored in the past six games. (AP)

Liverpool's season is on the brink

JAMES ROBSON
■ London

Just one year ago Liverpool was closing in on a record-tying 20th English league title. Now coach Arne Slot is in a battle to salvage the season and, perhaps, save his job. A 4-0 defeat to Manchester City last week saw Liverpool crash out of the FA Cup. And a 2-0 loss to Paris Saint-Germain on Wednesday has pushed the Merseyside club to the brink of a Champions League exit in the quarterfinals. Add to that a title defense that unraveled early in the campaign and it is little surprise that speculation has mounted regarding Slot's future even after he delivered



the Premier League title in his first year in charge. After defeat in Paris, Slot admitted his team was in "survival mode". His situation has not been helped by the availability of Xabi Alonso, the

former Liverpool player who was regarded as a leading candidate to succeed Jurgen Klopp when the club icon stepped down as manager in 2024. Alonso is a free agent after being fired by Real

Madrid this season and his stock remains high after winning the German title with Bayer Leverkusen. While Liverpool has given no indication that Slot's job is at risk, the Dutchman has acknowledged that failing to secure a spot in next season's Champions League would be unacceptable. The best chance of qualifying for the competition appear to be via Liverpool's finishing position in the league, with England's top flight set to be given a bonus fifth spot because of its teams' performances in Europe this season. But even that is not guaranteed for Liverpool, which currently sits fifth, just one point above Chelsea. (AP)

Badoni, Choudhary help LSG beat KKR by three wickets

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Kolkata

Lucknow Super Giants defeated Kolkata Knight Riders by three wickets in an Indian Premier League match here on Thursday.

Opting to bowl, LSG restricted KKR to 181 for four.

Angkrish Raghuvanshi (45 off 33 balls), skipper Ajinkya Rahane (41 off 24 balls), Rovman Powell (39 not out off 24 balls) and Cameron Green (32 not out off 24 balls) were the major contributors for the home side.

For LSG, Digvesh Singh Rath (1/25) was the pick of the bowlers.

Chasing 182, LSG rode on Ayush Badoni's 34-ball 54 and Mukul Choudhary's brilliant

27-ball 54 not out to cross the line in a last ball thriller.

For KKR, Anukul Roy (2/32) and Vaibhav Arora (2/38) were the main wicket-takers.

Earlier in the innings, Lucknow Super Giants clawed their way back with a disciplined middle-overs bowling effort to restrict Kolkata Knight Riders to 181 for 4 in their IPL clash here on Thursday.

Sent in to bat, KKR, who were searching their first win of the season, were cruising at 98/1 at the halfway mark, with skipper Ajinkya Rahane and the in-form Angkrish Raghuvanshi in full flow.

The duo added 84 runs off 52 balls and looked set to power the home side past 200 after Finn Allen (9) fell for



a second successive single-digit score.

However, a smart mix of spin and tidy pace bowling triggered another familiar middle-overs slump for KKR who lost three wickets between overs 11 and 14.

Rahane (41 off 24 balls; 4x4, 2x6) fell to spinner Digvesh Rath with Mohammed Shami completing a fine low catch, while Raghuvanshi (45 off 33 balls; 5x4, 2x6) holed out to long-on in the very next over off left-arm spinner Maniraman Siddharth.

The slide worsened when Avesh Khan returned strongly after an expensive start to clean up Rinku Singh (4) with a sharp back-of-a-length delivery that seamed away, leaving KKR without a bound-

ary for 30 balls.

KKR slipped to 115/4 in 15 overs, once again exposing their fragility in the middle phase.

A late flourish from Rovman Powell (39 not out off 24 balls; 4x4, 2x6) ensured KKR score a competitive total, while Cameron Green (32 not out off 24 balls; 3x4, 1x6) finally had his best show after intense scrutiny as the highest paid (Rs 25.20-core) overseas cricketer in the IPL.

But the LSG bowlers led by Shami (27 runs from 4 overs with nine dot balls) were outstanding.

Rathi was the most tidy with 1/25, while Siddharth returned with 1/34.

Earlier, Rahane set the tone with an aggressive approach,

showcasing exquisite timing and intent, while Raghuvanshi continued his rich vein of form, playing the perfect foil.

The youngster, fresh from back-to-back fifties, combined fluency with composure as the pair recovered after Finn Allen's early dismissal.

Allen's wicket, however, was not without controversy as he top-edged one to deep third, where Rathi completed a tricky back-peddalling catch close to the ropes, with the umpires opting not to review the boundary call.

KKR had a slow start with 18 dot balls in the first five overs but recovered through Raghuvanshi's counterattack against Avesh, finishing the powerplay at 56/1.

You cannot fault David Miller's intent, says Sunil Gavaskar

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

Former India captain Sunil Gavaskar defended Delhi Capitals batter David Miller for his refusal to take a single in the IPL thriller against Gujarat Titans that cost his side the match, saying the South African's intent cannot be faulted.

Needing two off two to reach 211, Miller refused a single off Prasidh Krishna on the penultimate ball. He missed the final delivery but ran for a single. However, Kuldeep Yadav, from the other end, was unable to beat Jos Buttler's direct throw after the two batters had crossed over.

"David Miller was backing himself, he had been striking



the ball well and believed he could finish it. You can't fault that intent. In the end, it also came down to execution, Prasidh Krishna bowled a superb slower bouncer at the right height, which made it difficult. These are very fine margins in pressure sit-

uations," Gavaskar told 'JioHotstar'.

The cricketer-turned-commentator added that game awareness is crucial in high-pressure moments, something that former India head coach Ravi Shastri highlighted during the tied Test

against Australia in 1986.

During that match in Chennai, with India chasing 348, Shastri showed great composure with an unbeaten 48 and crucially took a single at the right moment as India tied the game at 347 before final batter Maninder Singh was dismissed for a duck.

"This is where game awareness becomes crucial. It reminds me of what Ravi Shastri did in that tied Test against Australia in 1986, taking a single at the right moment to level the scores.

"In this case (GT vs DC), in hindsight, a single might have been the better option (for Miller), especially after Kuldeep Yadav managed one earlier," added Gavaskar.

Former England cricketer Kevin Pietersen said Rashid

Khan played a pivotal role in the nerve-wracking win for GT, with the Afghanistan all-rounder picking up three wickets while conceding just 17 runs in his four overs. This was GT's first win of the season. However, he was critical of the rest of the Gujarat Titans bowling attack.

"Rashid Khan was outstanding. It's always good to see him back close to his best because by his own standards, he would expect more from himself.

"Having said that, I don't think Gujarat Titans' bowling as a whole was at its best, and they didn't close the game out particularly well. But that's the nature of the game, you'll have more tough days than good ones," added Pietersen.

When Miller didn't take a single, I thought we had a chance: Gill

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

When David Miller refused a single off Prasidh Krishna's second last delivery of the 20th over which would have tied Delhi Capitals score with Gujarat Titans, Shubman Gill felt that now they could win which had seemed improbable at that point.

With Prasidh's slower being missed by Miller and Jos Buttler's throw beating a diving Kuldeep Yadav, Gujarat Titans recorded their first win of the season beating Delhi Capitals by one run here on Wednesday.

"Definitely, all three games we played had gone



till the last over but very pleased to get over the line. (When Miller didn't take a single), I thought, we had a chance to win," Gill said after the match.

On the choice of final delivery, Gill reckoned that a bowler with the ability to bowl slower delivery was a perfect choice looking at the track.

Rashid unlikely to feature in one-off Test against India

BHARAT SHARMA ■ New Delhi

Advised by doctors to stay away from red-ball cricket following a back surgery, star Afghanistan all-rounder Rashid Khan has hinted that he might skip the one-off Test against India in Mullanpur in June.

While the prospect of playing a Test in India is enticing, Rashid maintained his priority remains staying fit for the 2027 ODI World Cup in South Africa.

The 27-year-old, who underwent lower-back surgery following the 2023 ODI World Cup, revealed that doctors have cautioned him against the traditional format. Despite that, he featured in a Test against Zimbabwe last



year, bowling 54 overs and picking up 11 wickets.

"Very tough question. It's a little difficult in red ball, because that was the first thing which was told to me by the doctor, 'You have to stay away from red ball.' But I still played a Test against Zimbabwe," Rashid told reporters after starring in Gujarat Titan's one-run win over Delhi Capitals in the IPL on Thursday. (PTI)

Shubman Gill fined for slow over-rate

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

Gujarat Titans skipper Shubman Gill has been fined ₹12 lakh for maintaining a slow over-rate during their Indian Premier League clash against Delhi Capitals, which they won in a thrilling last-ball finish here.

Gujarat Titans secured their first win of the season with a one-run victory over the hosts in a high-scoring cliffhanger on Wednesday.

"Gujarat Titans (GT) Captain Shubman Gill has been fined after his team maintained a slow over-rate during Match No. 14 of the TATA Indian Premier League (IPL) 2026 against Delhi Capitals (DC) at Arun Jaitley Stadium, Delhi," said an IPL media advisory.



"As this was his team's first offence of the season under Article 2.22 of the IPL's Code of Conduct, which pertains to minimum over-rate offences, Gill was fined INR 12 lakh," it added.

In a nail-biting contest, David Miller had a momentary lapse in judgment, refusing a single off the penultimate delivery from Prasidh Krishna before missing the final ball.

Kuldeep Yadav then failed to get past Jos Buttler's direct hit, as Delhi Capitals finished at 209 for 8 in their chase of Titans' 210.

Gujarat Titans will next take on Lucknow Super Giants in Lucknow on Sunday, while Delhi Capitals are set to face Chennai Super Kings in Chennai on Saturday.



Ayush enters quarterfinals; Sindhu, Prannoy lose

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Ningbo (China)

Young Indian shuttler Ayush Shetty entered the men's singles quarterfinals of the Asia Championships with an impressive straight-game win but the seasoned PV Sindhu was eliminated from the women's event here on Thursday.

World number 25 Ayush, who is also the reigning US Open Super 300 champion, registered a 21-16, 21-12 victory over his world number 20 rival, Chinese Taipei's Chi Yu Jen, in a commanding display. He will next face third seed Jonatan Christie of Indonesia.

However, it was a disappointing day for the rest of the Indian contingent.

Two-time Olympic medalist Sindhu went down 18-21, 8-21 to second seed Wang Zhiyi of China in a 46-minute last-16 stage match.

HS Prannoy, returning after a shoulder injury, fought hard but lost 12-21, 19-21 to China's Weng Hong Yang.

In mixed doubles, Dhruv Kapila and Tanisha Crasto bowed out after a 13-21, 14-21

defeat to fourth-seeded Malaysians Chen Tang Jie and Toh Ee Wei.

Unnati Hooda, along with the women's doubles pair of Priya Konjengbam and Shruti Mishra, will be in action later in the day.

Ayush relied on his height to unleash steep smashes and maintained tight control at the net to dominate proceedings.

The opening game was closely fought early on, with the scores level at 4-4 before Chi moved ahead 10-6.

Ayush clawed his way back after the break, drawing level at 12-12 and then taking control as Chi struggled with his length, committing a series of unforced errors.

The Indian surged to 18-14 and closed out the game comfortably.

In the second game, Ayush raced to a 4-0 lead before Chi briefly caught up.

Regaining rhythm, the Indian led 11-7 at the interval and never looked back, using aggressive returns and sharp net play to move to 16-9.

He soon wrapped up the match, sealing it with a sharp backhand at the net.

IPL: RR, RCB set for top-order shootout in Guwahati

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Guwahati

Riding on explosive starts from Yashasvi Jaiswal and Vaibhav Sooryavanshi, Rajasthan Royals will look to extend their dominance, while defending champions Royal Challengers Bengaluru will bank on a rejuvenated Devdutt Padikkal as the two in-form sides lock horns in an IPL clash here on Friday.

RCB have a settled top-order under the watch of the talismanic Virat Kohli, who hasn't shown any signs of rust despite stepping away from T20 internationals in 2024, while Phil Salt also unleashed his explosive abilities in the previous game.

Batting one down, Padikkal has carried his domestic form



seamlessly into the IPL, signalling a return to his fluent best with an aggressive yet controlled approach.

Padikkal had made an immediate impact in his debut IPL season, scoring 473 runs for RCB and establishing himself as a stylish batter. However, subsequent stints with Rajasthan Royals and Lucknow Super Giants didn't quite yield the desired returns.

His return to Bengaluru last season, by his own admission, proved to be a turning point, as he played a key role in the franchise finally clinching their maiden title.

The left-hander has begun this season in similar vein, striking back-to-back fifties—a 29-ball 50 against Chennai Super Kings and a 26-ball 61 against Sunrisers Hyderabad

—and will look to extend his rich vein of form.

The likes of skipper Rajat Patidar and big-hitting Australian Tim David provide solidity in the middle.

However, it is RCB's bowling transformation that has stood out. Once considered their Achilles heel, the attack now looks far more rounded. Jacob Duffy has stepped up in the absence of Josh Hazlewood, delivering incisive spells, while Krunal Pandya and Suyash Sharma have effectively choked runs in the middle overs.

The Royals, meanwhile, have emerged as one of the most explosive batting units this season, powered by the opening pair of Jaiswal and teenage sensation Sooryavanshi.

I see Impact Sub rule as great opportunity for young players: Prabhsimran Singh

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

Punjab Kings power-hitter Prabhsimran Singh fully backs the 'Impact Sub' rule, praising it for giving young players a valuable lifeline and a golden opportunity to shine in the IPL.

The youngster also revealed that he consciously tries to model his wicket-keeping style after Mahendra Singh Dhoni. The 'Impact Sub' rule has faced criticism from

several cricket experts for disproportionately favouring batters, undermining the role of all-rounders, and contributing to inflated scores. But Prabhsimran sees things differently. "As a youngster, I see the Impact Sub rule as a great opportunity for young players, and I have said this several times. Many don't like it because, obviously, a team can take more high-risk decisions when a player — be it a batter or bowler — is added to

the side," said Prabhsimran in a media interaction.

"But for young players, it's invaluable. When I joined the (PBKS) franchise, I spent eight years with them, and for four of those years, I didn't get many chances to play. Sitting on the sidelines, I always hoped for a shot, and now, because of the Impact Sub rule, I feel the opportunities for youngsters have increased significantly," the young top-order batter, who



scored 500-plus runs last IPL season, added.

With India blessed with a wealth of top-order wicket-keeper-batters, including KL Rahul, Sanju Samson, Rishabh Pant and Ishan Kishan, one might wonder if Prabhsimran tries to emulate them or stick to his own style, and the cricketer clarifies that he consciously makes an effort only to model his game after former India skipper Dhoni.

"You cannot say I try to

copy anyone... they are all my seniors, and each has their own style of play, while I have mine. Now that I am keeping as well, I have watched Mahi bhai's keeping — his hands are so fast.

"I don't try to copy anyone in batting, but when it comes to keeping, I consciously make an effort to be like Mahi bhai." Prabhsimran, who has been with the Punjab franchise for eight years, has in the past couple of seasons

established himself as their go-to opener for a blazing start and says the powerplay is now the phase where teams unleash their attacking intent to drive toward a 200-plus score, a feat that is increasingly becoming the norm. "The game has become so fast that earlier, scores of 170-180 were defendable, and even today that can happen, but when you look at the numbers, 200-plus scores are increasingly becoming the norm.